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Smash Mains 2026

Revised & Updated for
UPSC MAINS 2026
Microthemes
GS Mains 2013-2025

Last 13 Yrs of PYQ Analysis | Updated with Questions of UPSC CSE Mains 2025

Microthemes

310

Subject

17



Scan QR to Get
all X-Factor Notes
& PYQs Microthemes
for 2026

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Table of Contents

GS-1

Art and Culture [12 Microthemes 33 Qs]	6
Modern History [8 Microthemes 30 Qs]	8
Post Independence [7 Microthemes 11 Qs]	10
World History [5 Microthemes 17 Qs]	11
Society [19 Microthemes 84 Qs]	12
Geography [21 Microthemes 96 Qs]	17

GS-2

Polity [31 Microthemes 102 Qs]	26
Governance [14 Microthemes 69 Qs]	35
Social Justice [9 Microthemes 37 Qs]	41
International Relations [11 Microthemes 58 Qs]	44

GS-3

Economic Development [34 Microthemes 78 Qs]	52
Agriculture [24 Microthemes 47 Qs]	58
Science & Technology [18 Microthemes 42 Qs]	62
Environment [13 Microthemes 32 Qs]	66
Disaster Management [9 Microthemes 16 Qs]	68
Internal Security [14 Microthemes 53 Qs]	69

GS-4

Ethics [59 Microthemes 166 Qs]	76
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Art forms • Bhakti and Sufi movement • Buddhism • Civilizations and their Highlights • Indian Philosophy • Kingdoms and their Highlights • Miscellaneous • Sources of Indian History • Colonial rule and impact • Gandhi X Indian Leaders of Freedom Struggle • Revolt and Mutiny • Socio-religious reform • Viceroy and their Administration • Acts and their Features • Important contributors/ contribution • Various stages of Freedom struggle • Foreign influence on Independent India's policies • Land reform • Personalities Contribution • Slogan based • States Reorganization • Wars after Independence • American and French revolution • Anti-colonial struggles • Great Economic Depression • Industrial Revolution • Miscellaneous • World wars • Diversity and pluralism • Family • Uniqueness of Indian society • Population and associated issues • Poverty and Developmental issues • Women and Associated concerns • Environmental Problems • Government Programme • Emerging urban issues • Miscellaneous • Globalisation • Caste system • Communalism • Miscellaneous • Regionalism • Secularism • Social empowerment • Climatology • Cryosphere and Himalayan Ecosystem • Geomorphology • Monsoon • Oceanography • Energy • Natural resources Potential • Water Management • Primary sector • Secondary sector • Tertiary sector • Cyclone • Desertification • Landslides • Volcanic activity • Cloudbursts • Twisters • Flora & Fauna and related changes • Geographical features and their location • Miscellaneous • Amendments • Case Laws • DPSP • Fundamental Rights • Making of the Constitution • Center-State Relations • Emergency • Nature of Indian Federalism • Special Provisions • Executive Vs Judiciary • Executive Vs Legislature • Judiciary Vs Legislature • Separation of Powers • Local Self Government • Constitutional Comparison • Bicameralism • Parliamentary Committees • Parliamentary Privileges • Presiding Officers • Role of MPs • Informal associations and their role in polity • Alternate Dispute Resolution • Judiciary • Pressure Groups • Union Executive • ECI • Elections • Political Parties • RP Act • Government Schemes and Policies • Structural reforms and Actions • Civil Society • Donor Agencies • SHGs • Citizens Charter • E-governance • Transparency and Accountability • Civil Services • Constitutional Bodies • Enforcement Agencies • Quasi judicial Bodies • Sectoral Regulatory Bodies • Statutory Bodies • Children • Disabled • Welfare and Development Schemes • Women • Education • Health • Human Resources • Miscellaneous • Hunger • Miscellaneous • Poverty • Neighbourhood • Bilateral Relations • Groupings involving Immediate and Extended neighbours • Groupings beyond South Asia • Geo-politics affecting India's Interest • Indian Diaspora • Miscellaneous • Miscellaneous • International Funding Agencies • United Nations • WTO • Jobless growth • Capital formation in Economy • Care X Monetized Economy • Demographic Dividend • Digitalization of Economy

Microthemes

• GDP • GDP X Saving Rate • Labour Activity X Economic Growth • Miscellaneous • Monetary policy • MSME X Economic Growth • Niti Aayog X Planning Commission • Taxes • Trends of Macro economy • Unemployment • Urban Development • Corporate Social Responsibility • Financial Inclusion • Inclusive Growth • Inclusive

Growth X Capitalism • Inclusive Growth X Infrastructure • Inclusive Growth X Public Expenditure • Inclusive Growth X Sustainable Development • Current Budget • Gender Budgeting • Static Budget • Static X Current Budget • Food Processing Sector • Revolutions and Missions • BoP and External value of rupee X Gold Monetization Scheme • FDI • Globalisation X Formal & Informal Economy • Industrial Reform • Labour Reform • Labour-intensive X Capital-intensive Export • Post-reform period X Industrial Growth • Post-reform period X Service-Led Transition • Protectionism and Currency Manipulations • Special Economic Zones • Airports X Infrastructure • Energy X SDGs • Green Energy X Infrastructure • Hydroelectricity • PPP X Infrastructure • Renewable Energy • Transport • Crop Diversification • Cropping pattern • Horticulture • Integrated Farming System • Millets • Organic Farming • Irrigation system and Challenges • Micro-Irrigation • Water storage and Conservation • Agri-marketing • Tech in Agri Production and Marketing • Tech in Agriculture Credit • Tech in Farm Productivity and Income • Agri finance & Subsidies • Agriculture Vulnerability & Crop Insurance • Buffer stock & food security • Miscellaneous • MSP • PDS • Revolutions and Missions • Non-Farm Activities (Livestock) • Act based • Contract farming & Land leasing • Land Reforms • Miscellaneous • Innovative Technologies • Material Science and Industry Applications • Medical and Health Technologies • Miscellaneous • Nobel Prizes • Sports and Technology • Tech in crisis Management • Tech solutions for daily challenges • Achievements of Indians in S&T • Indigenisation of technology • Artificial Intelligence • Bio-Technology • Defence Technology • Intellectual Property Rights • IT • Nano Technology • Robotics • Space Technology • Biodiversity • Climate Change Impact • Ecosystem carrying capacity and SDG • EIA • Environmental Pollution and Mitigation • EVs • IPCC Reports • Mining and Erosion • River linking and Impact • UNFCCC • Wetlands • Cloudburst • Disaster Preparedness • Disaster Risk Reduction • Drought • Earthquake • Government Disaster Initiatives • Landslide • Structural failure causing Disaster • Tsunami • Urban floods • Vulnerability and Risk Assessment • Left-Wing Extremism • N-E Insurgency • Threat from External state and Non-state actors • Threat from Non-state Actors • Threat from State Actors • Act based • Cyber security • Drug trafficking and its Linkages • Mob Violence • Money-laundering and Prevention • Role of Media and Social Networking sites in Internal Security Threats • Border Area Management • Maritime Security challenges • Organized Crime and Terrorism • Act based • Security Forces and Their Mandates • Applied Ethics • Consequences of Ethics • Normative Ethics (Deontology vs Teleology) • Determinants of Ethics • Dimensions of Ethics • Essence of Ethics • Ethics in Private and Public sphere • Term Based • Innovative Measures to Curb Sexual Violence • Role of Educational institutions • Teachings of Great Leaders • Value Based Questions • Attitude for Civil Servants • Attitude for Individuals • Moral and Political Attitude • Organisational Attitude • Social influence and persuasion • EI in Administration • EI X Crisis of Conscience • EI: Concept and utility • EQ vs IQ • A.P.J. Abdul Kalam • Abraham Lincoln • Aristotle • Dalai Lama • Erik Erikson • Immanuel Kant • Jawaharlal Nehru • John Rawls's concept of social Justice • Kautilya • Mahatma Gandhi • Plato • Potter Stewart • Sardar Patel • Socrates • Swami Vivekananda • Tirukkural • Empathy and compassion • Foundational values • Impartiality and Non-Partisanship • Integrity • Integrity X Intelligence X Energy • Trustworthiness and Fortitude • Accountability and Ethical Governance • Public/Civil Service Values • Corporate Governance • Conflict of interest • Ethical dilemmas in Public Administration • Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding • Laws, Rules, Regulations and Conscience as Ethical Guidance • Challenges of Corruption • Citizen's Charter • Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct • Information Sharing and Transparency in Government X RTI • Probity in Governance • Utilization of public funds • Quality of Service Delivery

GS-I

01. Indian Culture-Salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times.
02. Modern Indian History-Mid-18th century - Present (significant events, personalities, issues);
03. Freedom Struggle-various stages, important contributors/contributions from different parts of the country
04. Post-Independence-consolidation and reorganisation within country
05. History of the world will include events from 18th century such as industrial revolution, world wars, redrawal of national boundaries, colonization, decolonization, political philosophies like communism, capitalism, socialism etc.— their forms and effect on the society.
06. Salient features of Indian Society; Diversity of India;
07. Role of women and women's organization, population and associated issues, poverty and developmental issues.
08. Urbanisation: problems and remedies
09. Globalisation and its effects on Indian society
10. Social empowerment, communalism, regionalism & secularism.
11. Salient Features of World Physical Geography
12. Distribution of key Natural Resources (world, South Asia and Indian subcontinent)
13. Factors responsible for the location of primary, secondary, and tertiary sector industries in various parts of the world (including India).
14. Important Geophysical phenomena such as earthquakes, Tsunami, Volcanic activity, cyclone etc.,
15. Geographical features and their location-changes in critical geographical features (including water-bodies and ice-caps) and in flora and fauna and the effects of such changes.





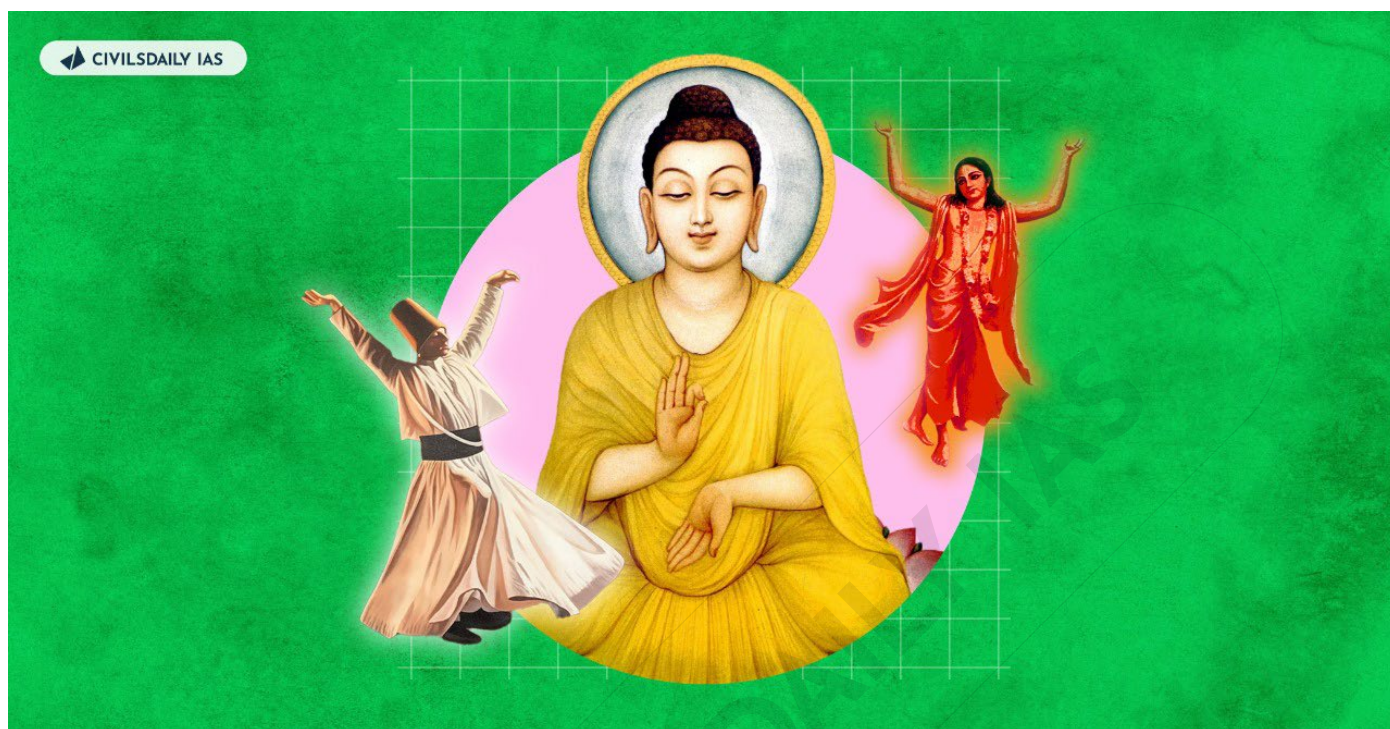
GS 1 Year-wise PYQ Analysis

Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
01. Indian Culture-Salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times.	3	4	2	2	1	3	1	4	1	3	3	3	3	33
02. Modern Indian History-Mid-18th century - Present (significant events, personalities, issues);	1	3	2	2	3	1	1	1	1	2	2		1	20
03. Freedom Struggle-various stages, important contributors/contributions from different parts of the country	2		1	1	2		3	1	2			1		13
04. Post-Independence-consolidation and reorganisation within country	5	1		1		1			1	1			1	11
05. History of the world will include events from 18th century such as industrial revolution, world wars, redrawing of national boundaries, colonization, decolonization, political philosophies like communism, capitalism, socialism etc.— their forms and effect on the society.	4	2	2	1	1	1	1		1		1	2	1	17
06. Salient features of Indian Society; Diversity of India;		1	1		2		2		2	1	2	3	1	15
07. Role of women and women's organization, population and associated issues, poverty and developmental issues.	1	3	3	1		2	2	2	3		2	3	1	23
08. Urbanisation: problems and remedies	2		1	2	1	1	1	1	2	2	1	1	1	16
09. Globalisation and its effects on Indian society	1		1	1		1	1	1		1		1	2	10
10. Social empowerment, communalism, regionalism & secularism.	1	1	1	2	2	3	1	3		2	2	1	1	20
11. Salient Features of World Physical Geography	2	2	2	1	3	3	2	2	2	3	2	1	1	26
12. Distribution of key Natural Resources (world, South Asia and Indian subcontinent)	2	2	2	3	1	1	1	3	1	3	2	1	3	25
13. Factors responsible for the location of primary, secondary, and tertiary sector industries in various parts of the world (including India).	2	3	1	1	3	2	2		1		1		2	18
14. Important Geophysical phenomena such as earthquakes, Tsunami, Volcanic activity, cyclone etc.,	2	1		1				1	2	1		3	1	12
15. Geographical features and their location-changes in critical geographical features (including water-bodies and ice-caps) and in flora and fauna and the effects of such changes.	2	2	1	1	1	1	2	1	1	1	2		1	16
Grand Total	30	25	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	275



Art and Culture

01. Indian Culture- Salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Ancient History x Education, Science, Medicine	Taxila university was one of the oldest universities of the world with which were associated a number of renowned learned personalities of different disciplines. Its strategic location caused its fame to flourish, but unlike Nalanda, it is not considered as a university in the modern sense. Discuss.	2014	10
Architecture x Caves, Rock-cut	The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss.	2020	10
	Mesolithic rock cut architecture of India not only reflects the cultural life of the times but also a fine aesthetic sense comparable to modern painting. Critically evaluate this comment.	2015	12.5
Art forms x Dance	Discuss the Tandava dance as recorded in the early Indian inscriptions.	2013	10
Bhakti and Sufi Movements	Evaluate the nature of the Bhakti literature and its contribution to Indian culture.	2021	10
	The Bhakti movement received a remarkable re-orientation with the advent of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Discuss.	2018	15
	Sufis and medieval mystic saints failed to modify either the religious ideas and practices or the outward structure of Hindu/Muslim societies to any appreciable extent. Comment.	2014	10
Buddhism and Jainism	Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art.	2019	10
	Early Buddhist Stupa-art, while depicting folk motifs and narratives successfully expounds Buddhist ideals. Elucidate.	2016	12.5
	Gandhara sculpture owed as much to the Romans as to the Greeks. Explain.	2014	10
Conservation of Indian Art & Heritage	Safeguarding the Indian art heritage is the need of the moment. Discuss.	2018	10
Foreign Travellers	Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India.	2018	10
Historical Sources	Though not very useful from the point of view of a connected political history of South India, the Sangam literature portrays the social and economic conditions of its time with remarkable vividness. Comment.	2013	10



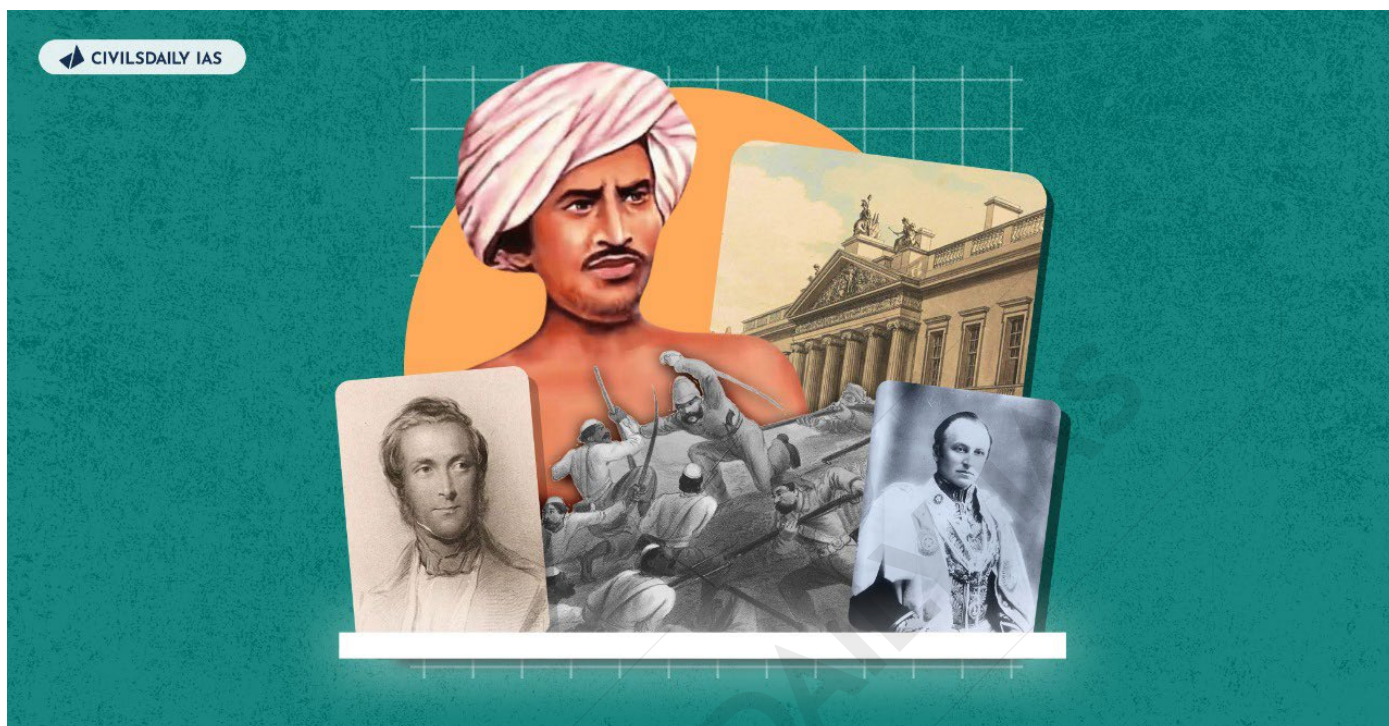


Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Indus Valley Civilization	Discuss the salient features of the Harappan architecture.	2025	10
	The ancient civilization in Indian sub-continent differed from those of Egypt, Mesopotamia and Greece in that its culture and traditions have been preserved without a breakdown to the present day. Comment.	2015	12.5
	To what extent has the urban planning and culture of the Indus Valley Civilization provided inputs to the present day urbanization? Discuss.	2014	10
Kingdoms	'The sculptors filled the Chandella artform with resilient vigor and breadth of life.' Elucidate.	2025	10
	Estimate the contribution of Pallavas of Kanchi for the development of art and literature of South India.	2024	10
	Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate.	2020	10
	How do you justify the view that the level of excellence of Gupta numismatic art is not at all noticeable in later times?	2017	10
Kingdoms x Chola	"Though the great Cholas are no more yet their name is still remembered with great pride because of their highest achievements in the domain of art and architecture." Comment.	2024	15
	Chola architecture represents a high watermark in the evolution of temple architecture. Discuss.	2013	10
Kingdoms x Kings	Examine the main aspects of Akbar's religious syncretism.	2025	10
	Krishnadeva Raya, the King of Vijayanagar, was not only an accomplished scholar himself but was also a great patron of learning and literature. Discuss.	2016	12.5
Kingdom x Chola x Gupta	Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture.	2022	15
Kingdom x Sultanate	What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society?	2023	15
Miscellaneous	Explain the role of geographical factors towards the development of Ancient India.	2023	10
Philosophical Schools	Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss.	2020	15
Sculptures	How will you explain that medieval Indian temple sculptures represent the social life of those days?	2022	10
	Discuss the significance of the lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture.	2022	15
Sources x Literature	Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.	2020	15
Vedic Culture	Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period.	2024	10
	What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society?	2023	15



Modern History

02. Modern Indian History- Mid-18th century - Present (significant events, personalities, issues);



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
1857 Revolt, other wars	The 1857 Uprising was the culmination the recurrent big and small local rebellions that had occurred in the preceding hundred years of British rule. Elucidate.	2019	10
	Clarify how mid-eighteenth century India was beset with the spectre of a fragmented polity.	2017	10
	Explain how the Uprising of 1857 constitutes an important watershed in the evolution of British policies towards colonial India.	2016	12.5
	⑧ In what ways did the naval mutiny prove to be the last nail in the coffin of British colonial aspirations in India?	2014	10
	The third battle of Panipat was fought in 1761. Why were so many empire-shaking battles fought at Panipat?	2014	10
British Policies x Armies	Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising of Indian soldiers-win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers ? Give reasons.	2022	10
British Policies x Economic	Examine how the decline of traditional artisanal industry in colonial India crippled the rural economy.	2017	15
	Examine critically the various facets of economic policies of the British in India from mid-eighteenth century till independence.	2014	10
British Policies x Famine	Why was there a sudden spurt in famines in colonial India since the mid-eighteenth century ? Give reasons.	2022	10
British Policies x Tribal	How did the colonial rule affect the tribals in India and what was the tribal response to the colonial oppression?	2023	15
Governor Generals	Evaluate the policies of Lord Curzon and their long term implications on the national movement.	2020	10
	In many ways, Lord Dalhousie was the founder of modern India. Elaborate.	2013	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Gandhi x Indian Leaders of Freedom Struggle	What was the difference between Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore in their approach towards education and nationalism?	2023	10
	Throw light on the significance of the thoughts of Mahatma Gandhi in the present times.	2018	10
	Highlight the differences in the approach of Subhash Chandra Bose and Mahatma Gandhi in the struggle for freedom.	2016	12.5
	Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, despite having divergent approaches and strategies, had a common goal of amelioration of the downtrodden. Elucidate.	2015	12.5
	How different would have been the achievement of Indian independence without Mahatma Gandhi? Discuss.	2015	12.5
Movement x Social Reform	Mahatma Jotirao Phule's writings and efforts of social reforms touched issues of almost all subaltern classes. Discuss.	2025	15
	Trace the rise and growth of socio-religious reform movements with special reference to Young Bengal and Brahmo Samaj.	2021	10
	The women's questions arose in modern India as a part of the 19th century social reform movement. What were the major issues and debates concerning women in that period?	2017	15

Modern History

03. Freedom Struggle-various stages, important contributors/ contributions from different parts of the country

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Contribution x Foreigners	Several foreigners made India their homeland and participated in various movements. <u>Analyze</u> their role in the Indian struggle for freedom.	2013	10
Contribution x Moderates	To what extent did the role of the Moderates prepare a base for the wider freedom movement? Comment. ?	2021	15
	Why did the 'Moderates' fail to carry conviction with the nation about their proclaimed ideology and political goals by the end of the nineteenth century?	2017	10
Contribution x Women	Discuss the role of women in the freedom struggle <u>especially</u> during the <u>Gandhian phase</u> .	2016	12.5
	Defying the barriers of age, gender and religion, the Indian women became the torch bearer during the struggle for freedom in India. Discuss.	2013	10
Council Acts, Commissions	It would have been difficult for the Constituent Assembly to complete its historic task of drafting the Constitution for Independent India in just three years but for the experience gained with the Government of India Act, 1935. Discuss.	2015	12.5
Freedom Struggle Stages	① ✓ What were the events that led to the Quit India Movement? Point out its results.	2024	10
	② ✓ Bring out the constructive programmes of Mahatma Gandhi during Non-Cooperation Movement and Civil Disobedience Movement.	2021	15
	③ ✓ Since the decade of the 1920s, the national movement acquired various ideological strands and thereby expanded its social base. Discuss. *** Tough.	2020	15
	⑦ ✓ Assess the role of British imperial power in complicating the process of transfer of power during the 1940s.	2019	15
	Many voices had strengthened and enriched the nationalist movement during the Gandhian phase. Elaborate.	2019	15
	Examine the linkages between 19th centuries 'Indian Renaissance' and the emergence of national identity.	2019	10
	Highlight the importance of the new objectives that got added to the vision of Indian independence since twenties of the last century.	2017	15



Post Independence

04. Post-Independence- Consolidation and reorganisation within country

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Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Consolidation after Independence	Trace India's consolidation process during early phase of independence in terms of polity, economy, education and international relations.	2025	15
	Assess the main administrative issues and socio-cultural problems in the integration process of Indian Princely States.	2021	10
Foreign influence on Independent India's Policies	The New Economic Policy - 1921 of Lenin had influenced the policies adopted by India soon after independence. Evaluate.	2014	10
Freedom Movement Personalities	Discuss the contribution of Maulana Abul Kalam Azad to pre-and post-independent India.	2013	10
Land Reforms	Critically discuss the objectives of Bhoodan and Gramdan movements initiated by Acharya Vinoba Bhave and their success.	2013	10
Slogan Based	Write a critical note on the evolution and significance of the slogan "Jai Jawana Jai Kisan".	2013	10
States Reorganization	The political and administrative reorganization of states and territories has been a continuous ongoing process since the mid-nineteenth century. Discuss with examples.	2022	15
	Discuss whether the formation of new states in recent times is beneficial or not for the economy of India.	2018	15
	Has the formation of linguistic States strengthened the cause of Indian Unity?	2016	12.5
Wars after Independence	Analyze the circumstances that led to Tashkent Agreement in 1966. Discuss the highlights of the agreement.	2013	10
	Critically examine the compulsions which prompted India to play a decisive roles in the emergence of Bangladesh.	2013	10



World History

05. History of the world will include events from 18th century such as industrial revolution, world wars, redrawing of national boundaries, colonization, decolonization, political philosophies like communism, capitalism, socialism etc.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
American and French Revolution	The French Revolution has enduring relevance to the contemporary world. Explain.	2025	15
	Explain how the foundations of the modern world were laid by the American and French revolution.	2019	15
	American Revolution was an economic revolt against mercantilism. Substantiate.	2013	10
Decolonisation	What problems were germane to the decolonization process of Malay Peninsula.	2017	10
	The anti-colonial struggles in West Africa were led by the new elite of Western-educated Africans. Examine.	2016	12.5
	What were the major political, economic and social developments in the world which motivated the anti-colonial struggle in India?	2014	10
	Africa was chopped into states artificially created by accident of European competition. Analyse.	2013	10
Indian Diaspora	Why indentured labour was taken by the British from India to other colonies? Have they been able to preserve their cultural identity over there?	2018	15
Industrial Revolution	How far was the Industrial Revolution in England responsible for the decline of handicrafts and cottage industries in India?	2024	15
	Why did the industrial revolution first occur in England? Discuss the quality of life of the people there during the industrialization. How does it compare with that in India at present?	2015	12.5
	Latecomer Industrial revolution in Japan involved certain factors that were markedly different from what west had experience.	2013	10
Miscellaneous	Bring out the socio-economic effects of the introduction of railways in different countries of the world.	2023	10
World History Events	What were the events that led to the Suez Crisis in 1956? How did it deal a final blow to Britain's self-image as a world power?	2014	10
	What policy instruments were deployed to contain the great economic depression?	2013	10
World Wars	How far is it correct to say that the First World War was fought essentially for the preservation of balance of power?	2024	15
	"There arose a serious challenge to the Democratic State System between the two World Wars." Evaluate the statement.	2021	15
	To what extent can Germany be held responsible for causing the two World Wars? Discuss critically	2015	12.5



Society

06. Salient features of Indian Society; Diversity of India;



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Diversity and pluralism	What is regional disparity? How does it differ from diversity? How serious is the issue of regional disparity in India?	2024	15
	Critically analyse the proposition that there is a high correlation between India's cultural diversities and socio-economic marginalities.	2024	15
	Analyse the salience of 'sect' in Indian society vis-a-vis caste, region and religion.	2022	15
	Do we have cultural pockets of small India all over the nation? Elaborate with examples.	2019	15
	In the context of diversity of India, can it be said that the regions form cultural units rather than the States? Give reasons with examples for your viewpoint.	2017	10
	Describe any four cultural elements of diversity in India and rate their relative significance in building a national identity.	2015	12.5
Family	Intercaste marriages between castes which have socio-economic parity have increased, to some extent, but this is less true of interreligious marriages. Discuss.	2024	10
	Do you think marriage as a sacrament in losing its value in Modern India?	2023	10
	Child cuddling is now being replaced by mobile phones. Discuss its impact on the socialization of children.	2023	10
	Explore and evaluate the impact of 'Work From Home' on family relationships.	2022	10
	The life cycle of a joint family depends on economic factors rather than social values. Discuss.	2014	10
Tribal Issues	Does tribal development in India centre around two axes, those of displacement and of rehabilitation? Give your opinion.	2025	15
	Given the diversities among tribal communities in India, in which specific contexts should they be considered as a single category ?	2022	10
	Examine the uniqueness of tribal knowledge system when compared with mainstream knowledge and cultural systems.	2021	10
	How do you explain the statistics that show that the sex ratio in Tribes in India is more favourable to women than the sex ratio among Scheduled Castes?	2015	12.5





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Uniqueness of Indian society	How does Indian society maintain continuity in traditional social values? Enumerate the changes taking place in it.	2021	15
	What makes Indian society unique in sustaining its culture? Discuss.	2019	10
	The spirit tolerance and love is not only an interesting feature of Indian society from very early times, but it is also playing an important part at the present. Elaborate.	2017	15

Society

07. Role of women and women's organization, population and associated issues, poverty and developmental issues.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Development and related issues	'Achieving sustainable growth with emphasis on environmental protection could come into conflict with poor people's needs in a country like India – Comment.	2025	15
	In dealing with socio-economic issues of development, what kind of collaboration between government, NGO's and private sector would be most productive?	2024	10
	What is Cryptocurrency? How does it affect global society? Has it been affecting Indian society also?	2021	15
	How have digital initiatives in India contributed to the functioning of the educational system in the country? Elaborate your answer.	2020	15
Population and associated issues	What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate.	2024	10
	Why did human development fail to keep pace with economic development in India?	2023	15
	Discuss the main objectives of Population Education and point out the measures to achieve them in India in detail.	2021	15
	Critically examine whether growing population is the cause of poverty OR poverty is the main cause of population increase in India.	2015	12.5
	Discuss the changes in the trends of labour migration within and outside India in the last four decades.	2015	12.5
Poverty	COVID-19 pandemic accelerated class inequalities and poverty in India. Comment.	2020	10
	Despite implementation of various programmes for eradication of poverty by the government in India, poverty is still existing.' Explain by giving reasons.	2018	10
	An essential condition to eradicate poverty is to liberate the poor from deprivation. Substantiate this statement with suitable examples	2016	12.5
Women	Distinguish between gender equality, gender equity and women's empowerment. Why is it important to take gender concerns into account in programme design and implementation?	2024	10
	Explain why suicide among young women is increasing in Indian Society.	2023	10
	Examine the role of 'Gig Economy' in the process of empowerment of women in India.	2021	10
	What are the continued challenges for women in India against time and space?	2019	15
	"Empowering women is the key to control population growth". Discuss	2019	10
	Women's movement in India has not addressed the issues of women of lower social strata. Substantiate your view.	2018	15
	Discuss the various economic and socio-cultural forces that are driving increasing feminization of agriculture in India.	2014	10
	How does patriarchy impact the position of a middle class working woman in India?	2014	10
	Why do some of the most prosperous regions of India have an adverse sex ratio for women? Give your arguments.	2014	10
	Male membership needs to be encouraged in order to make women's organization free from gender bias. Comment.	2013	10



Society

08. Urbanisation: problems and remedies

CIVILDAILY IAS



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Emerging Urbanisation Trends	How is the growth of Tier 2 cities related to the rise of a new middle class with an emphasis on the culture of consumption?	2022	10
	What are the main socio-economic implications arising out of the development of IT industries in major cities of India?	2021	15
	The growth of cities as I.T. hubs has opened up new avenues employment but has also created new problems. Substantiate this statement with examples.	2017	15
	Discussion the various social problems which originated out of the speedy process of urbanization in India.	2013	10
Poverty x Urban x Migration	How does smart city in India, address the issues of urban poverty and distributive justice?	2025	10
	Why do large cities tend to attract more migrants than smaller towns? Discuss in the light of conditions in developing countries.	2024	10
	Does urbanization lead to more segregation and/or marginalization of the poor in Indian metropolises?	2023	15
Urban Planning	How is efficient and affordable urban mass transport key to the rapid economic development of India? ?)	2019	15
	Mention core strategies for the transformation of aspirational districts in India and explain the nature of convergence, collaboration and competition for its success.	2018	15
	With a brief background of quality of urban life in India, introduce the objectives and strategy of the 'Smart City Programme'.	2016	12.5
	Smart cities in India cannot sustain without smart villages. Discuss this statement in the backdrop of rural urban integration.	2015	12.5
Urban Water Management	What are the environmental implications of the reclamation of water bodies into urban land use? Explain with examples. ?	2021	10
	Account for the huge flooding of million cities in India including the smart ones like Hyderabad and Pune. Suggest lasting remedial measures.	2020	15
	Major cities of India are becoming more vulnerable to flood conditions. Discuss.	2016	12.5





Society

09. Globalisation and its effects on Indian society

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Globalisation	How do you account for the growing fast food industries given that there are increased health concerns in modern society? Illustrate your answer with the Indian experience.	2025	15
	Do you think that globalization results in only an aggressive consumer culture?	2025	10
	Globalization has increased urban migration by skilled, young, unmarried women from various classes. How has this trend impacted upon their personal freedom and relationship with family?	2024	10
	Elucidate the relationship between globalization and new technology in a world of scarce resources, with special reference to India.	2022	15
	Is diversity and pluralism in India under threat due to globalisation? Justify your answer.	2020	15
	Are we losing our local identity for the global identity? Discuss.	2019	15
	Globalization is generally said to promote cultural homogenization but due to this cultural specificities appear to be strengthened in the Indian Society. Elucidate.	2018	15
	To what extent globalization has influenced the core of cultural diversity in India? Explain.	2016	12.5
	Discuss the positive and negative effects of globalization on women in India.	2015	12.5
	Critically examine the effects of globalization on the aged population in India.	2013	10

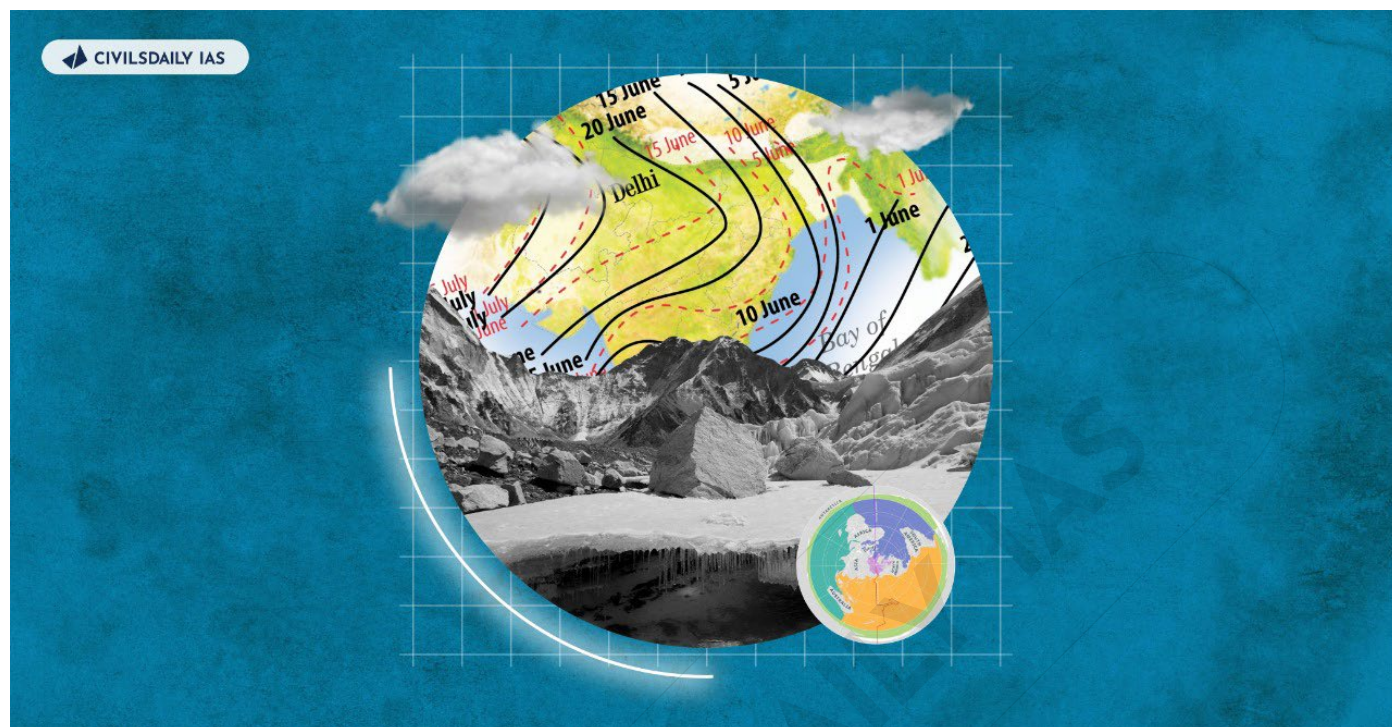
10. Social empowerment, communalism, regionalism & secularism.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Caste System	Why is caste identity in India both fluid and static?	2023	15
	Has caste lost its relevance in understanding the multi-cultural Indian Society? Elaborate your answer with illustrations.	2020	10
	Caste system is assuming new identities and associational forms. Hence, caste system cannot be eradicated in India. Comment.	2018	10
	Debate the issue of whether and how contemporary movements for assertion of Dalit identity work towards annihilation of caste.	2015	12.5
Communalism	Discuss the impact of post-liberal economy on ethnic identity and communalism.	2023	15
	Communalism arises either due to power struggle or relative deprivation. Argue by giving suitable illustrations.	2018	15
	Distinguish between religiousness/religiosity and communalism giving one example of how the former has got transformed into the latter in independent India.	2017	15
Miscellaneous	☐The ethos of civil service in India stand for the combination of professionalism with nationalistic consciousness – Elucidate.	2025	10
	Customs and traditions suppress reason leading to obscurantism. Do you agree?	2020	15
Regionalism	Do you agree that regionalism in India appears to be a consequence of rising cultural assertiveness? Argue.	2020	10
	What is the basis of regionalism? Is it that unequal distribution of benefits of development on regional basis eventually promotes regionalism? Substantiate your answer.	2016	12.5
	Growing feeling of regionalism is an important factor in the generation of demand for a separate state. Discuss.	2013	10
Secularism	Are tolerance, assimilation and pluralism the key elements in the making of an Indian form of secularism? Justify your answer.	2022	15
	What are the challenges to our cultural practices in the name of secularism.	2019	10
	How the Indian concept of secularism is different from the western model of secularism? Discuss.	2018	10
	How do the Indian debates on secularism differ from the debates in the West?	2014	10
Social empowerment	Despite comprehensive policies for equity and social justice, underprivileged sections are not yet getting the full benefits of affirmative action envisaged by the Constitution. Comment.	2024	15
	What are the two major legal initiatives by the State since Independence, addressing discrimination against Scheduled Tribes (STs)?	2017	10
	Why are the tribals in India referred to as the Scheduled Tribes? Indicate the major provisions enshrined in the Constitution of India for their upliftment.	2016	12.5



Geography

11. Salient Features of World Physical Geography



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Climatology x Atmosphere	Troposphere is a very significant atmospheric layer that determines weather processes. How?	2022	15
	Discuss the concept of air mass and explain its role in macro-climatic changes.	2016	12.5
Climatology x Monsoon, ENSO, IOD	Why is the South-West monsoon called 'Purvaia' (easterly) in Bhojpur Region? How has this directional seasonal wind system influenced the cultural ethos of the region?	2023	10
	What characteristics can be assigned to monsoon climate that succeeds in feeding more than 50 percent of the world population residing in Monsoon Asia?	2017	15
	How far do you agree that the behavior of the Indian monsoon has been changing due to humanizing landscapes? Discuss.	2015	12.5
	Most of the unusual climatic happenings are explained as an outcome of the El-Nino effect. Do you agree?	2014	10
Climatology x Temperature Inversion	What do you understand by the phenomenon of temperature inversion in meteorology? How does it affect the weather and the habitants of the place?	2013	5
Climatology x Wind and Pressure Systems	Major hot deserts in northern hemisphere are located between 20-30 degree north and on the western side of the continents. Why?	2013	10

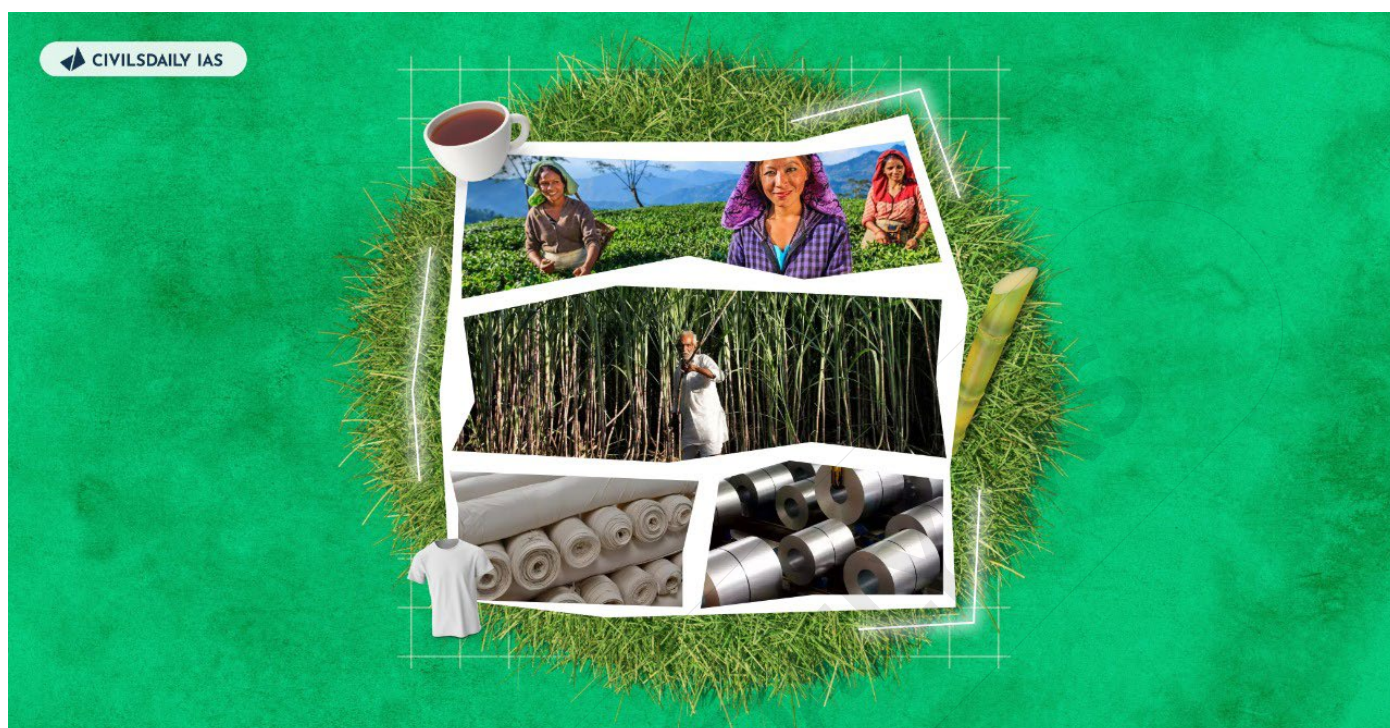


Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Geomorphology	Discuss how the changes in shape and sizes of continents and ocean basins of the planet take place due to tectonic movements of the crustal masses.	2025	15
	How are the fjords formed? Why do they constitute some of the most picturesque areas of the world?	2023	10
	Describe the characteristics and types of primary rocks.	2022	10
	Briefly mention the alignment of major mountain ranges of the world and explain their impact on local weather conditions, with examples.	2021	15
	Why is India considered as a subcontinent? Elaborate your answer. ?	2021	10
	Discuss the geophysical characteristics of Circum-Pacific Zone.	2020	10
	Define mantle plume and explain its role in plate tectonics.	2018	10
	Explain the formation of thousands of islands in Indonesian and Philippines archipelagos.	2014	10
	Why are the world's fold mountain systems located along the margins of continents? Bring out the association between the global distribution of Fold Mountains and the earthquakes and volcanoes.	2014	10
	What do you understand by the theory of continental drift? Discuss the prominent evidences in its support.	2013	5
	There is no formation of deltas by rivers of the Western Ghat. Why?	2013	5
Oceanography	What are the forces that influence ocean currents? Describe their role in fishing industry of the world.	2022	15
	How do ocean currents and water masses differ in their impacts on marine life and the coastal environment? Give suitable examples?	2019	15
	What are the consequences of spreading of 'Dead Zones' on marine ecosystem?	2018	10
	Account for variations in oceanic salinity and discuss its multi-dimensional effects.	2017	15
	Explain the factors responsible for the origin of ocean currents. How do they influence regional climates, fishing and navigation?	2015	12.5
	Critically evaluate the various resources of the oceans which can be harnessed to meet the resource crisis in the world.	2014	10



Geography

12. Distribution of key Natural Resources (world, South Asia and Indian subcontinent)



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Oil, Natural Resources	Discuss the distribution and density of population in the Ganga River Basin with special reference to land, soil and water resources.	2025	15
	Explain briefly the ecological and economic benefits of solar energy generation in India with suitable examples.	2025	10
	Give a geographical explanation of the distribution of off-shore oil reserves of the world. How are they different from the on-shore occurrences of oil reserves?	2025	15
	Comment on the resource potentials of the long coastline of India and highlight the status of natural hazard preparedness in these areas.	2023	15
	Discuss the natural resource potentials of 'Deccan Trap'.	2022	10
	Examine the potential of wind energy in India and explain the reasons for their limited spatial spread.	2022	10
	India has immense potential of solar energy though there are regional variations in its development. Elaborate.	2020	15
	Why is India taking keen interest in resources of Arctic Region?	2018	10
	How does India see its place in the economic space of rising natural resource rich Africa?	2014	10
	It is said the India has substantial reserves of shale oil and gas, which can feed the needs of country for quarter century. However, tapping of the resources doesn't appear to be high on the agenda. Discuss critically the availability and issues involved.	2013	10
World Geography: Minerals, Oil and other Natural Resources	With growing scarcity of fossil fuels, the atomic energy is gaining more and more significance in India. Discuss the availability of raw material required for the generation of atomic energy in India and in the world.	2013	10
	Discuss the multi-dimensional implications of uneven distribution of mineral oil in the world.	2021	15
	What are the economic significances of discovery of oil in Arctic Sea and its possible environmental consequences?	2015	12.5





Geography

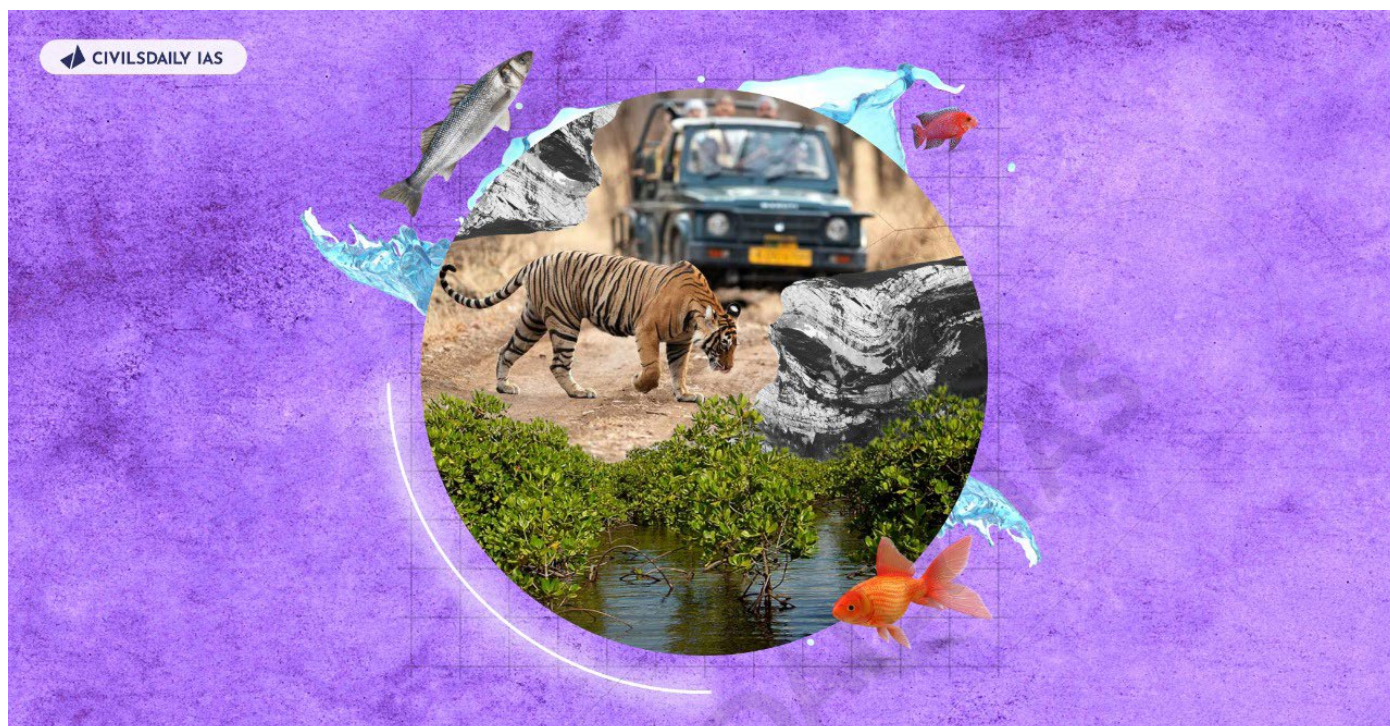
13. Factors responsible for the location of primary, secondary, and tertiary sector industries in various parts of the world (including India).

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Buffer Stock & Food Security	From being net food importer in 1960s, India has emerged as a net food exporter to the world. Provide reasons.	2023	15
Food Processing Sector	Discuss the factors for localization of agro-based food processing industries of North-West India.	2019	10
Land Use, Planning	How can Artificial Intelligence (AI) and drones be effectively used along with GIS and RS techniques in locational and areal planning?	2025	15
Millet, Pulses	Mention the advantages of the cultivation of pulse because of which the year 2016 was declared as the International Year of Pulses by the United Nations.	2017	10
Primary sector	What are non-farm primary activities? How are these activities related to physiographic features in India? Discuss with suitable examples.	2025	10
	Describing the distribution of rubber producing countries, indicate the major environmental issues faced by them.	2022	15
	Despite India being one of the countries of the Gondwanaland, its mining industry contributes much less to Gross Domestic Product (GDP) in percentage. Discuss.	2021	10
	Define blue revolution, explain the problems and strategies for pisciculture development in India.	2018	15
	In spite of adverse environmental impact, coal mining is still inevitable for development." Discuss.	2017	10
	Whereas the British planters had developed tea gardens all along the Shivaliks and Lesser Himalayas from Assam to Himachal Pradesh, in effect they did not succeed beyond the Darjeeling area. Explain.	2014	10
Revolutions and Missions	Why did the Green Revolution in India virtually by-pass the eastern region despite fertile soil and good availability of water?	2014	10
Secondary Sector	Account for the present location of iron and steel industries away from the source of raw material, by giving examples.	2020	15
	Can the strategy of regional-resource based manufacturing help in promoting employment in India?	2019	10
	What is the significance of Industrial Corridors in India? Identify industrial corridors, explain their main characteristics.	2018	15
	Petroleum refineries are not necessarily located nearer to crude oil producing areas, particularly in many of the developing countries. Explain its implications.	2017	15
	Account for the change in the spatial pattern of the Iron and Steel industry in the world.	2014	10
	Do you agree that there is a growing trend of opening new sugar mills in the Southern states of India? Discuss with justification	2013	5
	Analyze the factors for highly decentralized cotton textile industry in India	2013	5
Space Programs x IND	Why is Indian Regional Navigational Satellite System (IRNSS) needed? How does it help in navigation?	2018	10
Tertiary sector	Mention the significance of straits and isthmus in international trade.	2022	15
	How can the mountain ecosystem be restored from the negative impact of development initiatives and tourism?	2019	15
	Enumerate the problems and prospects of inland water transport in India.	2016	12.5
	The states of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand reaching the limits of their ecological carrying capacity due to tourism. Critically evaluate.	2015	12.5



Geography

14. Important Geophysical phenomena such as earthquakes, Tsunami, Volcanic activity, cyclone etc.,



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Aurora	What are aurora australis and aurora borealis? How are these triggered?	2024	15
Cloudbursts	What is the phenomenon of 'cloudbursts'? Explain.	2024	10
Cyclones	What is sea surface temperature rise? How does it affect the formation of tropical cyclones?	2024	10
	Discuss the meaning of colour-coded weather warnings for cyclone prone areas given by India Meteorological Department.	2022	10
	Tropical cyclones are largely confined to South China Sea, Bay of Bengal and Gulf of Mexico. Why?	2014	10
	The recent cyclone on the east coast of India was called "Phailin". How are the tropical cyclones named across the world?	2013	5
Landslides	Differentiate the causes of landslides in the Himalayan region and Western Ghats.	2021	10
	The Himalayas are highly prone to landslides. Discuss the causes and suggest suitable measures of mitigation.	2016	12.5
	Bring out the causes for more frequent landslides in the Himalayas than in Western Ghats	2013	5
Tsunami	What are Tsunamis? How and where are they formed? What are their consequences? Explain with examples.	2025	10
Twisters	What is a twister? Why are the majority of twisters observed in areas around the Gulf of Mexico?	2024	15
Volcanic Activity	Mention the global occurrence of volcanic eruptions in 2021 and their impact on regional environment. 2021	2021	10



Geography

15. Geographical features and their location- Changes in critical geographical features (including water-bodies and ice-caps) and in flora and fauna and the effects of such changes.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Climate Change	How are climate change and the sea level rise affecting the very existence of many island nations? Discuss with examples.	2025	10
	Discuss the consequences of climate change on the food security in tropical countries.	2023	10
	The process of desertification does not have climatic boundaries. Justify with examples.	2020	10
Cryosphere, Glacier Melting	How does the melting of the Arctic ice and glaciers of the Antarctic differently affect the weather patterns and human activities on the Earth? Explain. ?	2021	15
	How will the melting of Himalayan glaciers have a far-reaching impact on the water resources of India?	2020	10
	How does the cryosphere affect global climate?	2017	10
	Bring out the relationship between the shrinking Himalayan glaciers and the symptoms of climate change in the Indian sub-continent.	2014	10
Flora and Fauna	Identify and discuss the factors responsible for diversity of natural vegetation in India. Assess the significance of wildlife sanctuaries in rain forests regions of India.	2023	15
	Examine the status of forest resources of India and its resultant impact on climate change.	2020	15
	Assess the impact of global warming on coral life system with examples.	2019	15
	Discuss the causes of depletion of mangroves and explain their importance in maintaining coastal ecology.	2019	10
Political Geography	South China Sea has assumed great geopolitical significance in the present context. Comment.	2016	12.5
Space Programs x Intl	How does the Juno Mission of NASA help to understand the origin and evolution of the Earth?	2017	10
Urban Geography	Mumbai, Delhi and Kolkata are the three mega cities of the country but the air pollution is much more serious problem in Delhi as compared to the other two. Why is this so?	2015	12.5
	Bring out the causes for the formation of heat islands in the urban habitat of the world.	2013	5
Water Management	The groundwater potential of the gangetic valley is on a serious decline. How may it affect the food security of India?	2024	15
	Why is the world today confronted with a crisis of availability of and access to freshwater resources?	2023	10
	The interlinking of rivers can provide viable solutions to the multi-dimensional inter-related problems of droughts, floods and interrupted navigation. Critically examine.	2020	15
	What is water stress? How and why does it differ regionally in India? ? : ?)	2019	15
	The ideal solution of depleting ground water resources in India is water harvesting system. How can it be made effective in urban areas?	2018	15
	In what way can flood be converted into a sustainable source of irrigation and all-weather inland navigation in India?	2017	15
	In what way micro-watershed Development projects help in water conservation in drought prone and semi-arid regions of India.	2016	12.5
	Present an account of the Indus Water Treaty and examine its ecological, economic and political implications in the context of changing bilateral relations.	2016	12.5
	The effective management of land and water resources will drastically reduce the human miseries. Explain	2016	12.5
	India is well endowed with fresh water resources. Critically examine why it still suffers from water scarcity.	2015	12.5





GS-II

01. Indian Constitution-Historical underpinnings & evolution; Features, amendments, significant provisions, basic structure of Constitution
02. Functions & responsibilities of the Union and the States; issues and challenges of federal structure;
03. Separation of Powers between different organs, dispute redressal mechanisms and institutions
04. Devolution of powers and finances up to local levels and challenges therein
05. Comparison of Indian constitutional scheme with other countries'
06. Parliament and State Legislatures (structure, functioning, conduct of business, powers & privileges; issues therein)
07. Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary—Ministries and Departments of the Government; pressure groups and formal/informal associations and their role in the Polity
08. Salient features of the Representation of People's Act.
09. Appointment to various Constitutional posts; Constitutional Bodies (powers, functions and responsibilities); Statutory, Regulatory and Quasi-judicial bodies
10. Government Policies & Interventions for development of various sectors (issues in their design, implementation)
11. Development processes and the development industry —the role of NGOs, SHGs, various groups and associations, donors, charities, institutional and other stakeholders.
12. Welfare schemes for vulnerable sections of the population by the Centre and States and the performance of these schemes; mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections.
13. Issues relating to development and management of Social Sector/ Services relating to Health, Education, Human Resources.
14. Issues relating to poverty and hunger
15. Transparency and accountability (institutional and other measures); Citizens Charter, E-Governance (applications, models, successes, limitations, potential)
16. Role of Civil Services in a democracy.
17. India and its neighborhood- relations.
18. Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
19. Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.
20. Important International institutions, agencies and fora- their structure, mandate.





GS 2 Year-wise PYQ Analysis

Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
1. Indian Constitution-Historical underpinnings & evolution; Features, amendments, significant provisions, basic structure of Constitution	1	1	2	3	2		1		1	2	2	1	2	18
2. Functions & responsibilities of the Union and the States; issues and challenges of federal structure;	3	1	1	2		1	1	2			2	1	2	16
3. Separation of Powers between different organs, dispute redressal mechanisms and institutions	1		2		1	1	1	1	1	1	2	2		13
4. Devolution of powers and finances up to local levels and challenges therein			1		1	1	1	1		1	1	1		8
5. Comparison of Indian constitutional scheme with other countries'						1	1	1	1	1	1	1	2	9
6. Parliament and State Legislatures (structure, functioning, conduct of business, powers & privileges; issues therein)	1	1			2	1	1	2	2	1	2			13
7. Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary—Ministries and Departments of the Government; pressure groups and formal/informal associations and their role in the Polity	1	3	1		1		2		2			1	3	14
8. Salient features of the Representation of People's Act.				1	2	1	1	1		3		1	1	11
9. Appointment to various Constitutional posts; Constitutional Bodies (powers, functions and responsibilities); Statutory, Regulatory and Quasi-judicial bodies	3	2	1	2	1	5	1	1	3	1	1	1	1	23
10. Government Policies & Interventions for development of various sectors (issues in their design, implementation)	1	2		1		1	2			1			1	9
11. Development processes and the development industry —the role of NGOs, SHGs, various groups and associations, donors, charities, institutional and other stakeholders.	1	1	3	1	1			1	2	1	1	1	1	14



Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
12. Welfare schemes for vulnerable sections of the population by the Centre and States and the performance of these schemes; mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections.	1	1		1	1		1		1	1	1		1	9
13. Issues relating to development and management of Social Sector/Services relating to Health, Education, Human Resources.	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	2	2	1	2	1		18
14. Issues relating to poverty and hunger	1		1		2	1	1	1		1		1	1	10
15. Transparency and accountability (institutional and other measures); Citizens Charter, E-Governance (applications, models, successes, limitations, potential)	2		2	2		2	1	2	1	1	1	3	1	18
16. Role of Civil Services in a democracy.		1		1	1			1				1		5
17. India and its neighborhood- relations.	4		2							1				7
18. Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.	1	2	2	2	1	1	2	2	2	3	1	2	1	22
19. Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.	2				2	2	1	1	2		2	1	2	15
20. Important International institutions, agencies and fora- their structure, mandate.	1	3		2	1	1	1	1			1	1	1	13
Grand Total	25	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	265



Polity

01. Indian Constitution-Historical underpinnings & evolution; Features, amendments, significant provisions, basic structure of Constitution

CIVILSDAILY IAS



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Amendment	Indian Constitution has conferred the amending power on the ordinary legislative institutions with a few procedural hurdles. In view of this statement, examine the procedural and substantive limitations on the amending power of the Parliament to change the Constitution.	2025	15
	"Parliament's power to amend the Constitution is a limited power and it cannot be enlarged into absolute power." In the light of this statement explain whether Parliament under Article 368 of the Constitution can destroy the Basic Structure of the Constitution by expanding its amending power?	2019	15
	Explain the salient features of the constitution(One Hundred and First Amendment) Act, 2016. Do you think it is efficacious enough 'to remove cascading effect of taxes and provide for common national market for goods and services'?	2017	15
Case Laws	Explain the constitutional perspectives of Gender Justice with the help of relevant Constitutional Provisions and case laws.	2023	15
	The most significant achievement of modern law in India in the constitutionalization of environmental problems by the Supreme Court. Discuss this statement with the help of relevant case laws.	2022	10
	What was held in the Coelho case? In this context, can you say that judicial review is of key importance amongst the basic features of the Constitution?	2016	12.5
Constitutional Morality	"Constitutional morality is the fulcrum which acts as an essential check upon the high functionaries and citizens alike..." In view of the above observation of the Supreme Court, explain the concept of constitutional morality and its application to ensure balance between judicial independence and judicial accountability in India.	2025	15
	'Constitutional Morality' is rooted in the Constitution itself and is founded on its essential facets. Explain the doctrine of 'Constitutional Morality' with the help of relevant judicial decisions.	2021	10
Council Acts, Commissions	Did the Government of India Act, 1935 lay down a federal constitution? Discuss.	2016	12.5





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
DPSP	Discuss the possible factors that inhibit India from enacting for its citizens a uniform civil code as provided for in the Directive Principles of State Policy.	2015	12.5
Fundamental Rights and Duties	Right to privacy is intrinsic to life and personal liberty and is inherently protected under Article 21 of the Constitution. Explain. In this reference discuss the law relating to D.N.A. testing of a child in the womb to establish its paternity.	2024	15
	"The Constitution of India is a living instrument with capabilities of enormous dynamism. It is a constitution made for a progressive society". Illustrate with special reference to the expanding horizons of the right to life and personal liberty.	2023	15
	Right of movement and residence throughout the territory of India are freely available to the Indian citizens, but these rights are not absolute. Comment	2022	10
	Examine the scope of Fundamental Rights in the light of the latest judgement of the Supreme Court on Right to Privacy.	2017	15
	Does the right to clean environment entail legal regulations on burning crackers during Diwali? Discuss in the light of Article 21 of the Indian Constitution and Judgement(s) of the Apex Court in this regard.	2015	12.5
	What do you understand by the concept "freedom of speech and expression"? Does it cover hate speech also? Why do the films in India stand on a slightly different plane from other forms of expression? Discuss.	2014	12.5
	Discuss Section 66A of IT Act, with reference to its alleged violation of Article 19 of the Constitution.	2013	10
Preamble	Discuss each adjective attached to the word 'Republic' in the preamble. Are they defensible in the present circumstances?	2016	12.5



Polity

02. Functions & responsibilities of the Union and the States; issues and challenges of federal structure;

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Emergency	Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of using Article 356 by the Union Governments since mid 1990s.	2023	15
	Under what circumstances can the Financial Emergency be proclaimed by the President of India? What consequences follow when such a declaration remains in force?	2018	10
Federalism	Examine the evolving pattern of Centre-State financial relations in the context of planned development in India. How far have the recent reforms impacted the fiscal federalism in India?	2025	15
	What changes has the Union Government recently introduced in the domain of Centre-State relations? Suggest measures to be adopted to build the trust between the Centre and the States and for strengthening federalism.	2024	15
	Explain the significance of the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act. To what extent does it reflect the accommodative spirit of federalism?	2023	15
	How far do you think cooperation, competition and confrontation have shaped the nature of federation in India? Cite some recent examples to validate your answer.	2020	10
	Indian Constitution exhibits centralising tendencies to maintain unity and integrity of the nation. Elucidate in the perspective of the Epidemic Diseases Act, 1897; The Disaster Management Act, 2005 and recently passed Farm Acts.	2020	15
	From the resolution of contentious issues regarding distribution of legislative powers by the courts, 'Principle of Federal Supremacy' and 'Harmonious Construction' have emerged. Explain.	2019	10
	The concept of cooperative federalism has been increasingly emphasized in recent years. Highlight the drawbacks in the existing structure and the extent to which cooperative federalism would answer the shortcomings.	2015	12.5
	Though the federal principle is dominant in our Constitution and that principle is one of its basic features, but it is equally true that federalism under the Indian Constitution leans in favour of a strong Centre, a feature that militates against the concept of strong federalism. Discuss.	2014	12.5
	Many State Governments further bifurcate geographical administrative areas like Districts and Talukas for better governance. In light of the above, can it also be justified that more number of smaller States would bring in effective governance at State level? Discuss.	2013	10
	Constitutional mechanisms to resolve the inter-state water disputes have failed to address and solve the problems. Is the failure due to structural or process inadequacy or both? Discuss.	2013	10
Governor x Union Territory	Discuss the essentials of the 69th Constitutional Amendment Act and anomalies, if any that have led to recent reported conflicts between the elected representatives and the institution of the Lieutenant Governor in the administration of Delhi. Do you think that this will give rise to a new trend in the functioning of the Indian federal politics?	2016	12.5
Special Provision	To what extent is Article 370 of the Indian Constitution, bearing marginal note "Temporary provision with respect to the State of Jammu and Kashmir", temporary? Discuss the future prospects of this provision in the context of Indian polity.	2016	12.5
	Recent directives from Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas are perceived by the 'Nagas' as a threat to override the exceptional status enjoyed by the State. Discuss in light of Article 371A of the Indian Constitution.	2013	10
Union Territory	Discuss the nature of Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly after the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganization Act, 2019. Briefly describe the powers and functions of the Assembly of the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir.	2025	10



Polity

03. Separation of Powers between different organs, dispute redressal mechanisms and institutions

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Executive Vs Legislature	"The growth of cabinet system has practically resulted in the marginalisation of the parliamentary supremacy." Elucidate.	2024	
	To what extent, in your view, the Parliament is able to ensure accountability of the executive in India?	2021	10
	Resorting to ordinances has always raised concern on violation of the spirit of separation of powers doctrine. While noting the rationales justifying the power to promulgate ordinances, analyze whether the decisions of the Supreme Court on the issue have further facilitated resorting to this power. Should the power to promulgate ordinances be repealed?	2015	12.5
Governor	Discuss the essential conditions for exercise of the legislative powers by the Governor. Discuss the legality of re-promulgation of ordinances by the Governor without placing them before the Legislature.	2022	15
Governor x Union Territory	Whether the Supreme Court Judgement (July 2018) can settle the political tussle between the Lt. Governor and elected government of Delhi? Examine.	2018	15
Judiciary	Critically examine the Supreme Court's judgement on 'National Judicial Appointments Commission Act, 2014' with reference to appointment of judges of higher judiciary in India.	2017	10
Judiciary vs Legislature	Judicial Legislation is antithetical to the doctrine of separation of powers as envisaged in the Indian Constitution. In this context justify the filing of large number of public interest petitions praying for issuing guidelines to executive authorities.	2020	15
	The Supreme Court of India keeps a check on arbitrary power of the Parliament in amending the Constitution. Discuss critically.	2013	10
Separation of Powers	"Constitutionally guaranteed judicial independence is a prerequisite of democracy". Comment.	2023	10
	Do you think that constitution of India does not accept principle of strict separation of powers rather it is based on the principle of 'checks and balance'? Explain.	2019	10



Polity

04. Devolution of powers and finances up to local levels and challenges therein

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Local Self-Government	Analyse the role of local bodies in providing good governance at local level and bring out the pros and cons merging the rural local bodies with the urban local bodies.	2024	10
	"The states in India seem reluctant to empower urban local bodies both functionally as well as financially." Comment.	2023	10
	To what extent, in your opinion, has the decentralisation of power in India changed the governance landscape at the grassroots ?	2022	10
	The strength and sustenance of local institutions in India has shifted from their formative phase of 'Functions, Functionaries and Funds' to the contemporary stage of 'Functionality'. Highlight the critical challenges faced by local institutions in terms of their functionality in recent times.	2020	15
	"The reservation of seats for women in the institutions of local self- government has had a limited impact on the patriarchal character of the Indian Political Process." Comment.	2019	15
	Assess the importance of Panchayat system in India as a part of local government. Apart from government grants, what sources the Panchayats can look out for financing developmental projects.	2018	15
	"The local self-government system in India has not proved to be effective instrument of governance". Critically examine the statement and give your views to improve the situation.	2017	10
	In absence of a well-educated and organized local level government system, 'Panchayats' and 'Samitis' have remained mainly political institutions and not effective instruments of governance. Critically discuss.	2015	12.5

Polity

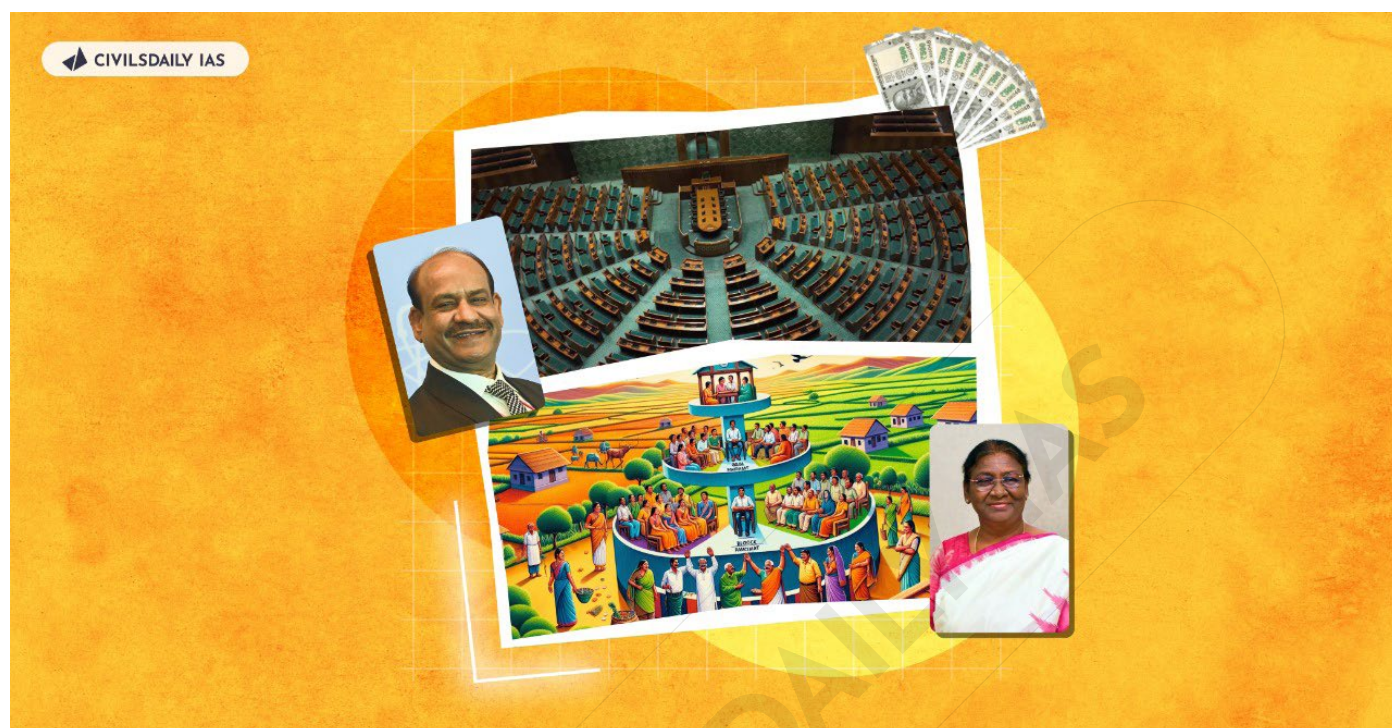
05. Comparison of Indian constitutional scheme with other countries

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Constitutional Comparison	Discuss the evolution of collegium system in India. Critically examine the advantages and disadvantages of the system on appointment of the Judges of the Supreme Court of India and that of the USA.	2025	15
	Compare and contrast the President's power to pardon in India and in the USA. Are there any limits to it in both the countries? What are 'preemptive pardons'?	2025	10
	Discuss India as a secular state and compare with the secular principles of the US constitution.	2024	15
	Compare and contrast the British and Indian approaches to Parliamentary sovereignty.	2023	10
	Critically examine the procedures through which the Presidents of India and France are elected.	2022	15
	Analyze the distinguishing features of the notion of Right to Equality in the Constitutions of the USA and India.	2021	15
	The judicial systems in India and UK seem to be converging as well as diverging in recent times. Highlight the key points of convergence and divergence between the two nations in terms of their judicial practices.	2020	10
	What can France learn from the Indian Constitution's approach to secularism?	2019	10
	India and USA are two large democracies. Examine the basic tenets on which the two political systems are based.	2018	15



Polity

06. Parliament and State Legislatures (structure, functioning, conduct of business, powers & privileges; issues therein)



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Parliament x Committees	Explain the structure of the Parliamentary Committee system. How far have the financial committees helped in the institutionalization of Indian Parliament?	2023	15
	Do Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committees keep the administration on its toes and inspire reverence for parliamentary control? Evaluate the working of such committees with suitable examples.	2021	15
	Why do you think the committees are considered to be useful for parliamentary work? Discuss, in this context, the role or the Estimates Committee.	2018	10
	Discuss the role of Public Accounts Committee in establishing accountability of the government to the people.	2017	10
Parliament x Houses	Explain the constitutional provisions under which Legislative Councils are established. Review the working and current status of Legislative Councils with suitable illustrations.	2021	15
	Rajya Sabha has been transformed from a 'useless stepney tyre' to the most useful supporting organ in past few decades. Highlight the factors as well as the areas in which this transformation could be visible.	2020	15
	The Indian Constitution has provisions for holding joint session of the two houses of the Parliament. Enumerate the occasions when this would normally happen and also the occasions when it cannot, with reasons thereof.	2017	15
Parliament x Presiding Officers	Discuss the role of Presiding Officers of state legislatures in maintaining order and impartiality in conducting legislative work and in facilitating best democratic practices.	2023	10
	Discuss the role of the Vice-President of India as the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.	2022	10
	'Once a Speaker, Always a Speaker'! Do you think this practice should be adopted to impart objectivity to the office of the Speaker of Lok Sabha? What could be its implications for the robust functioning of parliamentary business in India?	2020	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Parliament x Privileges	The 'Powers, Privileges and Immunities of Parliament and its Members' as envisaged in Article 105 of the Constitution leave room for a large number of un-codified and un-enumerated privileges to continue. Assess the reasons for the absence of legal codification of the 'parliamentary privileges'. How can this problem be addressed?	2014	12.5
Role of MPs	Individual Parliamentarian's role as the national lawmaker is on a decline, which in turn, has adversely impacted the quality of debates and their outcome. Discuss.	2019	15
	The role of individual MPs (Members of Parliament) has diminished over the years and as a result healthy constructive debates on policy issues are not usually witnessed. How far can this be attributed to the anti-defection law, which was legislated but with a different intention?	2013	10



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Polity

07. Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary-Ministries and Departments of the Government; pressure groups and formal/informal associations and their role in the Polity

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Alternate Dispute Resolution	Explain and distinguish between Lok Adalats and Arbitration Tribunals. Whether they entertain civil as well as criminal cases ?	2024	10
	Who are entitled to receive free legal aid? Assess the role of the National Legal Services Authority(NALSA) in rendering free legal aid in India.	2023	10
	What are the major changes brought in the Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996 through the recent Ordinance promulgated by the President? How far will it improve India's dispute resolution mechanism? Discuss.	2015	12.5
Attorney General	The Attorney General of India plays a crucial role in guiding the legal framework of the Union Government and ensuring sound governance through legal counsel." Discuss his responsibilities, rights and limitations in this regard.	2025	10
	"The Attorney-General is the chief legal adviser and lawyer of the Government of India." Discuss.	2019	15
Informal Associations	Khap Panchayats have been in the news for functioning as extra-constitutional authorities, often delivering pronouncements amounting to human rights violations. Discuss critically the actions taken by the legislative, executive and the judiciary to set the things right in this regard.	2015	12.5
Judiciary	Explain the reasons for the growth of public interest litigation in India. As a result of it, has the Indian Supreme Court emerged as the world's most powerful judiciary?	2024	15
	Discuss the desirability of greater representation to women in the higher judiciary to ensure diversity, equity and inclusiveness.	2021	10
	Starting from inventing the 'basic structure' doctrine, the judiciary has played a highly proactive role in ensuring that India develops into a thriving democracy. In light of the statement, evaluate the role played by judicial activism in achieving the ideals of democracy.	2014	12.5
President Powers	Instances of President's delay in commuting death sentences has come under public debate as denial of justice. Should there be a time limit specified for the President to accept/reject such petitions? Analyse.	2014	12.5
Pressure Groups	What are environmental pressure groups? Discuss their role in raising awareness, influencing policies and advocating for environmental protection in India.	2025	15
	"Pressure groups play a vital role in influencing public policy making in India." Explain how the business associations contribute to public policies.	2021	10
	What are the methods used by the Farmers organizations to influence the policy-makers in India and how effective are these methods?	2019	10
	How do pressure groups influence Indian political process? Do you agree with this view that informal pressure groups have emerged as powerful than formal pressure groups in recent years?	2017	10
	Pressure group politics is sometimes seen as the informal face of politics. With regards to the above, assess the structure and functioning of pressure groups in India.	2013	10
Tribunal	Comment on the need for administrative tribunals as compared to the court system. Assess the impact of the recent tribal reforms through rationalisation of tribunals made in 2021.	2025	10
Union and State Executive	The size of the cabinet should be as big as governmental work justifies and as big as the Prime Minister can manage as a team. How far the efficacy of a government then is inversely related to the size of the cabinet? Discuss.	2014	12.5



Polity

08. Salient features of the Representation of People's Act.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Party System	While the national political parties in India favour centralisation, the regional parties are in favour of State autonomy. Comment.	2022	15
	The Indian party system is passing through a phase of transition which looks to be full of contradictions and paradoxes." Discuss.	2016	12.5
RPA x Election Dispute	Discuss the 'corrupt practices' for the purpose of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. Analyze whether the increase in the assets of the legislators and/ or their associates, disproportionate to their known sources of income, would constitute 'undue influence' and consequently a corrupt practice.	2025	10
	Discuss the procedures to decide the disputes arising out of the election of a Member of the Parliament or State Legislature under The Representation of the People Act, 1951. What are the grounds on which the election of any returned candidate may be declared void? What remedy is available to the aggrieved party against the decision? Refer to the case laws.	2022	15
	"There is a need for simplification of procedure for disqualification of persons found guilty of corrupt practices under the Representation of Peoples Act". Comment.	2020	10
	On what grounds a people's representative can be disqualified under the Representation of People Act, 1951? Also mention the remedies available to such person against his disqualification.	2019	15
RPA x Electoral Reforms	Examine the need for electoral reforms as suggested by various committees with particular reference to "one nation-one election" principle.	2024	10
	In the light of recent controversy regarding the use of Electronic Voting Machines (EVM), what are the challenges before the Election Commission of India to ensure the trustworthiness of elections in India?	2018	10
	'Simultaneous election to the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies will limit the amount of time and money spent in electioneering but it will reduce the government's accountability to the people' Discuss.	2017	10
	To enhance the quality of democracy in India the Election Commission of India has proposed electoral reforms in 2016. What are the suggested reforms and how far are they significant to make democracy successful?	2017	15
RPA x MCC	Discuss the role of the Election Commission of India in the light of the evolution of the Model Code of Conduct.	2022	15





Governance

09. Appointment to various Constitutional posts; Constitutional Bodies(powers, functions and responsibilities); Statutory, Regulatory and Quasi-judicial bodies

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Comptroller and Auditor General CAG	"The duty of the Comptroller and Auditor General is not merely to ensure the legality of expenditure but also its propriety." Comment.	2024	10
	The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) has a very vital role to play. Explain how this is reflected in the method and terms of his appointment as well as the range of powers he can exercise.	2018	10
	Exercise of CAG's powers in relation to the accounts of the Union and the States is derived from Article 149 of the Indian Constitution. Discuss whether audit of the Government's Policy implementation could amount to overstepping its own (CAG) jurisdiction.	2016	12.5
Domestic Bodies/Agencies	The jurisdiction of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) regarding lodging an FIR and conducting probe within a particular State is being questioned by various States. However, the power of the States to withhold consent to the CBI is not absolute. Explain with special reference to the federal character of India.	2021	15
Finance Commission	How have the recommendations of the 14th Finance Commission of India enabled the States to improve their fiscal position?	2021	10
	How is the Finance Commission of India constituted? What do you about the terms of reference of the recently constituted Finance Commission? Discuss.	2018	15
	Discuss the recommendations of the 13th Finance Commission which have been a departure from the previous commissions for strengthening the local government finances.	2013	10
National Commissions	Discuss the role of the National Commission for Backward Classes in the wake of its transformation from a statutory body to a constitutional body.	2022	10
	Whether National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) can enforce the implementation of constitutional reservation for the Scheduled Castes in the religious minority institutions? Examine.	2018	10
Non-Constitutional/ Statutory Bodies	The National Commission for Protection of Child Rights has to address the challenges faced by children in the digital era. Examine the existing policies and suggest measures the Commission can initiate to tackle the issue.	2025	15
	Discuss the role of the Competition Commission of India in containing the abuse of dominant position by the Multi-National Corporations in India. Refer to the recent decisions.	2023	10
	Though the Human Rights Commissions have contributed immensely to the protection of human rights in India, yet they have failed to assert themselves against the mighty and powerful. Analyzing their structural and practical limitations, suggest remedial measures.	2021	15
	Which steps are required for constitutionalization of a Commission? Do you think imparting constitutionality to the National Commission for Women would ensure greater gender justice and empowerment in India? Give reasons.	2020	15
	Multiplicity of various commissions for the vulnerable sections or the society leads to problems or overlapping jurisdiction and duplication of functions. Is it better to merge all commissions into an umbrella Human Rights Commission? Argue your case.	2018	15
	Is the National Commission for Women able to strategize and tackle the problems that women face at both public and private spheres? Give reasons in support of your answer.	2017	15
	National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) in India can be most effective when its tasks are adequately supported by other mechanisms that ensure the accountability of a government. In light of the above observation assess the role of NHRC as an effective complement to the judiciary and other institutions in promoting and protecting human rights standards.	2014	12.5
	'A national Lokpal, however strong it may be, cannot resolve the problems of immorality in public affairs'. Discuss.	2013	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Sectoral Regulatory Bodies	For achieving the desired objectives, it is necessary to ensure that the regulatory institutions remain independent and autonomous. Discuss in the light of the experiences in recent past.	2015	12.5
	The setting up of a Rail Tariff Authority to regulate fares will subject the cash strapped Indian Railways to demand subsidy for obligation to operate non-profitable routes and services. Taking into account the experience in the power sector, discuss if the proposed reform is expected to benefit the consumers, the Indian Railways or the private container operators.	2014	12.5
	The product diversification of financial institutions and insurance companies, resulting in overlapping of products and services strengthens the case for the merger of the two regulatory agencies, namely SEBI and IRDA. Justify.	2013	10
Tribunal	“The Central Administration Tribunal which was established for redressal of grievances and complaints by or against central government employees, nowadays is exercising its powers as an independent judicial authority.” Explain.	2019	10
	How far do you agree with the view that tribunals curtail the jurisdiction of ordinary courts? In view of the above, discuss the constitutional validity and competency of the tribunals in India.	2018	15
	What is a quasi-judicial body? Explain with the help of concrete examples.	2016	12.5



Governance

10. Government Policies & Interventions for development of various sectors (issues in their design, implementation)



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Govt. Programs	The Gati-Shakti Yojana needs meticulous coordination between the government and the private sector to achieve the goal of connectivity. Discuss.	2022	10
	Two parallel run schemes of the Government viz. the Adhaar Card and NPR, one as voluntary and the other as compulsory, have led to debates at national levels and also litigations. On merits, discuss whether or not both schemes need run concurrently. Analyse the potential of the schemes to achieve developmental benefits and equitable growth.	2014	12.5
	The basis of providing urban amenities in rural areas (PURA) is rooted in establishing connectivity. Comment.	2013	10
Structural reforms and Actions	"In contemporary development models, decision-making and problem-solving responsibilities are not located close to the source of information and execution, defeating the objectives of development." Critically evaluate.	2025	15
	The need for cooperation among various service sector has been an inherent component of development discourse. Partnership bridges bring the gap among the sectors. It also sets in motion a culture of 'Collaboration' and 'team spirit'. In the light of statements above examine India's Development process.	2019	15
	'In the context of neo-liberal paradigm of development planning, multi-level planning is expected to make operations cost effective and remove many implementation blockages.'-Discuss.	2019	15
	Policy contradictions among various competing sectors and stakeholders have resulted in inadequate 'protection and prevention of degradation' to environment. " Comment with relevant illustration.	2018	10
	Has the Indian governmental system responded adequately to the demands of Liberalization, Privatization and Globalization started in 1991? What can the government do to be responsive to this important change?	2016	12.5
	Though 100 percent FDI is already allowed in non-news media like a trade publication and general entertainment channel, the Government is mulling over the proposal for increased FDI in news media for quite some time. What difference would an increase in FDI make? Critically evaluate the pros and cons.	2014	12.5





Governance

11. Development processes and the development industry —the role of NGOs, SHGs, various groups and associations, donors, charities, institutional and other stakeholders.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Civil Society	Civil Society Organizations are often perceived as being anti-State actors rather than non-State actors. Do you agree? Justify.	2025	10
	Discuss the contribution of civil society groups for women's effective and meaningful participation and representation in state legislatures in India.	2023	15
	Can Civil Society and Non-Governmental Organizations present an alternative model of public service delivery to benefit the common citizen? Discuss the challenges of this alternative model.	2021	15
	In the Indian governance system, the role of non-state actors has been only marginal. Critically examine this statement.	2016	12.5
	Examine critically the recent changes in the rules governing foreign funding of NGOs under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), 1976.	2015	12.5
	How can the role of NGOs be strengthened in India for development works relating to protection of the environment? Discuss throwing light on the major constraints.	2015	12.5
Donor Agencies	Public charitable trusts have the potential to make India's development more inclusive as they relate to certain vital public issues. Comment.	2024	10
	Do you agree with the view that increasing dependence on donor agencies for development reduces the importance of community participation in the development process? Justify your answer.	2022	15
SHGs	Can the vicious cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition be broken through microfinancing of women SHGs? Explain with examples.	2021	10
	"Micro-Finance as an anti-poverty vaccine, is aimed at asset creation and income security of the rural poor in India". Evaluate the role of Self Help Groups in achieving the twin objectives along with empowering women in rural India.	2020	15
	'The emergence of Self Help Groups(SHGs) in contemporary times points to the slow but steady withdrawal of the state from developmental activities'. Examine the role of the SHGs in developmental activities and the measures taken by the Government of India to promote the SHGs.	2017	15
	The Self-Help Group (SHG) Bank Linkage Programme (SBLP), which is India's own innovation, has proved to be one of the most effective poverty alleviation and women empowerment programmes. Elucidate.	2015	12.5
	The penetration of Self Help Groups (SHGs) in rural areas in promoting participation in development programmes is facing socio-cultural hurdles. Examine.	2014	12.5
	The legitimacy and accountability of Self Help Groups (SHGs) and their patrons, the micro-finance outfits, need systematic assessment and scrutiny for the sustained success of the concept. Discuss.	2013	10



Governance

15. Transparency and accountability (institutional and other measures); Citizens Charter, E-Governance (applications, models, successes, limitations, potential)



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Citizens Charter	The Citizens' charter has been a land mark initiative in ensuring citizen-centric administration. But it is yet to reach its full potential. Identify the factors hindering the realisation of its promise and suggest measures to overcome them.	2024	15
	Citizens' Charter is an ideal instrument of organizational transparency and accountability, but it has its own limitations. Identify the limitations and suggest measures for greater effectiveness or the Citizens Charter.	2018	15
	Though Citizen's charters have been formulated by many public service delivery organizations, there is no corresponding improvement in the level of citizens' satisfaction and quality of services being provided. Analyze.	2013	10
E-governance	E-governance projects have a built-in bias towards technology and back-end integration than user-centric designs. Examine.	2025	10
	e-governance is not just about the routine application of digital technology in service delivery process. It is as much about multifarious interactions for ensuring transparency and accountability. In this context evaluate the role of the 'Interactive Service Model' of e-governance.	2024	15
	e-governance, as a critical tool of governance, has ushered in effectiveness, transparency and accountability in governments. What inadequacies hamper the enhancement of these features?	2023	10
	Has digital illiteracy, particularly in rural areas, coupled with lack of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) accessibility hindered socio-economic development? Examine with justification.	2021	15
	"The emergence of Fourth Industrial Revolution (Digital Revolution) has initiated e-Governance as an integral part of government". Discuss.	2020	10
	Implementation of information and Communication Technology (ICT) based Projects / Programmes usually suffers in terms of certain vital factors. Identify these factors, and suggest measures for their effective implementation.	2019	10
	E-Governance is not only about utilization of the power of new technology, but also much about critical importance of the 'use value' of information Explain.	2018	10
	Electronic cash transfer system for the welfare schemes is an ambitious project to minimize corruption, eliminate wastage and facilitate reforms. Comment.	2013	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Transparency and Accountability	What are the aims and objects of the recently passed and enforced, The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024? Whether University/State Education Board examinations, too, are covered under the Act?	2024	15
	Reforming the government delivery system through the Direct Benefit Transfer Scheme is a progressive step, but it has its limitations too. Comment.	2022	10
	"Recent amendments to the Right to Information Act will have profound impact on the autonomy and independence of the Information Commission". Discuss.	2020	10
	Effectiveness of the government system at various levels and people's participation in the governance system are inter-dependent. Discuss their relationship with each other in context of India.	2016	12.5
	In the integrity index of Transparency International, India stands very low. Discuss briefly the legal, political, economic, social and cultural factors that have caused the decline of public morality in India.	2016	12.5
	In the light of the Satyam Scandal, discuss the changes brought in corporate governance to ensure transparency, accountability.	2015	12.5
	If amendment bill to the Whistleblowers Act, 2011 tabled in the Parliament is passed, there may be no one left to protect. Critically evaluate.	2015	12.5

Governance

16. Role of Civil Services in a democracy.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Civil Services	The Doctrine of Democratic Governance makes it necessary that the public perception of the integrity and commitment of civil servants becomes absolutely positive. Discuss.	2024	10
	"Institutional quality is a crucial driver of economic performance". In this context suggest reforms in Civil Service for strengthening democracy.	2020	10
	Initially Civil Services in India were designed to achieve the goals of neutrality and effectiveness, which seems to be lacking in the present context. Do you agree with the view that drastic reforms are required in Civil Services. Comment	2017	15
	Traditional bureaucratic structure and culture have hampered the process of socio-economic development in India. Comment.	2016	12.5
	Has the Cadre based Civil Services Organisation been the cause of slow change in India? Critically examine.	2014	12.5



Social Justice

12. Welfare schemes for vulnerable sections of the population by the Centre and States and the performance of these schemes; mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Children	Examine the main provisions of the National Child Policy and throw light on the status of its implementation.	2016	12.5
Disabled	The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 remains only a legal document without intense sensitisation of government functionaries and citizens regarding disability. Comment.	2022	10
	Does the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 ensure effective mechanism for empowerment and inclusion of the intended beneficiaries in the society? Discuss	2017	10
Efficacy of Welfare and Development Schemes	"Development and welfare schemes for the vulnerable, by its nature, are discriminatory in approach." Do you agree? Give reasons for your answer.	2023	15
	Performance of welfare schemes that are implemented for vulnerable sections is not so effective due to absence of their awareness and active involvement at all stages of policy process – Discuss.	2019	15
	Do government's schemes for up-lifting vulnerable and backward communities by protecting required social resources for them, lead to their exclusion in establishing businesses in urban economics?	2014	12.5
	The Central Government frequently complains on the poor performance of the State Governments in eradicating suffering of the vulnerable sections of the society. Restructuring of Centrally sponsored schemes across the sectors for ameliorating the cause of vulnerable sections of population aims at providing flexibility to the States in better implementation. Critically evaluate.	2013	10
Women	Women's social capital complements in advancing empowerment and gender equity. Explain.	2025	10
	"Though women in post-Independent India have excelled in various fields, the social attitude towards women and feminist movement has been patriarchal." Apart from women education and women empowerment schemes, what interventions can help change this milieu?	2021	15





Social Justice

13. Issues relating to development and management of Social Sector/ Services relating to Health, Education, Human Resources.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Education	The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009 remains inadequate in promoting incentive-based system for children's education without generating awareness about the importance of schooling. Analyse.	2022	15
	"Earn while you learn' scheme needs to be strengthened to make vocational education and skill training meaningful." Comment.	2021	10
	National Education Policy 2020 is in conformity with the Sustainable Development Goal-4. It intends to restructure and reorient education system in India. Critically examine the statement.	2020	15
	The quality of higher education in India requires major improvements to make it internationally competitive. Do you think that the entry of foreign educational institutions would help improve the quality of higher and technical education in the country? Discuss.	2015	12.5
	Should the premier institutes like IITs/IIMs be allowed to retain premier status, allowed more academic independence in designing courses and also decide mode/criteria of selection of students. Discuss in light of the growing challenges.	2014	12.5
Health	In a crucial domain like the public healthcare system, the Indian State should play a vital role to contain the adverse impact of marketisation of the system. Suggest some measures through which the State can enhance the reach of public healthcare at the grassroots level.	2024	15
	"Besides being a moral imperative of a Welfare State, primary health structure is a necessary precondition for sustainable development." Analyse.	2021	10
	In order to enhance the prospects of social development, sound and adequate health care policies are needed particularly in the fields of geriatric and maternal health care. Discuss.	2020	10
	Appropriate local community-level healthcare intervention is a prerequisite to achieve 'Health for All ' in India. Explain.	2018	10
	'To ensure effective implementation of policies addressing water, sanitation and hygiene needs, the identification of beneficiary segments is to be synchronized with the anticipated outcomes' Examine the statement in the context of the WASH scheme.	2017	10
	Public health system has limitations in providing universal health coverage. Do you think that the private sector could help in bridging the gap? What other viable alternatives would you suggest?	2015	12.5
	Identify the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) that are related to health. Discuss the success of the actions taken by the Government for achieving the same.	2013	10
Human Resources	Skill development programs have succeed in increasing human resources supply to various sectors. In the context of the statement analyze the linkages between education, skill and employment.	2023	15
	The crucial aspect of development process has been the inadequate attention paid to Human Resource Development in India. Suggest measures that can address this adequacy.	2023	10
	Despite Consistent experience of High growth, India still goes with the lowest indicators of human development. Examine the issues that make balanced and inclusive development elusive.	2019	10
	Professor Amartya Sen has advocated important reforms in the realms of primary education and primary health care. What are your suggestions to improve their status and performance?	2016	12.5
	Demographic Dividend in India will remain only theoretical unless our manpower becomes more educated, aware, skilled and creative. What measures have been taken by the government to enhance the capacity of our population to be more productive and employable?	2016	12.5
	An athlete participates in Olympics for personal triumph and nation's glory; victors are showered with cash incentives by various agencies, on their return. Discuss the merit of state sponsored talent hunt and its cultivation as against the rationale of a reward mechanism as encouragement.	2014	12.5



Social Justice

14. Issues relating to poverty and hunger

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Hunger	There is a growing divergence in the relationship between poverty and hunger in India. The shrinking of social expenditure by the government is forcing the poor to spend more on Non- Food essential items squeezing their food – budget.- Elucidate.	2019	10
	How far do you agree with the view that the focus on lack of availability of food as the main cause of hunger takes the attention away from ineffective human development policies in India?	2018	15
	The concept of Mid Day Meal (MDM) scheme is almost a century old in India with early beginnings in Madras Presidency in pre-independent India. The scheme has again been given impetus in most states in the last two decades. Critically examine its twin objectives, latest mandates and success.	2013	10
Poverty	Inequality in the ownership pattern of resources is one of the major causes of poverty. Discuss in the context of 'paradox of poverty'.	2025	15
	Poverty and malnutrition create a vicious cycle, adversely affecting human capital formation. What steps can be taken to break the cycle?	2024	10
	Besides the welfare schemes, India needs deft management of inflation and unemployment to serve the poor and the underprivileged sections of the society. Discuss.	2022	15
	"The incidence and intensity of poverty are more important in determining poverty based on income alone". In this context analyse the latest United Nations Multidimensional Poverty Index Report.	2020	15
	Hunger and Poverty are the biggest challenges for good governance in India still today. Evaluate how far successive governments have progressed in dealing with these humongous problems. Suggest measures for improvement.	2017	10
	'Poverty Alleviation Programmes in India remain mere show pieces until and unless they are backed by political will'. Discuss with reference to the performance of the major poverty alleviation programmes in India.	2017	15
	Though there have been several different estimates of poverty in India, all indicate reduction in poverty levels over time. Do you agree? Critically examine with reference to urban and rural poverty indicators.	2015	12.5



International Relations

17. India and its neighborhood- relations.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Bilateral Relations	Discuss the political developments in Maldives in the last two years. Should they be of any cause of concern to India?	2013	10
Bilateral x Neighbour-hood	India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka.' Discuss India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka the light of the preceding statement.	2022	10
	Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples.	2015	12.5
	Project 'Mausam' is considered a unique foreign policy initiative of the Indian Government to improve relationship with its neighbors. Does the project have a strategic dimension? Discuss.	2015	12.5
	The protests in Shahbag Square in Dhaka in Bangladesh reveal a fundamental split in society between the nationalists and Islamic forces. What is its significance for India?	2013	10
	In respect of India-Sri Lanka relations, discuss how domestic factors influence foreign policy.	2013	10
	What is meant by Gujral doctrine? Does it have any relevance today? Discuss.	2013	10

International Relations

18. Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Bilateral Relations	India–Africa digital partnership is achieving mutual respect, co-development and long-term institutional partnerships. Elaborate.	2025	10
	Discuss the geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India with a focus on global trade and energy flows. Further also discuss how this relationship affects India's maritime security and regional stability amidst international competition?	2024	10
	What is the significance of Indo-US defence deals over Indo-Russian defence deals? Discuss with reference to stability in the Indo-Pacific region.	2020	15
	'The time has come for India and Japan to build a strong contemporary relationship, one involving global and strategic partnership that will have a great significance for Asia and the world as a whole.' Comment.	2019	10
	"What introduces friction into the ties between India and the United States is that Washington is still unable to find for India a position in its global strategy, which would satisfy India's National self-esteem and ambitions" Explain with suitable examples.	2019	15
	India's relations with Israel have, of late, acquired a depth and diversity, which cannot be rolled back." Discuss.	2018	10
	Increasing interest of India in Africa has its pros and cons. Critically examine.	2015	12.5
	With respect to the South China sea, maritime territorial disputes and rising tension affirm the need for safeguarding maritime security to ensure freedom of navigation and over flight throughout the region. In this context, discuss the bilateral issues between India and China.	2014	12.5
	Economic ties between India and Japan, while growing in recent years, are still far below their potential. Elucidate the policy constraints which are inhibiting this growth.	2013	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Groupings x Neighbourhood	Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.	2024	10
	'Virus of Conflict is affecting the functioning of the SCO'. In the light of the above statement point out the role of India in mitigating problems.	2023	10
	Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realized by forming this new organisation?	2022	10
	Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India?	2021	15
	Evaluate the economic and strategic dimensions of India's Look East Policy in the context of the post-Cold War international scenario.	2016	12.5
	Increasing cross-border terrorist attacks in India and growing interference in the internal affairs of several member-states by Pakistan are not conducive for the future of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation). Explain with suitable examples.	2016	12.5
Groupings x Regional	How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics ?	2022	15
	"If the last few decades were of Asia's growth story, the next few are expected to be of Africa's." In the light of this statement, examine India's influence in Africa in recent years.	2021	10
	The newly tri-nation partnership AUKUS is aimed at countering China's ambitions in the Indo-Pacific region. Is it going to supersede the existing partnerships in the region? Discuss the strength and impact of AUKUS in the present scenario.	2021	15
	'Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad)' is transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times - Discuss.	2020	15



International Relations

19. Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Energy Security	"Energy security constitutes the dominant kingpin of India's foreign policy, and is linked with India's overarching influence in Middle Eastern countries." How would you integrate energy security with India's foreign policy trajectories in the coming years?	2025	15
	Clean energy is the order of the day. Describe briefly India's changing policy towards climate change in various international fora in the context of geopolitics.	2022	15
	The question of India's Energy Security constitutes the most important part of India's economic progress. Analyze India's energy policy cooperation with West Asian Countries.	2017	15
Geo-politics affecting India's Interest	With the waning of globalization, post-Cold War world is becoming a site of sovereign nationalism. Elucidate.	2025	10
	The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategic ally to counter China's political and economic dominance.' Explain this statement with examples.	2024	10
	"The long-sustained image of India as a leader of the oppressed and marginalised Nations has disappeared on account of its new found role in the emerging global order". Elaborate.	2019	15
	A number of outside powers have entrenched themselves in Central Asia, which is a zone of interest to India. Discuss the implications, in this context, of India's joining the Ashgabat Agreement, 2018.	2018	10
	In what ways would the ongoing US-Iran Nuclear Pact Controversy affect the national interest of India? How should India respond to this situation?	2018	15
	'China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbor.	2017	10
	The proposed withdrawal of International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) from Afghanistan in 2014 is fraught with major security implications for the countries of the region. Examine in light of the fact that India is faced with a plethora of challenges and needs to safeguard its own strategic interests.	2013	10
Groupings x Neighbourhood	What do you understand by 'The String of Pearls'? How does it impact India? Briefly outline the steps taken by India to counter this.	2013	10
Groupings x Regional	'The expansion and strengthening of NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well in India.' What is your opinion about this statement? Give reasons and examples to support your answer.	2023	15
Indian Diaspora	Indian diaspora has scaled new heights in the West. Describe its economic and political benefits for India.	2023	10
	'Indian diaspora has a decisive role to play in the politics and economy of America and European Countries'. Comment with examples.	2020	10
	Indian Diaspora has an important role to play in South-East Asian countries' economy and society. Appraise the role of Indian Diaspora in South- East Asia in this context	2017	15
Miscellaneous	"The USA is facing an existential threat in the form of a China, that is much more challenging than the erstwhile Soviet Union." Explain.	2021	10



International Relations

20. Important International institutions, agencies and fora- their structure, mandate.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
United Nations, Agencies, Adjacent Bodies	"The reform process in the United Nations remains unresolved, because of the delicate imbalance of East and West and entanglement of the USA vs. Russo-Chinese alliance." Examine and critically evaluate the East-West policy confrontations in this regard.	2025	15
	Terrorism has become a significant threat to global peace and security'. Evaluate the effectiveness of the United Nations Security Council's Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) and its associated bodies in addressing and mitigating this threat at the international level.	2024	15
	'Sea is an important Component of the Cosmos'. Discuss in the light of the above statement the role of the IMO(International Maritime Organisation) in protecting environment and enhancing maritime safety and security.	2023	15
	Critically examine the role of WHO in providing global health security during the Covid-19 pandemic.	2020	10
	'Too little cash, too much politics, leaves UNESCO fighting for life.' Discuss the statement in the light of US' withdrawal and its accusation of the cultural body as being 'anti-Israel bias'.	2019	10
	What are the main functions of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)? Explain different functional commissions attached to it.	2017	10
	What are the aims and objectives of the McBride Commission of the UNESCO? What is India's position on these?	2016	12.5
	Discuss the impediments India is facing in its pursuit of a permanent seat in UN Security Council.	2015	12.5
World Bank, IMF, ADB, International Finance	India has recently signed to become founding a New Development Bank (NDB) and also the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) .How will the role of the two Banks be different? Discuss the significance of these two Banks for India.	2014	12.5
	Some of the International funding agencies have special terms for economic participation stipulating a substantial component of the aid to be used for sourcing equipment from the leading countries. Discuss on merits of such terms and if, there exists a strong case not to accept such conditions in the Indian context.	2014	12.5
	The World Bank and the IMF, collectively known as the Bretton Woods Institutions, are the two inter-governmental pillars supporting the structure of the world's economic and financial order. Superficially, the World Bank and the IMF exhibit many common characteristics, yet their role, functions and mandate are distinctly different. Elucidate.	2013	10
WTO	What are the key areas of reform if the WTO has to survive in the present context of 'Trade War', especially keeping in mind the interest of India?	2018	15
	The broader aims and objectives of WTO are to manage and promote international trade in the era of globalization. But the Doha round of negotiations seem doomed due to differences between the developed and the developing countries. Discuss in the Indian perspective.	2016	12.5
	The aim of Information Technology Agreements (ITAs) is to lower all taxes and tariffs on information technology products by signatories to zero. What impact should such agreements have on India's interests?	2014	12.5
	WTO is an important international institution where decisions taken affect countries in profound manner. What is the mandate of WTO and how binding are their decisions? Critically analyse India's stand on the latest round of talks on Food security.	2014	12.5

GS-III

01. Indian Economy (issues re: planning, mobilisation of resources, growth, development, employment);
02. Inclusive growth and issues arising from it
03. Government Budgeting
04. Major Crops - Cropping patterns in various parts of the country
05. Different types of irrigation and irrigation systems
06. Storage, transport and marketing of Agricultural produce and issues and related constraints
07. E- technology in the aid of farmers
08. Issues related to direct and indirect farm subsidies and MSP; PDS (objectives, functioning, limitations, revamping, issues of buffer stocks & food security), Technology Missions
09. Economics of Animal-Rearing
10. Food processing and related industries in India (scope & significance, location, upstream-downstream requirements, supply chain management);
11. Land Reforms in India
12. Effects of Liberalisation on the economy; Changes in Industrial policy & their effects on industrial growth
13. Infrastructure (energy, ports, roads, airports, railways); Investment models
14. Science and Technology- developments and their applications and effects in everyday life
15. Achievements of Indians in S&T; Indigenisation of technology & developing new technology
16. Awareness in the fields of IT, Space, Computers, robotics, nano-technology, bio-technology and issues relating to intellectual property rights
17. Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment
18. Disaster and Disaster Management
19. Linkages between Development & spread of Extremism
20. Role of external state and non-state actors in creating challenges to internal security.
21. Challenges to internal security through communication networks, role of media and social networking sites in internal security challenges, basics of cyber security; money-laundering and its prevention.
22. Security challenges and their management in border areas - linkages of organized crime with terrorism.
23. Various Security forces and agencies and their mandate.





GS 3 Year-wise PYQ Analysis

Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
1. Indian Economy (issues re: planning, mobilisation of resources, growth, development, employment);	1	1	2	1	1	1	2	3	2	2	4	1	2	23
2. Inclusive growth and issues arising from it	1	1		2	1		1	1	1	1		1	1	11
3. Government Budgeting	2			1	1	1	1		1				1	8
4. Major Crops - Cropping patterns in various parts of the country				1	1	3	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	12
5. Different types of irrigation and irrigation systems				1			1	2	1			1		6
6. Storage, transport and marketing of Agricultural produce and issues and related constraints		1				1		1		1			1	5
7. E- technology in the aid of farmers		1	1								1		1	4
8. Issues related to direct and indirect farm subsidies and MSP; PDS (objectives, functioning, limitations, revamping, issues of buffer stocks & food security), Technology Missions	2		1	1	2	1	1		1	1	1	1		12
9. Economics of Animal-Rearing			1											1
10. Food processing and related industries in India (scope & significance, location, upstream-downstream requirements, supply chain management);	1		1		1		1	1		1			1	7
11. Land Reforms in India	1	1	1	1					1		1	1		7
12. Effects of Liberalisation on the economy; Changes in Industrial policy & their effects on industrial growth	3	2	2	2	2	1						1	1	14
13. Infrastructure (energy, ports, roads, airports, railways); Investment models	1	2	1		1	2				2		1		10
14. Investment models	2	1		1				1						5
15. Science and Technology- developments and their applications and effects in everyday life	5	1			1			2	1	2		2		14
16. Achievements of Indians in S&T; Indigenisation of technology & developing new technology		1			1	1	1						1	5
17. Awareness in the fields of IT, Space, Computers, robotics, nano-technology, bio-technology and issues relating to intellectual property rights	1	1	4	2	1	1	3	1	2	1	3	2	1	23



Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
18. Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment	2	2	1	1	2	3	2	2	3	3	4	2	5	32
19. Disaster and Disaster Management	1	1	1	2	1	1	2	1	2	1	1	2		16
20. Linkages between Development & spread of Extremism	1		1		1	1		1		1			2	8
21. Role of external state and non-state actors in creating challenges to internal security.		2		1		1			1					5
22. Challenges to internal security through communication networks, role of media and social networking sites in internal security challenges, basics of cyber security; money-laundering and its prevention.	3		2		2	2	1	1	2	1		2		16
23. Security challenges and their management in border areas - linkages of organized crime with terrorism.	1	2		3	1		2	1	1	2	3	2	2	20
24. Various Security forces and agencies and their mandate.			1				1	1			1			4
Grand Total	28	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20	20		268



Economic Development

01. Indian Economy and issues relating to planning, mobilization of resources, growth, development and employment.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Care x Monetized Economy	Distinguish between 'care economy' and 'monetized economy'. How can care economy be brought into monetized economy through women empowerment?	2023	15
Demographic Dividend	"While we flaunt India's demographic dividend, we ignore the dropping rates of employ ability."What are we missing while doing so? Where will the jobs that India desperately needs come from? Explain	2014	
Digital Payments, Digital Infrastructure	What is the status of digitalization in the Indian economy? Examine the problems faced in this regard and suggest improvements.	2023	10
Economic Growth, LPG, Planning	"Economic growth in the recent past has been led by increase in labour productivity."Explain this statement. Suggest the growth pattern that will lead to creation of more jobs without compromising labour productivity.	2022	15
	Do you agree that the Indian economy has recently experienced V- shapes recovery? Give reasons in support of your answer.	2021	15
	Among several factors for India's potential growth, savings rate is the most effective one. Do you agree? What are the other factors available for growth potential?	2017	
GST	Explain the rationale behind the Goods and Services Tax (Compensation to States) Act of 2017. How has COVID-19 impacted the GST compensation fund and created new federal tensions?	2020	15
	Enumerate the indirect taxes which have been subsumed in the goods and services tax (GST) in India. Also, comment on the revenue implications of the GST introduced in India since July 2017.	2019	
	Discuss the rationale for introducing the Goods and Services Tax (GST) in India. Bring outcritically the reasons for the delay in roll out for its regime.	2013	
Inclusive Growth	The increase in life expectancy in the country has led to newer health challenges in the community. What are those challenges and what steps need to be taken to meet them?	2022	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Manufacturing Sector	Discuss the rationale of the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme. What are its achievements? In what way can the functioning and outcomes of the scheme be improved?	2025	15
	India aims to become a semiconductor manufacturing hub. What are the challenges faced by the semiconductor industry in India? Mention the salient features of the India Semiconductor Mission.	2025	15
	Faster economic growth requires increased share of the manufacturing sector in GDP, particularly of MSMEs. Comment on the present policies of the Government in this regard.	2023	10
	“Success of make in India program depends on the success of Skill India programme and radical labour reforms.” Discuss with logical arguments.	2015	
National Income Accounting(GDP)	Explain the difference between computing methodology of India’s Gross Domestic Product(GDP) before the year 2015 and after the year 2015.	2021	10
	Define potential GDP and explain its determinants. What are the factors that have been inhibiting India from realizing its potential GDP?	2020	10
	Do you agree with the view that steady GDP growth and low inflation have left the Indian economy in good shape? Give reasons in support of your arguments.	2019	
Non-Constitutional/ Statutory Bodies	How are the principles followed by the NITI Aayog different from those followed by the erstwhile Planning Commission in India?	2018	
RBI x Functions	What are the causes of persistent high food inflation in India? Comment on the effectiveness of the monetary policy of the RBI to control this type of inflation.	2024	10
Unemployment	Most of the unemployment in India is structural in nature. Examine the methodology adopted to compute unemployment in the country and suggest improvements.	2023	15
	The nature of economic growth in India in recent times is often described as a jobless growth. Do you agree with this view? Give arguments in favour of your answer.	2015	

Economic Development

02. Inclusive growth and issues therein

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Corporate Social Responsibility	With a consideration towards the strategy of inclusive growth, the new Companies Bill, 2013 has indirectly made CSR a mandatory obligation. Discuss the challenges expected in its implementation in right earnest. Also discuss other provisions in the Bill and their implications	2013	
Financial Inclusion, PSL	Is inclusive growth possible under market economy? State the significance of financial inclusion in achieving economic growth in India.	2022	10
	Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) is necessary for bringing unbanked to the institutional finance fold. Do you agree with this for financial inclusion of the poorer section of the Indian society? Give arguments to justify your opinion.	2016	12.5
Inclusive Growth	Distinguish between the Human Development Index (HDI) and Inequality-adjusted Human Development Index (IHDI) with special reference to India. Why is the IHDI considered a better indicator of inclusive growth?	2025	10
	What are the salient features of ‘inclusive growth’? Has India been experiencing such a growth process? Analyze and suggest measures for inclusive growth.	2017	
	Comment on the challenges for inclusive growth which include careless and useless manpower in the Indian context. Suggest measures to be taken for facing these challenges	2016	12.5
Inclusive Growth x Capitalism	Capitalism has guided the world economy to unprecedented prosperity. However, it often encourages shortsightedness and contributes to wide disparities between the rich and the poor. In this light, would it be correct to believe and adopt capitalism driving inclusive growth in India? Discuss.	2014	



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Inclusive Growth x Infrastructure	“Investment in infrastructure is essential for more rapid and inclusive economic growth.” Discuss in the light of India’s experience	2021	10
	What are ‘Smart Cities’? examine their relevance for urban development in India. Will it increase rural-urban differences? Give arguments for ‘Smart Villages’ in the light of PURA and RURBAN Mission.	2016	12.5
Inclusive Growth x Public Expenditure	Examine the pattern and trend of public expenditure on social services in the post-reforms period in India. To what extent this has been in consonance with achieving the objective of inclusive growth?	2024	10
Inclusive Growth x Sustainable Development	Explain intra-generational and inter-generational issues of equity from the perspective of inclusive growth and sustainable development.	2020	10
	It is argued that the strategy of inclusive growth is intended to meet the objectives of inclusiveness and sustainability together. Comment on this statement.	2019	

Economic Development

03. Government Budgeting

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Budget, Fiscal Policy	Explain how the Fiscal Health Index (FHI) can be used as a tool for assessing the fiscal performance of states in India. In what way would it encourage the states to adopt prudent and sustainable fiscal policies?	2025	15
	Distinguish between Capital Budget and Revenue Budget. Explain the components of both these Budgets.	2021	10
	The public expenditure management is a challenge to the Government of India in context of budget making during the post liberalization period. Clarify it.	2019	
	Comment on the important changes introduced in respect of the Long term Capital Gains Tax (LCGT) and Dividend Distribution Tax (DDT) in the Union Budget for 2018-2019.	2018	
	One of the intended objectives of Union Budget 2017-18 is to ‘transform, energize and clean India’. Analyse the measures proposed in the Budget 2017-18 to achieve the objective.	2017	
	What is the meaning of the term ‘tax expenditure’? Taking housing sector as an example, discuss how it influences the budgetary policies of the government.	2013	
	What were the reasons for the introduction of Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2003? Discuss critically its salient features and their effectiveness	2013	
Gender Budgeting	Women empowerment in India needs gender budgeting. What are requirements and status of gender budgeting in the Indian context?	2016	12.5

Economic Development

10. Food processing and related industries in India-scope’ and significance, location, upstream and downstream requirements, supply chain management

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Revolutions and Missions	India needs to strengthen measures to promote the pink revolution in food industry for ensuring better nutrition and health. Critically elucidate the statement.	2013	



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Food Processing Sector	Examine the scope of the food processing industries in India. Elaborate the measures taken by the government in the food processing industries for generating employment opportunities.	2025	15
	Elaborate the scope and significance of the food processing industry in India	2022	10
	What are the challenges and opportunities of food processing sector in the country? How can income of the farmers be substantially increased by encouraging food processing?	2020	10
	Elaborate on the policy taken by the government of India to meet the challenges of the food processing sector.	2019	
	What are the reasons for poor acceptance of cost-effective small processing unit? How the food processing unit will be helpful to uplift the socio-economic status of poor farmers?	2017	
	What are the impediments in marketing and supply chain management in developing the food processing industry in India? Can e-commerce help in overcoming this bottleneck?	2015	

Economic Development

12. Effects of liberalization on the economy, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
BoP, FDI, FPI, External Financing	Craze for gold in Indians have led to a surge in import of gold in recent years and put pressure on balance of payments and external value of rupee. In view of this, examine the merits of Gold Monetization Scheme.	2015	12.5
Foreign Exchange, Currency Devaluation	How would the recent phenomena of protectionism and currency manipulations in world trade affect macroeconomic stability of India?	2018	
Labour Reform	Discuss the merits and demerits of the four 'Labour Codes' in the context of labour market reforms in India. What has been the progress so far in this regard?	2024	15
LPG Reforms	"Industrial growth rate has lagged behind in the overall growth of Gross-Domestic-Product (GDP) in the post-reform period" Give reasons. How far the recent changes in Industrial Policy are capable of increasing the industrial growth rate?	2017	
	How globalization has led to the reduction of employment in the formal sector of the Indian economy? Is increased formalization detrimental to the development of the country?	2016	12.5
	Normally countries shift from agriculture to industry and then later to services, but India shifted directly from agriculture to services. What are the reasons for the huge growth-services vis-a-vis industry in the country? Can India become a developed country without a strong industrial base?	2014	
	Examine the impact of liberalization on companies owned by Indians. Are they competing with the MNCs satisfactorily? Discuss.	2013	
Manufacturing Sector	Account for the failure of manufacturing sector in achieving the goal of labour-intensive exports rather than capital-intensive exports. Suggest measures for more labour-intensive rather than capital-intensive exports.	2017	
SEZ	There is a clear acknowledgement that Special Economic Zones (SEZs) are a tool of industrial development, manufacturing and exports. Recognising this potential, the whole instrumentality of SEZs require augmentation. Discuss the issue plaguing the success of SEZs with respect to taxation, governing laws and administration.	2015	
Trade	What are the challenges before the Indian economy when the world is moving away from free trade and multilateralism to protectionism and bilateralism? How can these challenges be met?	2025	10



Economic Development

13. Infrastructure: Energy, Ports, Roads, Airports, Railways etc:



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Airports x Infrastructure	What is the need for expanding the regional air connectivity in India? In this context, discuss the government's UDAN Scheme and its achievements.	2024	15
	International civil aviation laws provide all countries complete and exclusive sovereignty over the airspace above the territory. What do you understand by airspace? What are the implications of these laws on the space above this airspace? Discuss the challenges which this poses and suggests ways to contain the threat.	2014	
Infrastructure Sector	National Urban Transport Policy emphasises on 'moving people' instead of 'moving vehicles. Discuss critically the success of the various strategies of the Government in this regard.	2014	
PPP x Infrastructure	Why is Public Private Partnership (PPP) required in infrastructural projects? Examine the role of PPP model in the redevelopment of Railway Stations in India.	2022	10
	Examine the developments of Airports in India through Joint Ventures under Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model. What are the challenges faced by the authorities in this regard.	2017	
	Explain how Private Public Partnership arrangements, in long gestation infrastructure projects, can transfer unsustainable liabilities to the future. What arrangements need to be put in place to ensure that successive generations' capacities are not compromised?	2014	
	Adoption of PPP model for infrastructure development of the country has not been free of criticism. Critically discuss the pros and cons of the model.	2013	



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Renewable Energy Sector	Do you think India will meet 50 percent of its energy needs from renewable energy by 2030 ? Justify your answer. How will the shift of subsidies from fossil fuels to renewables help achieve the above objective? Explain.	2022	15
	Describe the benefits of deriving electric energy from sunlight in contrast to the conventional energy generation. What are the initiatives offered by our Government for this purpose?	2020	15
	“Access to affordable, reliable, sustainable and modern energy is the sine qua non to achieve Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)”. Comment on the progress made in India in this regard.	2018	
	Give an account of the current status and the targets to be achieved pertaining to renewable energy sources in the country. Discuss in brief the importance of National Programme on Light Emitting diodes (LEDs).	2016	12.5
	To what factors can be the recent dramatic fall in equipment cost and tariff of solar energy be attributed? What implications does the trend have for thermal power producers and related industry?	2015	
	Write a note on India’s green energy corridor to alleviate the problem of conventional energy.	2013	
	What do you understand by run of the river hydroelectricity project? How is it different from any other hydroelectricity project?	2013	

Economic Development

14. Investment models

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
BoP, FDI, FPI, External Financing	Justify the need for FDI for the developments of the Indian economy. Why there is gap between MOUs signed and actual FDIs? Suggest remedial steps to be taken for increasing actual FDIs in India.	2016	12.5
	Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the defence sector is now set to be liberalized: What influence this is expected to have on Indian defence and economy in the short and long run?	2014	
	Discuss the impact of FDI entry into multi-trade retail sector on supply chain management in commodity trade pattern of the economy.	2013	
	Though India allowed Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in what is called multi-brand retail through the joint venture route in September 2012, the FDI, even after a year, has not picked up. Discuss the reasons.	2013	
Investment Funds	Explain the meaning of investment in an economy in terms of capital formation. Discuss the factors to be considered while designing a concession agreement between a public entity and a private entity.	2020	15



Agriculture

04. Major crops-cropping patterns in various parts of the country, different types of irrigation and irrigation systems storage, transport and marketing of agricultural produce and issues and related constraints; e-technology in the aid of farmers:



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Crop Diversification	Explain the factors influencing the decision of the farmers on the selection of high value crops in India.	2025	10
	Explain the changes in cropping pattern in India in the context of changes in consumption pattern and marketing conditions.	2023	15
	What are the present challenges before crop diversification? How do emerging technologies provide an opportunity for crop diversification?	2021	15
	What are the major factors responsible for making rice-wheat system a success? In spite of this success how has this system become bane in India?	2020	15
	How has the emphasis on certain crops brought about changes in cropping patterns in recent past? Elaborate the emphasis on millets production and consumption.	2018	
Cropping pattern	What are the major reasons for declining rice and wheat yield in the cropping system? How crop diversification is helpful to stabilize the yield of the crop in the system?	2017	
	What is allelopathy? Discuss its role in major cropping systems of irrigated agriculture.	2016	12.5
Integrated Farming System	What is Integrated Farming System ? How is it helpful to small and marginal farmers in India ?	2022	15
	How far is Integrated Farming System (IFS) helpful in sustaining agricultural production?	2019	
Millets, Pulses	Explain the role of millets for ensuring health and nutritional security in India.	2024	10
Organic Farming	Sikkim is the first 'Organic State' in India. What are the ecological and economical benefits of Organic State?	2018	





Agriculture

05. Different types of irrigation and irrigation systems

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Irrigation	What are the major challenges faced by Indian irrigation system in recent times? State the measures taken by the government for efficient irrigation management.	2024	15
	Suggest measures to improve water storage and irrigation system to make its judicious use under depleting scenario.	2020	15
Micro-Irrigation	How and to what extent would micro-irrigation help in solving India's water crisis?	2021	10
	What is water-use efficiency? Describe the role of micro-irrigation in increasing the water-use efficiency	2016	12.5
Water Storage and Conservation	What are the salient features of the Jal Shakti Abhiyan launched by the Government of India for water conservation and water security?	2020	10
	Elaborate the impact of National Watershed Project in increasing agricultural production from water-stressed areas.	2019	

Agriculture

06. Storage, transport and marketing of Agricultural produce and issues and related constraints

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Agri-Marketing	Elaborate the scope and significance of supply chain management of agricultural commodities in India.	2025	10
	What are the main bottlenecks in upstream and downstream process of marketing of agricultural products in India ?	2022	15
	What are the main constraints in transport and marketing of agricultural produce in India?	2020	10
	Examine the role of supermarkets in supply chain management of fruits, vegetables and food items. How do they eliminate number of intermediaries?	2018	
	There is also a point of view that Agricultural Produce Market Committees [APMCs] set up under the State Acts have not only impeded the development of agriculture but also have been the cause of food inflation in India. Critically examine	2014	

Agriculture

07. E-Technology in the aid of farmers

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Tech x Agri Production and Marketing	How does e-Technology help farmers in production and marketing of agricultural produce?	2023	10
Tech x Agriculture Credit	"In the villages itself no form of credit organization will be suitable except the cooperative society."—All India Rural Credit Survey. Discuss this statement in the background of agricultural finance in India. What constraints and challenges do financial institutions supplying agricultural finance face? How can technology be used to better reach and serve rural clients?	2014	
Tech x Farm Productivity and Income	How does nanotechnology offer significant advancements in the field of agriculture? How can this technology help to uplift the socio-economic status of farmers?	2025	15
	How can the Digital India program help farmers to improve farm productivity and income? What step has the government taken in this regard?	2015	



Agriculture

08. Issues related to direct and indirect farm subsidies and MSP; PDS

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Allied Sector x Horticulture	Assess the role of National Horticulture Mission (NHM) in boosting the production, productivity and income of horticulture farms. How far has it succeeded in increasing the income of farmers?	2018	
Buffer Stock & Food Security	Elucidate the importance of buffer stocks for stabilizing agricultural prices in India. What are the challenges associated with the storage of buffer stock? Discuss.	2024	15
	Food Security Bill is expected to eliminate hunger and malnutrition in India. Critically discuss various apprehensions in its effective implementation along with the concerns it has generated in WTO.	2013	
Crop Insurance	Give the vulnerability of Indian agriculture to vagaries of nature, discuss the need for crop insurance and bring out the salient features of the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY).	2016	12.5
PDS	What are the major challenges of Public Distribution System (PDS) in India? How can it be made effective and transparent?	2022	10
	What are the salient features of the National Food Security Act, 2013? How has the Food Security Bill helped in eliminating hunger and malnutrition in India?	2021	15
	What are the reformatory steps taken by the Government to make food grain distribution system more effective?	2019	
Revolutions and Missions	Explain various types of revolutions, took place in Agriculture after Independence in India. How these revolutions have helped in poverty alleviation and food security in India?	2017	
Subsidies x Agriculture	What are the direct and indirect subsidies provided to farm sector in India? Discuss the issues raised by the World Trade Organization (WTO) in relation to agricultural subsidies.	2023	15
	What do you mean by Minimum Support Price (MSP)? How will MSP rescue the farmers from the low-income trap?	2018	
	How do subsidies affect the cropping pattern, crop diversity and economy of farmers? What is the significance of crop insurance, minimum support price and food processing for small and marginal farmers?	2017	
	In what way could replacement of price subsidy with direct benefit Transfer (DBT) change the scenario of subsidies in India? Discuss.	2015	
	What are the different types of agriculture subsidies given to farmers at the national and at state levels? Critically analyse the agricultural subsidy regime with reference to the distortions created by it.	2013	

Agriculture

09. Economics of Animal Rearing

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Allied Sector x Livestock	Livestock rearing has a big potential for providing non-farm employment and income in rural areas. Discuss suggesting suitable measures to promote this sector in India.	2015	



Agriculture

11. Land Reforms in India

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Contract farming, land leasing	In view of the declining average size of land holdings in India which has made agriculture non-viable for a majority of farmers, should contract farming and land leasing be promoted in agriculture? Critically evaluate the pros and cons.	2015	
Land Reforms	What were the factors responsible for the successful implementation of land reforms in some parts of the country? Elaborate.	2024	10
	State the objectives and measures of land reforms in India. Discuss how land ceiling policy on landholding can be considered as an effective reform under economic criteria	2023	10
	How did land reforms in some parts of the country help to improve the socio-economic conditions of marginal and small farmers?	2021	10
	Discuss the role of land reforms in agricultural development. Identify the factors that were responsible for the success of land reforms in India.	2016	12.5
	Establish relationship between land reforms, agricultural productivity and elimination of poverty in the Indian economy. Discuss the difficulties in designing and implementation of agriculture-friendly land reforms in India	2013	
Land Reform x Act Based	The Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 has come into effect from 1st January, 2014. What are the key issues which would get addressed with the Act in place? What implications would it have on industrialization and agriculture in India?	2014	



Science & Technology

15. Science and Technology- Developments and their Applications and Effects in Everyday Life.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Emerging Tech x IT	What is digital signature? What does its authentication mean? Give various salient built-in features of a digital signature.	2013	
	How does the 3D printing technology work? List out the advantages and disadvantages of the technology.	2013	
General science	Each year a large amount of plant material, cellulose, is deposited on the surface of Planet Earth. What are the natural processes this cellulose undergoes before yielding carbon dioxide, water and other end products?	2022	10
Medical and Health Technologies	Stem cell therapy is gaining popularity in India to treat a wide variety of medical conditions including Leukaemia, Thalassemia, damaged cornea and several burns. Describe briefly what stem cell therapy is and what advantages it has over other treatments?	2017	
	Can overuse and the availability of antibiotics without doctor's prescription, the contributors to the emergence of drug-resistant diseases in India? What are the available mechanisms for monitoring and control? Critically discuss the various issues involved.	2014	
	What do you understand by fixed dose drug combinations (FDCs)? Discuss their merits and demerits.	2013	
Nobel Prizes	The Nobel Prize in Physics of 2014 was jointly awarded to Akasaki, Amano and Nakamura for the invention of Blue LEDs in 1990s. How has this invention impacted the everyday life of human beings?	2021	15
Robotics, Material Science, Sports,	What do you understand by Umpire decision review in cricket? Discuss its various components. Explain how silicon tape on the edge of a bat may fool the system?	2013	
	What is an FRP composite material? How are they manufactured? Discuss their applications in aviation and automobile industry	2013	
Tech in Crisis Management	The world is facing an acute shortage of clean and safe freshwater. What are the alternative technologies which can solve this crisis? Briefly discuss any three such technologies citing their key merits and demerits.	2024	15





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Tech solutions for daily challenges	What is the technology being employed for electronic toll collection on high-ways? What are its advantages and limitations? What are the proposed changes that will make this process seamless? Would this transition carry any potential hazards?	2024	10
	How is science interwoven deeply with our lives? What are the striking changes in agriculture triggered off by the science-based technologies?	2020	10
Vaccines	What is the basic principle behind vaccine development? How do vaccines work? What approaches were adopted by the Indian vaccine manufacturers to produce COVID-19 vaccines?	2022	15

Science & Technology

16. Achievements of Indians in Science & Technology; Indigenization of Technology and Developing New Technology.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Achievements of Indians in S & T	How was India benefited from the contributions of Sir M.Visvesvaraya and Dr. M. S. Swaminathan in the fields of water engineering and agricultural science respectively?	2019	
	Discuss the work of 'Bose-Einstein Statistics' done by Prof. Satyendra Nath Bose and show how it revolutionized the field of Physics.	2018	
	Scientific research in Indian universities is declining, because a career in science is not as attractive as our business operations, engineering or administration, and the universities are becoming consumer oriented. Critically comment.	2014	
Nuclear Energy Governance	The fusion energy programme in India has steadily evolved over the past few decades. Mention India's contributions to the international fusion energy project International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER). What will be the implications of the success of this project for the future of global energy?	2025	10
	With growing energy needs should India keep on expanding its nuclear energy programme? Discuss the facts and fears associated with nuclear energy.	2018	
	Give an account of the growth and development of nuclear science and technology in India. What is the advantage of fast breeder reactor programme in India?	2017	



Science & Technology

17. Awareness in the fields of IT, Space, Computers, Robotics, Nano-technology, Bio-technology and issues relating to Intellectual Property Rights.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
AI	Introduce the concept of Artificial Intelligence (AI). How does AI help clinical diagnosis? Do you perceive any threat to privacy of the individual in the use of AI in healthcare?	2023	10
Defence	How is S-400 air defence system technically superior to any other system presently available in the world?	2021	10
Emerging Tech x IT	Discuss the advantage and security implications of cloud hosting of server vis-a-vis inhouse machine-based hosting for government businesses.	2015	
Genetics, Biotechnology	How can India achieve energy independence through clean technology by 2047? How can biotechnology play a crucial role in this endeavour?	2025	10
	Discuss several ways in which microorganisms can help in meeting the current fuel shortage.	2023	10
	What are the research and developmental achievements in applied biotechnology/? How will these achievements help to uplift the poorer sections of society?	2021	15
	How can biotechnology improve the living standards of farmers?	2019	
	Why is there so much activity in the field of biotechnology in our country? How has this activity benefitted the field of biopharma?	2018	
IPR	What is the present world scenario of intellectual property rights with respect to life materials? Although, India is second in the world to file patents, still only a few have been commercialized. Explain the reasons behind this less commercialization.	2024	10
	How is the government of India protecting traditional knowledge of medicine from patenting by pharmaceutical companies?	2019	
	India's Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) which has a database containing formatted information on more than 2 million medicinal formulations is proving a powerful weapon in the country's fight against erroneous patents. Discuss the pros and cons making this database publicly available under open-source licensing	2015	
	In a globalised world, intellectual property rights assume significance and are a source of litigation. Broadly distinguish between the terms – copyrights, patents and trade secrets.	2014	
	Bring out the circumstances in 2005 which forced amendment to section 3(d) in the Indian Patent Law, 1970. Discuss how it has been utilized by Supreme court in its judgment rejecting Novartis patent application for "Glivec". Discuss briefly the pros and cons of the decision.	2013	
Nanotechnology, Carbon	What do you understand by nanotechnology and how is it helping in health sector?	2020	10
	Why is nanotechnology one of the key technologies of the 21st century? Describe the salient features of Indian Government's Mission on Nanoscience and Technology and the scope of its application in the development process of the country.	2016	12.5
Robotics, Material Science, Sports,	What are the areas of prohibitive labour that can be sustainably managed by robots? Discuss the initiatives that can propel research in premier research institutes for substantive and gainful innovation.	2015	



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Space Programs x IND	What is the main task of India's third moon mission which could not be achieved in its earlier mission? List the countries that have achieved this task. Introduce the subsystems in the spacecraft launched and explain the role of the Virtual Launch Control Centre at the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre which contributed to the successful launch from Srihari Kota.	2023	15
	What is India's plan to have its own space station and how will it benefit our space programme?	2019	10
	India has achieved remarkable successes in unmanned space missions including the Chandrayaan and Mars Orbiter Mission, but has not ventured into manned space mission, both in terms of technology and logistics? Explain critically.	2017	10
	Discuss India's achievements in the field of Space Science and Technology. How the application of this technology has helped India in its socio-economic development?	2016	12.5
	What do you understand by 'Standard Positioning Systems' and 'Protection Positioning Systems' in the GPS era? Discuss the advantages India perceives from its ambitious IRNSS programme employing just seven satellites.	2015	12.5
Space Programs x Intl	Launched on 25th December, 2021, James Webb Space Telescope has been much in the news since then. What are its unique features which make it superior to its predecessor Space Telescopes? What are the key goals of this mission? What potential benefits does it hold for the human race?	2022	15
Space x Theory	What are asteroids? How real is the threat of them causing extinction of life? What strategies have been developed to prevent such a catastrophe?	2024	15
Tech in Crisis Management	COVID-19 pandemic has caused unprecedented devastation worldwide. However, technological advancements are being availed readily to win over the crisis. Give an account of how technology was sought to aid management to the pandemic.	2020	15



Environment

18. Conservation, Environmental Pollution and Degradation, Environmental Impact Assessment.

CIVILSDAILY IAS



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Air Pollution and Related Issues	What is Carbon Capture, Utilization and Storage (CCUS)? What is the potential role of CCUS in tackling climate change?	2025	10
	Discuss in detail the photochemical smog emphasizing its formation, effects and mitigation. Explain the 1999 Gothenburg Protocol.	2022	10
	Describe the key points of the revised Global Air Quality Guidelines (AQGs) recently released by the World Health Organisation (WHO). How are these different from its last update in 2005? What changes in India's National Clean Air Programme are required to achieve these revised standards?	2021	10
	What are the key features of the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) initiated by the Government of India?	2020	15
Biodiversity	How does biodiversity vary in India? How is the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 helpful in conservation of flora and fauna?	2018	
Climate Change	'Climate Change' is a global problem. How India will be affected by climate change? How Himalayan and coastal states of India will be affected by climate change?	2017	
EIA	What role do environmental NGOs and activists play in influencing Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) outcomes for major projects in India? Cite four examples with all important details.	2024	10
	How does the draft Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) Notification, 2020 differ from the existing EIA Notification, 2006?	2020	10
	Rehabilitation of human settlements is one of the important environmental impacts which always attracts controversy while planning major projects. Discuss the measures suggested for mitigation of this impact while proposing major developmental projects.	2016	12.5
	Environmental Impact Assessment studies are increasingly undertaken before project is cleared by the government. Discuss the environmental impacts of coal-fired thermal plants located at Pitheads.	2014	12.5
EVs	The adoption of electric vehicles is rapidly growing worldwide. How do electric vehicles contribute to reducing carbon emissions and what are the key benefits they offer compared to traditional combustion engine vehicles?	2023	15





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Inclusive Growth x Sustainable Development	Define the concept of carrying capacity of an ecosystem as relevant to an environment. Explain how understanding this concept is vital while planning for sustainable development of a region.	2019	
Mining Hazards	Mineral resources are fundamental to the country economy and these are exploited by mining. Why is mining considered an environmental hazard? Explain the remedial measures required to reduce the environmental hazard due to mining.	2025	15
	Explain the causes and effects of coastal erosion in India. What are the available coastal management techniques for combating the hazard?	2022	15
	Coastal sand mining, whether legal or illegal, poses one of the biggest threats to our environment. Analyse the impact of sand mining along the Indian coasts, citing specific examples.	2019	
	What are the consequences of illegal mining? Discuss the ministry of environment and forests' concept of "GO AND NO GO" zones for coal mining.	2013	
Rio Family/UNFCCC/ IPCC	Write a review on India's climate commitments under the Paris Agreement and mention how these have been further strengthened in COP26. In this direction, how has the first Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) intended by India been updated in 2022?	2025	15
	The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) has predicted a global sea level rise of about one metre by AD 2100. What would be its impact in India and the other countries in the Indian Ocean region?	2023	15
	Discuss global warming and mention its effects on the global climate. Explain the control measures to bring down the level of greenhouse gases which cause global warming, in the light of the Kyoto Protocol, 1997.	2022	15
	Explain the purpose of the Green Grid Initiative launched at the World Leaders Summit of the COP26 UN Climate Change Conference in Glasgow in November 2021. When was this idea first floated in the International Solar Alliance (ISA)?	2021	10
	Describe the major outcomes of the 26th session of the Conference of the Parties (COP) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). What are the commitments made by India in this conference?	2021	15
	Should the pursuit of carbon credit and clean development mechanism set up under UNFCCC be maintained even through there has been a massive slide in the value of carbon credit? Discuss with respect to India's energy needs for economic growth.	2014	
River Linking and Impact	Not many years ago, river linking was a concept but it is becoming reality in the country. Discuss the advantages of river linking and its possible impact on the environment.	2017	
Solid Wastes	What are the impediments in disposing the huge quantities of discarded solid wastes which are continuously being generated? How do we remove safely the toxic wastes that have been accumulating in our habitable environment?	2018	
Water Pollution and Related Issues	Seawater intrusion in the coastal aquifers is a major concern in India. What are the causes of seawater intrusion and the remedial measures to combat this hazard?	2025	10
	Examine the factors responsible for depleting groundwater in India. What are the steps taken by the government to mitigate such depletion of groundwater?	2025	15
	Industrial pollution of river water is a significant environmental issue in India. Discuss the various mitigation measures to deal with this problem and also the government's initiatives in this regard.	2024	10
	What is oil pollution? What are its impacts on the marine ecosystem? In what way is oil pollution particularly harmful for a country like India?	2023	10
	Discuss the Namami Gange and National mission for clean Ganga (NMCG) programmes and causes of mixed results from the previous schemes. What quantum leaps can help preserve the river Ganga better than incremental inputs?	2015	
	Enumerate the National Water Policy of India. Taking river Ganges as an example, discuss the strategies which may be adopted for river water pollution control and management. What are the legal provisions for management and handling of hazardous wastes in India?	2013	
Wetlands	Comment on the National Wetland Conservation Programme initiated by the Government of India and name a few India's wetlands of international importance included in the Ramsar Sites.	2023	15
	What is wetland? Explain the Ramsar concept of 'wise use' in the context of wetland conservation. Cite two examples of Ramsar sites from India.	2018	



Disaster Management

19. Disaster and Disaster Management.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Cloudbursts	Explain the mechanism and occurrence of cloudburst in the context of the Indian subcontinent. Discuss two recent examples.	2022	10
	With reference to National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) guidelines, discuss the measures to be adopted to mitigate the impact of the recent incidents of cloudbursts in many places of Uttarakhand.	2016	12.5
Dam Failures	Dam failures are always catastrophic, especially on the downstream side, resulting in a colossal loss of life and property. Analyze the various causes of dam failures. Give two examples of large dam failures.	2023	10
Disaster Preparedness and Resilience	What is disaster resilience? How is it determined? Describe various elements of a resilience framework. Also mention the global targets of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (2015-2030).	2024	15
	Discuss the recent measures initiated in disaster management by the Government of India departing from the earlier reactive approach.	2020	15
	Disaster preparedness is the first step in any disaster management process. Explain how hazard zonation mapping will help in disaster mitigation in the case of landslides.	2019	
	Describe various measures taken in India for Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR) before and after signing 'Sendai Framework for DRR (2015-2030)'. How is this framework different from 'Hyogo Framework for Action, 2005'?	2018	
Drought	Drought has been recognised as a disaster in view of its party expense, temporal duration, slow onset and lasting effect on various vulnerable sections. With a focus on the September 2010 guidelines from the National disaster management authority, discuss the mechanism for preparedness to deal with the El Nino and La Nina fallouts in India.	2014	
Earthquake	Discuss about the vulnerability of India to earthquake-related hazards. Give examples including the salient features of major disasters caused by earthquakes in different parts of India during the last three decades	2021	10
	The frequency of earthquakes appears to have increased in the Indian subcontinent. However, India's preparedness for mitigating their impact has significant gaps. Discuss various aspects.	2015	





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Landslides	Describe the various causes and the effects of landslides. Mention the important components of the National Landslide Risk Management Strategy.	2021	15
Tsunami	On December 2004, tsunami brought havoc on 14 countries including India. Discuss the factors responsible for occurrence of Tsunami and its effects on life and economy. In the light of guidelines of NDMA describe the mechanisms for preparedness to reduce the risk during such events	2017	
Urban floods	Flooding in urban areas is an emerging climate-induced disaster. Discuss the causes of this disaster. Mention the features of two such major floods in the last two decades in India. Describe the policies and frameworks in India that aim at tackling such floods.	2024	15
	The frequency of urban floods due to high intensity rainfall is increasing over the years. Discussing the reasons for urban floods. highlight the mechanisms for preparedness to reduce the risk during such events.	2016	12.5
Vulnerability and Risk Assessment	Vulnerability is an essential element for defining disaster impacts and its threat to people. How and in what ways can vulnerability to disasters be characterized? Discuss different types of vulnerability with reference to disasters.	2019	
	How important are vulnerability and risk assessment for pre-disaster management. As an administrator ,what are key areas that you would focus in a disaster management	2013	

Internal Security

20. Linkages between Development and Spread of Extremism.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
LWE	The Government of India recently stated that Left Wing Extremism (LWE) will be eliminated by 2026. What do you understand by LWE and how are the people affected by it? What measures have been taken by the government to eliminate LWE?	2025	10
	Naxalism is a social, economic and developmental issue manifesting as a violent internal security threat. In this context, discuss the emerging issues and suggest a multilayered strategy to tackle the menace of Naxalism.	2022	15
	What are the sound determinants of left-wing extremism in Eastern part of India? What strategy should Government of India, civil administration and security forces adopt to counter the threat in the affected areas?	2020	15
	Left Wing Extremism (LWE) is showing a downward trend, but still affects many parts of the country. Briefly explain the Government of India's approach to counter the challenges posed by LWE.	2018	
	The persisting drives of the government for development of large industries in backward areas have resulted in isolating the tribal population and the farmers who face multiple displacements with Malkangiri and Naxalbari foci, discuss the corrective strategies needed to win the left wing extremism (LWE) doctrine affected citizens back into the mainstream of social and economic growth.	2015	
	Article 244 of Indian Constitution relates to Administration of Scheduled areas and tribal areas. Analyze the impact of non-implementation of the provisions of Fifth Schedule on the growth of Left Wing Extremism	2013	
North East Insurgency	What are the major challenges to internal security and peace process in the North-Eastern States? Map the various peace accords and agreements initiated by the government in the past decade.	2025	15
	The north-eastern region of India has been infested with insurgency for a very long time. Analyze the major reasons for the survival of armed insurgency in this region.	2017	

**Internal Security****21. Role of External State and Non-state Actors in creating challenges to Internal Security.**

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Threats from external state and non-state actors	Analyse the multidimensional challenges posed by external state and non-state actors, to the internal security of India. Also, discuss measures required to be taken to combat these threats	2021	15
	The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is viewed as a cardinal subset of China's larger 'One Belt One Road' initiative. Give a brief description of CPEC and enumerate the reasons why India has distanced itself from the same.	2018	
	Use of Internet and social media by non-state actors for subversive activities is a major concern. How have these have misused in the recent past? Suggest effective guidelines to curb the above threat.	2016	12.5
	The diverse nature of India as a multireligious and multi-ethnic society is not immune to the impact of radicalism which has been in her neighbourhood. Discuss along with the strategies to be adopted to counter this environment.	2014	
	China and Pakistan have entered into an agreement for development of an economic corridor. What threat does it dispose for India's security? Critically examine.	2014	



Internal Security

22. Challenges to Internal Security through Communication Networks, Role of Media and Social Networking Sites in Internal Security Challenges, Basics of Cyber Security; Money-Laundering and its prevention.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Cyber Security	What are the different elements of cyber security? Keeping in view the challenges in cyber security, examine the extent to which India has successfully developed a comprehensive National Cyber Security Strategy.	2022	10
	Keeping in view India's internal security, analyse the impact of cross-border cyber attacks. Also, discuss defensive measures against these sophisticated attacks.	2021	10
	Discuss different types of cyber crimes and measures required to be taken to fight the menace	2020	10
	What is the CyberDome Project? Explain how it can be useful in controlling internet crimes in India	2019	
	Discuss the potential threats of Cyber attack and the security framework to prevent it.	2017	
	Considering the threats cyberspace poses for the country, India needs a "Digital Armed Force" to prevent crimes. Critically evaluate the National Cyber Security Policy, 2013 outlining the challenges perceived in its effective implementation.	2015	
	Cyber warfare is considered by some defense analysts to be a larger threat than even Al Qaeda or terrorism. What do you understand by Cyber warfare? Outline the cyber threats which India is vulnerable to and bring out the state of the country's preparedness to deal with the same.	2013	
Data Protection	Describe the context and salient features of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023	2024	10
	Data security has assumed significant importance in the digitized world due to rising cyber crimes. The Justice B. N. Srikrishna Committee Report addresses issues related to data security. What, in your view, are the strengths and weakness of the Report relating to protection of personal data in cyber space?	2018	
Mob Violence	Mob violence is emerging as a serious law and order problem in India. By giving suitable examples, analyze the causes and consequences of such violence.	2017	





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Digital Media and Security Threats	Social media and encrypting messaging services pose a serious security challenge. What measures have been adopted at various levels to address the security implications of social media? Also suggest any other remedies to address the problem.	2024	15
	Religious indoctrination via digital media has resulted in Indian youth joining the ISIS. What is ISIS and its mission? How can ISIS be dangerous for the internal security of our country?	2015	
	What are social networking site and what security implications do these sites present?	2013	
Drug Trafficking	India's proximity to two of the world's biggest illicit opium-growing states has enhanced her internal security concerns. Explain the linkages between drug trafficking and other illicit activities such as gunrunning, money laundering and human trafficking. What counter-measures should be taken to prevent the same?	2018	
Money Laundering and its prevention	Discuss how emerging technologies and globalisation contribute to money laundering. Elaborate measures to tackle the problem of money laundering both at national and international levels.	2021	10
	Money laundering poses a serious threat to country's economic sovereignty. What is its significance for India and what steps are required to be taken to control this menace?	2013	

Internal Security

23. Security Challenges and their Management in Border Areas - Linkages of Organized Crime with Terrorism.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Border Area Management	India has a long and troubled border with China and Pakistan fraught with contentious issues. Examine the conflicting issues and security challenges along the border. Also give out the development being undertaken in these areas under the Border Area Development Programme (BADP) and Border Infrastructure and Management (BIM) Scheme.	2024	15
	The use of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) by our adversaries across the borders to ferry arms / ammunitions, drugs, etc., is a serious threat to internal security. Comment on the measures being taken to tackle this threat.	2023	10
	For effective border area management, discuss the steps required to be taken to deny local support to militants and also suggest ways to manage favourable perception among locals	2020	10
	Cross-border movement of insurgents is only one of the several security challenges facing the policing of the border in North-East India. Examine the various challenges currently emanating across the India-Myanmar border. Also, discuss the steps to counter the challenges.	2019	
	Border management is a complex task due to difficult terrain and hostile relations with some countries. Elucidate the challenges and strategies for effective border management.	2016	12.5
	How illegal transborder migration does pose a threat to India's security? Discuss the strategies to curb this, bring out the factors which give impetus to such migration.	2014	
	How far are India's internal security challenges linked with border management, particularly in view of the long porous borders with most countries of South Asia and Myanmar?	2013	
Maritime Security Challenges	Why is maritime security vital to protect India's sea trade? Discuss maritime and coastal security challenges and the way forward.	2025	15
	What are the maritime security challenges in India? Discuss the organisational, technical and procedural initiatives taken to improve the maritime security.	2022	10
	In 2012, the longitudinal marking of the high-risk areas for piracy was moved from 65° East to 78° east in the Arabian Sea by International Maritime organisation. What impact does this have on India's maritime security concerns?	2014	



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Organized Crime and Terrorism	Terrorism is a global scourge. How has it manifested in India? Elaborate with contemporary examples. What are the counter measures adopted by the State? Explain.	2025	10
	Explain how narco-terrorism has emerged as a serious threat across the country. Suggest suitable measures to counter narco-terrorism.	2024	10
	Give out the major sources of terror funding in India and the efforts being made to curtail these sources. In the light of this, also discuss the aim and objective of the 'No Money for Terror (NMFT)' Conference recently held at New Delhi in November 2022.	2023	15
	Winning of 'Hearts and Minds' in terrorism-affected areas is an essential step in restoring the trust of the population. Discuss the measures adopted by the Government in this respect as part of the conflict resolution in Jammu and Kashmir.	2023	10
	Discuss the types of organised crimes. Describe the linkages between terrorists and organised crime that exist at the national and transnational levels.	2022	10
	Analyse the complexity and intensity of terrorism, its causes, linkages and obnoxious nexus. Also, suggest measures required to be taken to eradicate the menace of terrorism	2021	15
	The banning of 'Jamaat-e – islaami' in Jammu and Kashmir brought into focus the role of over-ground workers (OGWs) in assisting terrorist organizations. Examine the role played by OGWs in assisting terrorist organizations in insurgency affected areas. Discuss measures to neutralize the influence of OGWs.	2019	
	The scourge of terrorism is a grave challenge to national security. What solutions do you suggest to curb this growing menace? What are the major sources of terrorist funding?	2017	
	The terms 'Hot Pursuit' and 'Surgical Strikes' are often used in connection with armed action against terrorist attacks. Discuss the strategic impact of such actions.	2016	12.5
	Terrorism is emerging as a competitive industry over the last few decades. Analyse the above statement.	2016	12.5

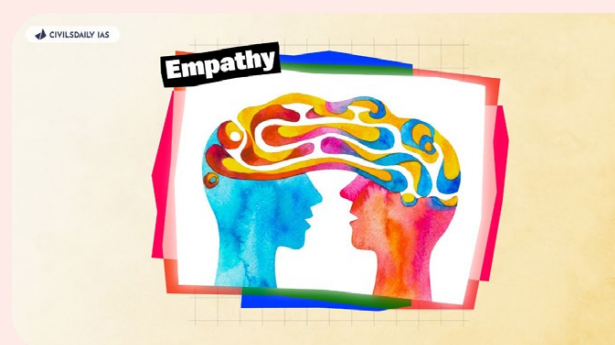
Internal Security

24. Various Security Forces and Agencies and their Mandate.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Land Reform x Act Based	Indian government has recently strengthened the anti-terrorism laws by amending the unlawful activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), 1967 and the NIA Act. Analyze the changes in the context of prevailing security environment while discussing the scope and reasons for opposing the UAPA by human rights organizations.	2019	
	Human rights activists constantly highlight the view that the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA) is a draconian act leading to cases of human rights abuses by the security forces. What sections of AFSPA are opposed by the activists? Critically evaluate the requirement with reference to the view held by the Apex Court.	2015	
Security Forces mandate	What are the internal security challenges being faced by India? Give out the role of Central Intelligence and Investigative Agencies tasked to counter such threats.	2023	15
	Analyze internal security threats and transborder crimes along Myanmar, Bangladesh and Pakistan borders including Line of Control (LoC). Also discuss the role played by various security forces in this regard	2020	15

GS-IV

1. Ethics and Human Interface: Essence, Determinants and Consequences of Ethics in - Human Actions; Dimensions of Ethics; Ethics - in Private and Public Relationships.
2. Human Values: Lessons from the Lives and Teachings of Great Leaders, Reformers and Administrators; Role of family society and educational institutions in inculcating values.
3. Attitude: Content, Structure, Function; its Influence and Relation with Thought and Behaviour; Moral and Political Attitudes; Social Influence and Persuasion.
4. Emotional intelligence-concepts, and their utilities and application in administration and governance.
5. Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers from India and World
6. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service, Integrity, Impartiality and Non-partisanship, Objectivity, Dedication to Public Service, Empathy, Tolerance and compassion towards weaker-sections
7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration: Status and Problems; Ethical Concerns and Dilemmas in Government and Private Institutions; Laws, Rules, Regulations and Conscience as Sources of Ethical Guidance; Accountability and Ethical Governance; Strengthening of Ethical and Moral Values in Governance; ethical Issues in International Relations and Funding; Corporate Governance
8. Probity in Governance: Concept of Public Service; Philosophical Basis of Governance and Probity; Information Sharing and Transparency in Government, Right to information; Codes of Ethics, Codes of Conduct, Citizen's Charters, Work Culture, Quality of Service Delivery, utilization of Public Funds, Challenges of Corruption.





GS 4 Year-wise PYQ Analysis

Syllabus	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Total
1.Ethics and Human Interface: Essence, Determinants and Consequences of Ethics in - Human Actions; Dimensions of Ethics; Ethics - in Private and Public Relationships.	5	4	2	1	4	2		3	1	3	1	5	2	33
2. Human Values: Lessons from the Lives and Teachings of Great Leaders, Reformers and Administrators; Role of family society and educational institutions in inculcating values.		3	1	1	1			3			2		1	12
3.Attitude: Content, Structure, Function; its Influence and Relation with Thought and Behaviour; Moral and Political Attitudes; Social Influence and Persuasion.		1	1	3	2			2	1	2	1	1	2	16
4.Emotional intelligence-concepts, and their utilities and application in administration and governance.	1				1		1	1	1		1			6
5.Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers from India and World	3		2	2	1	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	32
6.Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service, Integrity, Impartiality and Non-partisanship, Objectivity, Dedication to Public Service, Empathy, Tolerance and compassion towards weaker-sections	1	1	1	1	1	2			4	1				12
7.Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration: Status and Problems; Ethical Concerns and Dilemmas in Government and Private Institutions; Laws, Rules, Regulations and Conscience as Sources of Ethical Guidance; Accountability and Ethical Governance; Strengthening of Ethical and Moral Values in Governance; ethical Issues in International Relations and Funding; Corporate Governance	2	1	3	3	3	4	5	1	3	3	4	3	3	38
8.Probity in Governance: Concept of Public Service; Philosophical Basis of Governance and Probity; Information Sharing and Transparency in Government, Right to information; Codes of Ethics, Codes of Conduct, Citizen's Charters, Work Culture, Quality of Service Delivery, utilization of Public Funds, Challenges of Corruption.		3	2	1		2	4			1	1	1	2	17
Grand Total	12	13	12	12	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	166



Ethics

01. Ethics and Human Interface: Essence, Determinants and Consequences of Ethics in - Human Actions; Dimensions of Ethics; Ethics - in Private and Public Relationships.



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Applied Ethics x Environment	Q2 (b) Keeping the national security in mind, examine the ethical dilemmas related to controversies over environmental clearance of development projects in ecologically sensitive border areas in the country.	2025	
	Global warming and climate change are the outcomes of human greed in the name of development, indicating the direction in which extinction of organisms including human beings is heading towards loss of life on Earth. How do you put an end to this to protect life and bring equilibrium between the society and the environment ?	2024	10
	Suppose the Government of India is thinking of constructing a dam in a mountain valley bound by forests and inhabited by ethnic communities. What rational policy should it resort to in dealing with unforeseen contingencies?	2018	10
	What is meant by 'environmental ethics'? Why is it important to study? Discuss any one environmental issue from the viewpoint of environmental ethics.	2015	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Applied Ethics x Tech	Q1 (a) In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and interaction. However, it has raised several ethical issues and challenges. Describe the key ethical dilemmas in this regard.	2025	
	The application of Artificial Intelligence as a dependable source of input for administrative rational decision-making is a debatable issue. Critically examine the statement from the ethical point of view.	2024	10
	Online methodology is being used for day-to-day meetings, institutional approvals in the administration and for teaching and learning in education sector to the extent telemedicine in the health sector is getting popular with the approvals of the competent authority. No doubt it has advantages and disadvantages for both the beneficiaries and system at large. Describe and discuss the ethical issues involved in the use of online method particularly to vulnerable section of society.	2022	10
	Impact of digital technology as a reliable source of input for rational decision making is a debatable issue. Critically evaluate with a suitable example.	2021	10
	The current internet expansion has instilled a different set of cultural values which are in conflict with traditional values. Discuss..	2020	10
Determinants of Ethics	"The concept of Just and Unjust is contextual. What was just a year back, may turn out to be unjust in today's context. Changing context should be constantly under scrutiny to prevent miscarriage of justice." Examine the above statement with suitable examples.	2024	10
	"Ethics encompasses several key dimensions that are crucial in guiding individuals and organizations towards morally responsible behaviour." Explain the key dimensions of ethics that influence human actions Discuss how these dimensions shape ethical decision-making in the professional context.	2024	10
	Without commonly shared and widely entrenched moral values and obligations, neither the law, nor democratic government, nor even the market economy will function properly. What do you understand by this statement? Explain with illustration in the contemporary times.	2017	10
	Some people feel that values keep changing with time and situation, while others strongly believe that there are certain universal and eternal human values. Give your perception in this regard with due justification.	2013	10
Essence of Ethics	Distinguish between laws and rules. Discuss the role of ethics in formulating them..	2020	10
	It is often said that 'politics' and 'ethics' do not go together. What is your opinion in this regard? Justify your answer with illustrations.	2013	10
Ethics in Private and Public sphere	In the context of defence services, 'patriotism' demands readiness to even lay down one's life in protecting the nation. According to you, what does patriotism imply in everyday civil life? Explain with illustrations and justify your answer.	2014	10
	What does ethics seek to promote in human life? Why is it all the more important in public administration?	2014	10
	What do you understand by 'values' and 'ethics'? In what way is it important to be ethical along with being professionally competent?	2013	10
	The good of an individual is contained in the good of all. What do you understand by this statement? How can this principle be implemented in public life?	2013	10
Ethics x Consequences	It is believed that adherence to ethics in human actions would ensure in smooth functioning of an organization/system. If so, what does ethics seek to promote in human life? How do ethical values assist in the resolution of conflicts faced by him in his day-to-day functioning?	2022	10
	Discuss the role of ethics and values in enhancing the following three major components of Comprehensive National Power(CNP)viz. human capital, soft power(culture and policies), and social harmony.	2020	10
	Increased national wealth did not result in equitable distribution of its benefits. It has created only some "enclaves of modernity and prosperity for a small minority at the cost of the majority." Justify.	2017	10
	Explain how ethics contributes to social and human well-being.	2016	10
	The current society is plagued with widespread trust-deficit. What are the consequences of this situation for personal well-being and for societal well-being? What can you do at the personal level to make yourself trustworthy?	2014	10



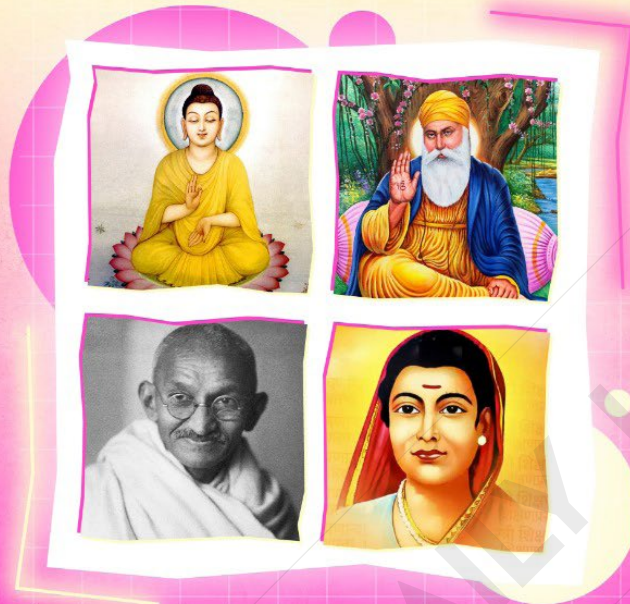
Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Normative Ethics (Deontology vs Teleology)	With regard to morality of actions, one view is that means are of paramount importance and the other view is that the ends justify the means. Which view do you think is more appropriate? Justify your answer.	2018	10
	Human beings should always be treated as 'ends' in themselves and never as merely 'means'. Explain the meaning and significance of this statement, giving its implications in the modern techno-economic society.	2014	10
Term Based	Differentiate 'moral intuition' from 'moral reasoning' with suitable examples.	2023	10
	Write short notes on the following in 30 words each : (i) Constitutional morality (ii) Conflict of interest (iii) Probity in public life (iv) Challenges of digitalization (v) Devotion to duty	2022	10
	Examine the relevance of the following in the context of civil service: (a) Transparency (b) Accountability (c) Fairness and justice (d) Courage of conviction (e) Spirit of service.	2017	10
	Differentiate between the following; a) Law and Ethics; b) Ethical management and Management of ethics; c) Discrimination and Preferential treatment; d) Personal ethics and Professional ethics	2015	10
	What do you understand by the following terms in the context of public service? (5 terms x 3 marks each: a) Integrity b) Perseverance c) Spirit of service d) Commitment e) Courage of conviction f) Personal opinion	2013	15



Ethics

02. Human Values: Lessons from the Lives and Teachings of Great Leaders, Reformers and Administrators; Role of family society and educational institutions in inculcating values.

CIVILDAILY IAS



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Crisis of Ethical Values	“Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society.” In your opinion, what measures can be adopted to uplift the core values in the society?	2023	10
	The crisis of ethical values in modern times is traced to a narrow perception of the good life. Discuss.	2017	10
	We are witnessing increasing instances of sexual violence against women in the country. Despite existing legal provisions against it, the number of such incidences is on the rise. Suggest some innovative measures to tackle this menace.	2014	10
Nature of Values	Social values are more important than economic values. Discuss the above statement with examples in the context of inclusive growth of a nation.	2015	10
	All human beings aspire for happiness. Do you agree? What does happiness mean to you? Explain with examples.	2014	10
Role of Educational institutions	“Education is not an injunction, it is an effective and pervasive tool for all-round development of an individual and social transformation”.Examine the New Education Policy,2020(NEP,2020)in light of the above statement.	2020	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Teachings of Great Leaders	Q4 (b) What are the major teachings of Mahavir? Explain their relevance in the contemporary world.	2025	
	What were the major teachings of Guru Nanak? Explain their relevance in the contemporary world.	2023	10
	What are the main factors responsible for gender inequality in India? Discuss the contribution of Savitribai Phule in this regard..	2020	10
	What teachings of Buddha are most relevant today and why? Discuss.	2020	10
	"Great ambition is the passion of a great character. Those endowed with it may perform very good or very bad acts. All depends on the principles which direct them." – Napoleon Bonaparte. Stating examples mention the rulers (i) who have harmed society and country, (ii) who worked for the development of society and country.	2017	10
	Discuss Mahatma Gandhi's concept of seven sins.	2016	10
	Which eminent personality has inspired you the most in the context of ethical conduct in life? Give the gist of his/her teachings giving specific examples, describe how you have been able to apply these teachings for your own ethical development.	2014	10

Ethics

03. Attitude: Content, Structure, Function; its Influence and Relation with Thought and Behaviour; Moral and Political Attitudes; Social Influence and Persuasion.

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Attitude for Civil Servants	Q5 (b) To achieve holistic development goal, a civil servant acts as an enabler and active facilitator of growth rather than a regulator. What specific measures would you suggest to achieve this goal?	2025	
	Attitude is an important component that goes as input in the development of human beings. How to build a suitable attitude needed for a public servant?	2021	10
	A positive attitude is considered to be an essential characteristic of a civil servant who is often required to function under extreme stress. What contributes a positive attitude in person.?	2020	10
	Our attitudes towards life, work, other people and society are generally shaped unconsciously by the family and social surroundings in which we grow up. Some of these unconsciously acquired attitudes and values are often undesirable in the citizens of modern democratic and egalitarian society. (a) Discuss such undesirable values prevalent in today's educated Indians. (b) How can such undesirable attitudes be changed and socio-ethical values be cultivated in the aspiring and serving civil servants?	2016	10
Attitude for Individuals	'Hatred is destructive of a person's wisdom and conscience that can poison a nation's spirit. Do you agree with this view? Justify your answer.	2020	10
	What factors affect the formation of a person's attitude towards social problems? In our society, contrasting attitudes are prevalent about many social problems. What contrasting attitudes do you notice about the caste system in our society? How do you explain the existence of these contrasting attitudes?	2014	10
Attitude x Practical intelligence	Mindless addiction to Form, ignoring the Substance of the matter, results in rendering of injustice. A perceptive civil servant is one who ignores such literalness and carries out true intent. Examine the above statement with suitable illustrations.	2024	10
	The Rules and Regulations provided to all the civil servants are same, yet there is difference in the performance. Positive minded officers are able to interpret the Rules and Regulations in favour of the case and achieve success, whereas negative minded officers are unable to achieve goals by interpreting the same Rules and Regulations against the case. Discuss with illustrations.	2022	10
	Two different kinds of attitudes exhibited by public servants towards their work have been identified as the bureaucratic attitude and the democratic attitude. A) Distinguish between these two terms and write their merits and demerits. B) Is it possible to balance the two to create a better administration for the faster development of our country?	2015	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Moral and Political Attitude	Young people with ethical conduct are not willing to come forward to join active politics. Suggest steps to motivate them to come forward.	2017	10
Organisational Attitude	In the context of work environment, differentiate between 'coercion' and 'undue influence' with suitable examples.	2023	10
	Discipline generally implies following the order and subordination. However, it may be counter-productive for the organisation. Discuss.	2017	10
Social influence and persuasion	Q4 (a) "For any kind of social re-engineering by successfully implementing welfare schemes, a civil servant must use reason and critical thinking in an ethical framework." Justify this statement with suitable examples.	2025	
	How could social influence and persuasion contribute to the success of Swatchh Bharat Abhiyan?	2016	10

CIVILSDAILY IAS





Ethics

04. Emotional intelligence-concepts, and their utilities and application in administration and governance.



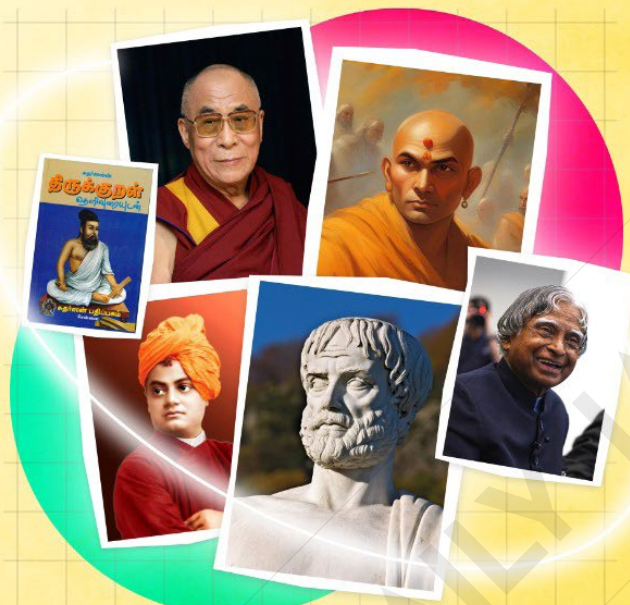
Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
El x Administration	How will you apply emotional intelligence in administrative practices?	2017	10
EI: Concept and Utility	What are the main components of emotional intelligence (EI) ? Can they be learned? discuss.	2020	10
	"Emotional Intelligence is the ability to make your emotions work for you instead of against you." Do you agree with this view? Discuss.	2019	10
	Anger is a harmful negative emotion. It is injurious to both personal life and work life. (a) Discuss how it leads to negative emotions and undesirable behaviours. (b) How can it be managed and controlled?	2016	10
	What is 'emotional intelligence' and how can it be developed in people? How does it help an individual in taking ethical decisions?	2013	10
El x Crisis of Conscience	In case of a crisis of conscience does emotional intelligence help to overcome the same without compromising the ethical and moral stand that you are likely to follow? Critically examine.	2021	10
EQ vs IQ	What really matters for success, character, happiness and lifelong achievements is a definite set of emotional skills – your EQ- not just purely cognitive abilities that are measured by conventional IQ tests." Do you agree with this view ? Give reasons in support of your answer.	2023	10



Ethics

05. Contributions of Moral Thinkers and Philosophers from India and World

CIVILSDAILY IAS



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Quote-based x Abdul Kalam	"If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. They are the father, the mother and the teacher." – Abdul Kalam.	2022	10
	"Where there is righteousness in the heart, there is beauty in the character. When there is beauty in the character, there is harmony in the home. When there is harmony in the home, there is order in the nation. When there is order in the nation, there is peace in the world." – A.P.J. Abdul Kalam	2019	10
	"If a country is to be corruption free and become a nation of beautiful minds, I strongly feel there are three key societal members who can make a difference. they are father, the mother and the teacher." – A. P. J. Abdul Kalam. Analyse.	2017	10
Quote-based x Abraham Lincoln	The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject any thing, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good. There are few things wholly evil or wholly good. Almost every thing, especially of governmental policy, is an inseparable compound of the two; so that our best judgement of the preponderance between them is continually demand. - Abraham Lincoln.	2018	10
	Nearly all men can withstand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power.—Abraham Lincoln	2013	10
Quote-based x Aristotle	I count him braver who overcomes his desires than him who overcomes his enemies.—Aristotle	2013	10
Quote-based x Dalai Lama	"Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it." Dalai Lama.	2022	10
	"We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves" – Dalai Lama	2021	10
Quote-based x Erik Erikson	"Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that it is better for us all" – Erik Erikson	2021	10
Quote-based x Immanuel Kant	"In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so." — Immanuel Kant	2024	10



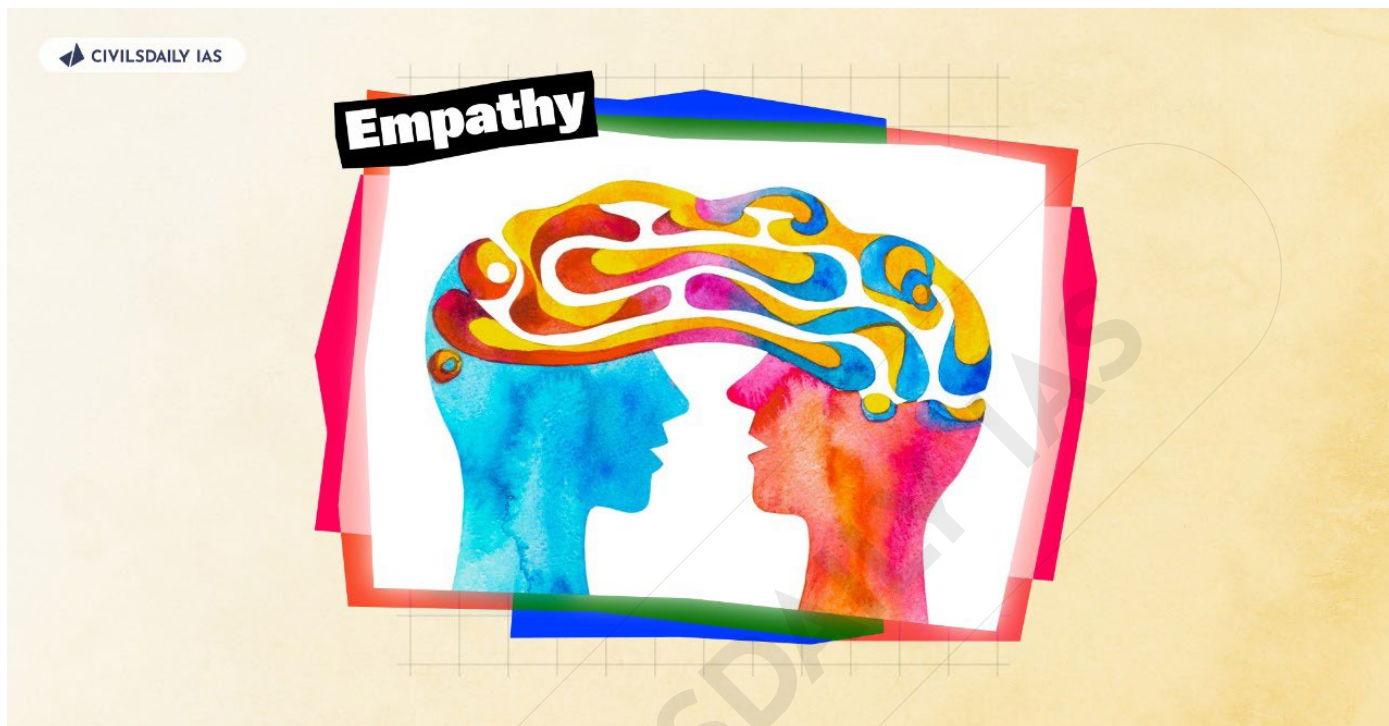


Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Quote-based x Jawaharlal Nehru	(b) "To awaken the people, it is the women who must be awakened. Ones she is on the move, the family moves, the village moves, the nation moves." – Jawaharlal Nehru	2023	10
Quote-based x John Rawls	Analyse John Rawls's concept of social justice in the Indian context.	2016	10
Quote-based x Kautilya	Corruption causes misuse of government treasury, Administrative inefficiency and obstruction in the path of national Development. Discuss Kautilya's views.	2016	10
Quote-Based x Mahatma Gandhi	(a) "The simplest acts of kindness are by far more powerful than a thousand heads bowing in prayer." – Mahatma Gandhi	2023	10
	"The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in service of others ." Mahatma Gandhi.	2020	10
	"A man is but the product of his thoughts. What he thinks, he becomes." – M.K.Gandhi	2019	10
	Anger and intolerance are the enemies of correct understanding. -Mahatma Gandhi	2018	10
	"The weak can never forgive; forgiveness is the attribute of the strong."	2015	10
	There is enough on this earth for every one's need but for no one's greed. Mahatma Gandhi.	2013	10
Quote-based x Plato	We can easily forgive a child who is afraid of the dark; the real tragedy of life is when men are afraid of the light.	2015	10
Quote-based x Potter Stewart	Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have the right to do and what is right to do.'-Potter Stewart .	2022	10
Quote-based x Sardar Patel	"Faith is of no avail in the absence of strength. Faith and strength, both are essential to accomplish any great work." – Sardar Patel	2024	10
Quote-based x Socrates	"A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true." – Socrates..	2020	10
	"An unexamined life is not worth living." – Socrates	2019	10
Quote-based x Swami Vivekananda	Q3 (c) "The strength of a society is not in its laws, but in the morality of its people." – Swami Vivekananda (Answer in 150 words, 10 marks)	2025	
	"Learn everything that is good from others, but bring it in, and in your own way absorb it, do not become others." – Swami Vivekananda	2024	10
	(c) Do not hate anybody, because that hatred that comes out from you must, in the long run, come back to you. If you love, that love will come back to you, completing the circle." – Swami Vivekanand.	2023	10
	"Every work has got to pass through hundreds of difficulties before succeeding. Those that persevere will see the light, sooner or later" – Swami Vivekananda	2021	10
	"Condemn none: if you can stretch out a helping hand do so. If not fold your hands, bless your brothers and let them go their own way." – Swami Vivekanand.	2020	10
Quote-based x Tirukkural	Q3 (a) "Those who in trouble untroubled are, Will trouble trouble itself." – Thiruvalluvar (Answer in 150 words, 10 marks)	2025	
	Falsehood takes the place of truth when it results in unblemished common good. -Tirukkural	2018	10
Quote-based x William James	Q3 (b) "The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes." – William James (Answer in 150 words, 10 marks)	2025	



Ethics

06. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service, Integrity, Impartiality and Non-partisanship, Objectivity, Dedication to Public Service, Empathy, Tolerance and compassion towards weaker-sections



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Empathy and Compassion	Apart from intellectual competency and moral qualities, empathy and compassion are some of the other vital attributes that facilitate the civil servants to be more competent in tackling the crucial issues or taking critical decisions. Explain with suitable illustrations.	2022	10
Foundational values	Identify ten essential values that are needed to be an effective public servant. Describe the ways and means to prevent non-ethical behaviour in public servants.	2021	10
	Identify five ethical traits on which one can plot the performance of a civil servant. Justify their inclusion in the matrix.	2021	10
	What do you understand by the term 'public servant'? Reflect on the expected role of a public servant.	2019	10
	What are the basic principles of public life? Illustrate any three of these with suitable examples.	2019	10
	State the three basic values, universal in nature, in the context of civil services and bring out their importance.	2018	10
	Indicate two more attributes which you consider important for public service. Justify your answer. (10 marks 100 words)	2013	10
Impartiality and Non-Partisanship	Should impartial and being non-partisan be considered indispensable qualities to make a successful civil servant? Discuss with illustrations.	2021	10
	Why should impartiality and non-partisanship be considered as foundational values in public services, especially in the present day socio-political context? Illustrate your answer with examples.	2016	10





Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Integrity	"Integrity is a value that empowers the human being". Justify with suitable illustration.	2021	10
	One of the tests of integrity is complete refusal to be compromised. Explain with reference to a real life example.	2017	10
	Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful. What do you understand by this statement? Explain your stand with illustrations from the modern context.	2014	10
Integrity x Intelligence x Energy	In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence and energy. And if they do not have the first, the other two will you. - Warren Buffett. What do you understand by this statement in the present-day scenario? Explain.	2018	10
Trustworthiness and Fortitude	How do the virtues of trustworthiness and fortitude get manifested in public service? Explain with examples.	2015	10

CIVILSDAILY IAS





Ethics

07. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Accountability and Ethical Governance	Explain the term social capital. How does it enhance good governance?	2023	10
	What do you understand by term 'good governance'? How far recent initiatives in terms of e-Governance steps taken by the State have helped the beneficiaries? Discuss with suitable examples.	2022	10
	An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including the judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate.	2021	10
	What do you understand by the terms 'governance', 'good governance' and 'ethical governance'?	2016	10
	What does 'accountability' mean in the context of public service? What measures can be adopted to ensure individual and collective accountability of public servants?	2014	10
Conflict of Interest	What is meant by conflict of interest? Illustrate with examples, the difference between the actual and potential conflicts of interest.	2018	10
	Conflict of interest in the public sector arises when (a) official duties, (b) public interest, and (c) personal interest are taking priority one above the other. How can this conflict in administration be resolved? Describe with an example.	2017	10
	Public servants are likely to confront with the issues of 'Conflict of Interest'. What do you understand by the term 'Conflict of Interest' and how does it manifest in the decision making by public servants? If faced with the conflict of interest situation, how would you resolve it? Explain with the help of examples.	2015	10
Constitutional Morality	Q1 (b) "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration.	2025	
	What is meant by constitutional morality? How does one uphold constitutional morality?	2019	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Corporate Governance	What do you understand by 'moral integrity' and 'professional efficiency' in the context of corporate governance in India ? Illustrate with suitable examples.	2023	10
	In contemporary world, corporate sector's contribution in generating wealth and employment is increasing. In doing so, they are bringing in unprecedented onslaught on the climate, environmental sustainability and living conditions of human beings. In this background, do you find that Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) is efficient and sufficient enough to fulfill the social roles and responsibilities needed in the corporate world for which the CSR is mandated? Critically examine.	2022	10
	Corporate social responsibility makes companies more profitable and sustainable. Analyse.	2017	10
Ethical Dilemma Resolution	Besides domain knowledge, a public official needs innovativeness and creativity of a high order as well, while resolving ethical dilemmas. Discuss with a suitable example.	2021	10
	Explain the process of resolving ethical dilemmas in Public Administration.	2018	10
Ethical Issues in International Relations and funding	Carl von Clausewitz once said, "War is a diplomacy by other means." Critically analyse the above statement in the present context of contemporary geo-political conflict.	2025	
	"It is not enough to talk about peace, one must believe in it; and it is not enough to believe in it, one must act upon it" In the present context, the major weapon industries of the developed nations are adversely influencing continuation of number of wars for their own self-interest, all around the world. What are the ethical considerations of the powerful nations in today's international arena to stop continuation of ongoing conflicts?	2024	10
	'International aid' is an accepted form of helping 'resource-challenged' nations. Comment on 'ethics in contemporary international aid'. Support your answer with suitable examples.	2023	10
	Russia and Ukraine war has been going on for the last seven months. Different countries have taken independent stands and actions keeping in view their own national interests. We are all aware that war has its own impact on the different aspects of society, including human tragedy. What are those ethical issues that are crucial to be considered while launching the war and its continuation so far? Illustrate with justification the ethical issues involved in the given state of affair.	2022	10
	"Refugees should not be turned back to the country where they would face prosecution or human rights violation." Examine the statement with reference to the ethical dimension being violated by the nation claiming to be democratic with an open society.	2021	10
	'The will to power exits, but it can be tamed and be guided by rationality and principles of moral duty.' Examine this statement in the context of international relations.	2020	10
	Strength, peace and security are considered to be the pillars of international relations. Elucidate.	2017	10
	At the international level, the bilateral relations between most nations are governed on the policy of promoting one's own national interest without any regard for the interest of other nations. This leads to conflicts and tensions between the nations. How can ethical consideration help resolve such tensions? Discuss with specific examples.	2015	10
Laws, Rules, Regulations, Conscience	The soul of the new law, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) is Justice, Equality and Impartiality based on Indian culture and ethos. Discuss this in the light of major shift from a doctrine of punishment to justice in the present judicial system.	2024	10
	Is conscience a more reliable guide when compared to laws, rules and regulations in the context of ethical decision making ? Discuss.	2023	10
	What is meant by 'crisis of conscience'? How does it manifest itself in the public domain?	2019	10
	Law and ethics are considered to be the two tools for controlling human conduct so as to make it conducive to civilized social existence. (a) Discuss how they achieve this objective. (b) Giving examples, show how the two differ in their approaches.	2016	10
	A mere compliance with law is not enough, the public servant also has to have a well-developed sensibility to ethical issues for effective discharge of duties." Do you agree? Explain with the help of two examples, where (i) an act is ethically right, but not legally and (ii) an act is legally right, but not ethically.	2015	10
	What do you understand by the term 'voice of conscience'? How do you prepare yourself to heed to the voice of conscience?	2013	10
	What is meant by 'crisis of conscience'? Narrate one incident in your life when you were faced with such a crisis and how you resolved the same.	2013	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Public/Civil Service Values	Q5 (a) "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant.	2025	
	"Non-performance of duty by a public servant is a form of corruption" Do you agree with this view? Justify your answer	2019	10
	In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication. Examine the statement with suitable examples in the context of a public servant discharging his/her duties.	2018	10
	What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by the civil servants in public interest?	2018	10
	Max Weber said that it is not wise to apply to public administration the sort of moral and ethical norms we apply to matters of personal conscience. It is important to realise that the State bureaucracy might possess its own independent bureaucratic morality. Critically analyse this statement.	2016	10

Ethics

08. Probity in Governance

Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Citizens Charter	Explain the basic principles of citizens' charter movement and bring out its importance.	2019	10
Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct	The 'Code of Conduct and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable mode. for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency. governance.	2024	10
	Distinguish between "Code of ethics" and "Code of conduct" with suitable examples.	2018	10
	Discuss the Public Services Code as recommended by the 2nd Administrative Reforms Commission.	2016	10
Corruption	Whistle blower, who reports corruption and illegal activities, wrongdoing and misconduct to the concerned authorities, runs the risk of being exposed to grave danger, physical harm and victimization by the vested interests, accused persons and his team. What policy measures would you suggest to strengthen protection mechanism to safeguard the whistle blower?	2022	10
	It is often said that poverty leads to corruption. However, there is no dearth of instances where affluent and powerful people indulge in corruption in a big way. What are the basic causes of corruption among people? Support your answer with examples.	2014	10
Probity	"In Indian culture and value system, an equal opportunity has been provided irrespective of gender identity. The number of women in public service has been steadily increasing over the years." Examine the gender specific challenges faced by female public servants and suggest to increase their efficiency in discharging their duties and maintaining high standards of probity.	2024	10
	'Probity is essential for an effective system of governance and socio-economic development.' Discuss.	2023	10
	What do you understand by probity in governance? Based on your understanding of the term, suggest measures for ensuring probity in government.	2019	10
	What do you understand by 'probity' in public life? What are the difficulties in practicing it in the present times? How can these difficulties be overcome?	2014	10



Microthemes	UPSC PYQs	Year	Marks
Quality of Service Delivery	Mission Karmayogi is aiming for maintaining a very high standard of conduct and behaviour to ensure efficiency for serving citizens and in developing oneself. How will this scheme empower the civil servants in enhancing productive efficiency and delivering the services at the grassroots level?	2024	10
	Wisdom lies in knowing what to reckon with and what to overlook. An officer being engrossed with the periphery, ignoring the core issues before him, is no rare in the bureaucracy. Do you agree that such preoccupation of an administrator leads to travesty of justice to the cause of effective service delivery and good governance? Critically evaluate.	2022	10
RTI	There is a view that the official secrets act is an obstacle to the implementation of the Rights to Information act. Do you agree with the view? Discuss	2019	10
	The Right to Information Act is not all about citizens' empowerment alone, it essentially redefines the concept of accountability. Discuss.	2018	10
	Today we find that in spite of various measures like prescribing codes of conduct, setting up vigilance cells/commissions, RTI, active media and strengthening of legal mechanisms, corrupt practices are not coming under control. A) Evaluate the effectiveness of these measures with justifications. B) Suggest more effective strategies to tackle this menace.	2015	10
	Some recent developments such as introduction of RTI Act, media and judicial activism, etc., are proving helpful in bringing about greater transparency and accountability in the functioning of the government. However, it is also being observed that at times the mechanisms are misused. Another negative effect is that the officers are now afraid to take prompt decisions. Analyze this situation in detail and suggest how this dichotomy can be resolved. Suggest how these negative impacts can be minimized.	2015	10
Utilization of Public Funds	Q6 (b) India is an emerging economic power of the world as it has recently secured the status of fourth largest economy of the world as per IMF projection. However, it has been observed that in some sectors, allocated funds remain either under-utilised or misutilised. What specific measures would you recommend for ensuring accountability in this regard to stop leakages and gaining the status of third largest economy of the world in near future?	2025	
	Effective utilisation of public funds is crucial to meet development goals. Critically examine the reasons for under-utilization and mis-utilisation of public funds and their implications.	2019	10
	There is a heavy ethical responsibility on the public servants because they occupy positions of power, handle huge amounts of public funds, and their decisions have wide-ranging impact on society and environment. What steps have you taken to improve your ethical competence to handle such responsibility?	2014	10
Work Culture	Q6 (a) It is said that for an ethical work culture, there must be code of ethics in place in every organisation. To ensure value-based and compliance-based work culture, what suitable measures would you adopt in your work place?	2025	



Ethics

Case Studies

CIVILSDAILY IAS



UPSC MAINS 2025

[Case Study 1] Vijay is the Deputy Commissioner of a remote district of Himachal Pradesh. For the last two years, he has been in this region. In the month of August, heavy rains lashed the complete state followed by cloudbursts in the upper reaches of the said district. The damage was very heavy in the complete state, especially in the affected district. The complete road network and telecommunication were disrupted and the buildings were damaged extensively. People's houses have been destroyed and they were forced to stay in open. More than 200 people have been killed and about 5000 were badly injured. The Civil Administration under Vijay got activated and started conducting rescue and relief operations. Temporary shelter camps and hospitals were established to provide shelter and medical facilities to the homeless and injured people. Helicopter services were pressed in for evacuating sick and old people from remote areas. Vijay got a message from his hometown in Kerala that his mother was seriously sick. After two days, Vijay received the unfortunate message that his mother has expired. Vijay has no close relative except one elder sister who is a US citizen and has been staying there for the last several years. In the meantime, the situation in the affected district deteriorated further due to resumption of heavy rains after a gap of five days. At the same time, continuous messages were coming on his mobile from his hometown to reach at the earliest for performing the last rites of his mother.

(a) What are the options available with Vijay?

(b) What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by Vijay?

(c) Critically evaluate and examine each of these options identified by Vijay.

(d) Which of the options, do you think, would be most appropriate for Vijay to adopt and why?

[UPSC 2025, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface
| Theme: profession vs personal duty

[Case Study 2] In line with the Directive Principles of State Policy enshrined in the Indian Constitution, the government has a constitutional obligation to ensure basic needs – Roti, Kapda aur Makan (Food, Clothes and Shelter) – for the underprivileged. Pursuing this mandate, the district administration proposed clearing a portion of forest land to develop housing for the homeless and economically weaker sections of the society.

The proposed land, however, is an ecologically sensitive zone densely populated with age-old trees, medicinal plants and vital biodiversity. Besides, these forests help to regulate micro-climate and rainfalls, provide habitat for wildlife, support soil fertility and prevent land/soil erosion and sustain livelihoods of tribal and nomadic communities.

In spite of the ecological and social costs, the administration argues in favour of the said proposal by highlighting that this very initiative addresses fundamental human rights as a critical welfare priority. Besides, it fulfils the government's duty to uplift & em-



power the poor through inclusive housing development. Further, these forest areas have become unsafe due to wild-animal threats and recurring human-wildlife conflicts. Lastly, clearing forest-zones may help to curb anti-social elements allegedly using these areas as hideouts, thereby enhancing law and order.

- Can deforestation be ethically justified in the pursuit of social welfare objectives like, housing for the homeless?
- What are the socio-economic, administrative and ethical challenges in balancing environmental conservation with human development?
- What substantial alternatives or policy interventions can be proposed to ensure that both environmental integrity and human dignity are protected?

[UPSC 2025, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface
Theme: Environmental ethics

[Case Study 3] Subhash is Secretary, PWD in the State Government. He is a senior officer, known for his competence, integrity and dedication to work. He enjoys the trust and confidence of Minister incharge of PWD and Programme Implementation. As a part of his job profile, he is responsible for policy formulations, execution of projects relating to infrastructure initiatives in the State. Besides, he oversees the technical and administrative aspects relating to planning, designing and construction etc. Subhash's Minister is an important Minister in the state and significant growth in urban infrastructure development and road network has been registered during his tenure. He is very keen for launching of ambitious road construction project in the near future. Subhash is in regular touch with the Minister and is working various modalities of road construction project. Regular meetings, interactions and presentations are made by him to the Minister based on a formal public announcement of the project is made by the Minister. Subhash's only son Vikas is in real estate business. His son from his own sources is aware that a mega road project is on the anvil and announcement in this regard is expected anytime. He is very keen to know from his father the exact location of the upcoming project. He knows that there would be quantum jump in the prices of land in the vicinity. Buying land at this stage at cheaper prices would pay him rich dividends. He is pleading with him (his father) day in and day out to share him location of the proposed project. He assured him that he would handle the matter discreetly as it would not attract any adverse notice as he in the normal course, keeps on buying land as a part of his business. He feels pressurised because of constant pleadings by his son. Another significant aspect of the matter pertained to the extra/undue interest in the above project by the Minister PWD. His nephew was also having big infrastructure project company. In fact, the Minister has also introduced his nephew to him and indicated to him to take care of his nephew's business interest in the forthcoming project. The Minister encouraged him to act fast in the matter as early announcement and execution of mega road project would enhance his status in the party and public life. In the above backdrop, Subhash is in a fix as to the future course of action.

- Discuss the ethical issues involved in the case.
- Critically examine the options available to Subhash in the above situation?
- Which of the above would be most appropriate and why??

[UPSC 2025, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption

[Case Study 4] "Rajesh is a Group A officer with nine years of service. He is posted as Administrative Officer in an Oil Public Sector undertaking. As an Administrative Officer he is responsible for managing and coordinating various administrative tasks to ensure smooth functioning of office. He also manages office supplies, equipment etc. Rajesh is now sufficient senior and is expecting his next promotion in JAG (Junior Administrative Grade) in the next one or two years. He knows that promotion is based on examination of ACRs/Performance Appraisal of last few years (5 years or so) of an officer by a DPC (Departmental Promotion Committee) and an officer lacking requisite grading of ACRs may not be found fit for promotion. Consequences of losing promotion may entail financial and reputational loss and set-back for career progression. Though he also puts his best efforts in official discharge of his duties, yet he is unsure of assessment by his superior officer. He is now putting extra efforts so that he gets thumping report at the end of financial year. As Administrative Officer, Rajesh is regularly interacting with his immediate boss, who is his reporting officer for writing his ACR. One day he calls Rajesh and wants him to buy computer-related stationery on priority from a particular vendor. Rajesh instructs his office to initiate action for procuring these items. During the day, the dealing Assistant brings an estimate of Rupees Thirty Five Lakhs covering all stationery items from the same vendor. It is noticed that as per delegated financial powers, as provided in the GFR (General Financial Rules) as applicable in that Organisation, expenditure for office items exceeding Rupees Thirty Lakhs requires sanction of the next higher authority (boss in the present case). Rajesh knows that immediate superior would expect all these purchases should be done at his level, and may not appreciate such lack of initiative on his part. During discussions with office, he learns that common practice of splitting of expenditure (where large order is divided into a series of smaller ones) is followed to avoid obtaining sanction from higher authority. This practice is against the rules and may come to the adverse notice of Audit. Rajesh is perturbed. He is unsure of taking decision in the matter."

- What are the options available with Rajesh in the above situation?
- What are the ethical issues involved in this case?
- Which would be the most appropriate option for Rajesh and why??

[UPSC 2025, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: services delivery

[Case Study 5] "Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Program, MGNREGA was earlier known as National Rural Employment Scheme, NREGA. It is an Indian Social Welfare Program that aimed at fulfilling the 'Right to Work' provisions made in the Constitution. MGNREGA was launched in 2006 under Rural Employment Sector by the Ministry of Rural Development. Main objective of the program is to give legal guarantee of wage employment to the adult members of rural households who are willing to do unskilled manual labour work subject to a maximum of 100 days per year for every household. Every rural household has the right to register under the scheme, job card is issued to the registered, Job Card holder can seek employment. State government shall pay 25% of minimum wage for the first 30 days as compensatory daily unemployment allowance to the families and of wage for remaining period of the year. MGNREGA work was undertaken by various



Gram Panchayats. You have been appointed as an Administrator Incharge of the District. You have been given the responsibility of monitoring MGNREGA work undertaken by various Gram Panchayats. You are also given the authority to give technical sanctions to all MGNREGA works. In one of the Panchayats in your jurisdiction, you notice that your predecessor has mismanaged the Program in terms of:

- (i) Money not disbursed to actual job-seekers.
- (ii) Muster Rolls of the Labourers not properly maintained.
- (iii) Mismatch between the work done and payments made.
- (iv) Payments made to fictitious persons.
- (v) Job Cards were given without looking into the need of person.
- (vi) Mismanagement of funds & to the extent of siphoning of funds.
- (vii) Approved works that never existed.

- (a) What is your reaction to the above situation and how do you restore the proper functioning of MGNREGA Program in this regard?
- (b) What actions would you initiate to solve the various issues listed above?
- (c) How would you deal with the above situation? ?

[UPSC 2025,20 Marks] Syllabus: 8. Probity in Governance | Theme: Corruption

[Case Study 6] "Ashok is Divisional Commissioner of one of the border districts of the North East State. A few years back, Military has taken over the neighbouring country after overthrowing the elected civil government. Civil law situation is prevailing in the country especially in last two years. However, internal situation further deteriorated due to rebel groups taking over control of certain populated areas near own border. Due to intense fight between military and rebel groups, civilian casualties has increased manifold in recent past. In the meantime, in one night Ashok, got 200-250 people, mainly women and children by laying cross over to our side of the border. There are also about 10 children with their weapons in military uniform part of this group who wants to cross over. Women and children are also crying and begging for help. A few of them are injured and bleeding profusely need immediate medical care. Ashok tried to contact Home Secretary of the State but failed to do so due to poor connectivity mainly due to inclement weather."

- (a) What are the options available with Ashok to cope with the situation?
- (b) What are the ethical and legal dilemmas being faced by Ashok?
- (c) Which of the options, do you think would be more appropriate for Ashok to adopt and why?
- (d) In the present situation, what are the extra precautionary measures to be taken by the Border Guarding Police in dealing with soldiers in uniform? ?

[UPSC 2025,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Refugee and Ethics



UPSC MAINS 2024

[Case Study 1] “There is a technological company named ABC Incorporated which is the second largest worldwide, situated in the Third World. You are the Executive Officer and the majority shareholder this company. The fast technological improvements have raised worries among environmental activists, regulatory authorities, and the general public over the sustainability of this scenario. You confront substantial issues about the business’s environmental footprint. In 2023, your organization had a significant increase of 48% in greenhouse gas emissions compared to the levels recorded in 2019. The significant rise in energy consumption is mainly due to the surging energy requirements of your data centers, fuelled by the exponential expansion of Artificial Intelligence (AI). AI-powered services need much more computational resources and electrical energy compared to conventional online activities, notwithstanding their notable gains. The technology’s proliferation has led to a growing concern over the environmental repercussions, resulting in an increase in warnings. AI models, especially those used in extensive machine learning and data processing, exhibit much greater energy consumption than conventional computer tasks, with an exponential increase.

Although there is already a commitment and goal to achieve net zero emissions by 2030, the challenge of lowering emissions seems overwhelming as the integration of AI continues to increase. To achieve this goal, substantial investments in renewable energy use would be necessary. The difficulty is exacerbated by the competitive environment of the technology sector, where rapid innovation is essential for preserving market standing and shareholders worth. To achieve a balance between innovation, profitability and sustainability, a strategic move is necessary that is in line with both, business objectives and ethical obligations

- What is your immediate response to the challenges posed in the above case?
- Discuss the ethical issues involved in the above case.
- Your company has been identified to be penalized by technological giants. What logical and ethical arguments will you put forth to convince about its necessity?
- Being a conscience being, what measures would you adopt to maintain balance between AI innovation and environmental footprint?”

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Syllabus - corporate governance. Sub-subject - Environment vs Technology

[Case Study 2] “Raman is a senior IPS officer and has recently been posted as D.G. of a state. Among the various issues and problems/challenges which needed his immediate attention, the issue relating to recruitment of unemployed youth by an unknown terrorist group, was a matter at grave concern.

It was noted that unemployment was relatively high in the state. The problem of unemployment amongst graduates and those with higher education was much more grave. Thus they were vulnerable and soft targets. In the review meeting taken by him with senior officers of DIG Range and above, it came to light that a new terrorist group has emerged at the global level. It has launched a massive drive to recruit young unemployed people. Special focus was to pick young people from & particular com-

munity. The said organisation seemed to have the clear objective of utinsing/using them for carrying out militant activities. It was also gathered that the said (new) group is desperately trying to spread its tentacles in his state. A definite/reliable intelligence tip was received by the State CD and Cyber Cell that a large number of such unemployed youth have already been contacted by the terrorist outfit/group through social media and local communal organisations and other contacts. The need of the hour was to act swiftly and to check these elements/designs before they assume serious proportions.

Discrete inquiries made by the police, through the Cyber Cell revealed that good numbers of unemployed youth are very active on Facebook, Instagram and Twitter.

On an average, many of them were spending, 8 hours each day, using electronic devices/internet, etc. It also came to light that such unemployed youth were showing sympathy and endorsing the messages received from certain persons, allegedly the contact persons of that global terrorist group. Their social media accounts revealed their strong affinity such groups in as much as many of them started forwarding anti-national tweets on their WhatsApp and Facebook, etc. It seemed that they succumbed to their ploy and started propagating secessionist ideology. Their posts were hyper-critical of the government’s initiatives, policies and subscribing to extreme beliefs and promoting extremism.

- What are the options available to Raman to tackle the above situation?
- What measures would you suggest for strengthening the existing set-up to ensure that such groups do not succeed in penetrating and vitiating the atmosphere in the state?
- In the above scenario, what action plan would you advise for enhancing, the intelligence gathering mechanism of the police force?”

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Syllabus - Public Service Values

[Case Study 3] “With multipronged strategy of the Central and State Governments specially in the last few years, the naxalite problem has been resolved to a large extent in the affected states of the country. However, there are a few Volpockets in certain states where naxalite problem still persists, mainly due to involvement of foreign countries. Rohit is posted as SP (Special Operations) for the last one year, in one of the districts which is still affected by the naxalite problem. The district administration has taken a lot of developmental works in the recent past in the naxalite affected areas to win the hearts and minds of the people. Over a period of time, Rohit has established an excellent intelligence network to get the real time information regarding the movement of naxalite cadre. To instill confidence in the public and have moral ascendancy over the naxalites, a number of cordons and search operations are being conducted by the police. Rohit, who himself was leading one of the contingents got a message through his intelligence source that about ten hard core naxalites were hiding in a particular village with sophisticated weapons.



Without wasting any time, Rohit reached the target village with his team and laid out a foolproof cordon and started carrying out a systematic search. During the search, his team managed to overpower all the naxalites along with their automatic weapons. However, in the meantime, more than five hundred tribal women surrounded the village and started marching towards the target house.

They were shouting and demanding the immediate release of insurgents since they are their protectors and saviours. The situation on the ground was becoming very critical as the tribal women were extremely agitated and aggressive. Rohit tried to contact his superior officer, IG (Special Operations) of the state on the radio set and on mobile phone, but failed to do so due to poor connectivity.

Rohit was in great dilemma since out of the naxalites apprehended, two were not only hard core top insurgents with prize money of 7 ten lakhs on their heads, but were also involved in a recent ambush on the security forces. However, if he did not release the naxalites, the situation could get out of control since the tribal women were aggressively charging towards them. In that case, to control the situation Rohit might have to resort to firing which may lead to valuable loss of lives of civilians and would further complicate the situation.

- What are the options available with Rohit to cope with the situation?
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by Rohit?
- Which of the options, do you think, would be more appropriate for Rohit to adopt and why?
- In the present situation, what are the extra precautionary measures to be taken by the police in dealing with women protesters?

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Syllabus - Public Service Values

[Case Study 4] "Sneha is a Senior Manager working for a big reputed hospital chain in a mid-sized city. She has been made in charge of the new super specialty center that the hospital is building with state-of-the-art equipment and world-class medical facilities. The building has been reconstructed and she is starting the process of procurement for various equipment and machine. As the head of the committee responsible for procurement, she has invited bids from all the interested reputed vendors dealing in medical equipment. She notices that her brother, who is a well-known supplier of this domain, has sent his expression of interest. Since the hospital privately not

mandatory for her to select only the lower bidder. Also, she is aware that her brother's company has been facing some financial difficulties and a big supply order will help him recover. At the same time, allocating the contract to her brother might bring charges of favouritism against her and tarnish her image.

The hospital management trusts her fully and would support any decision of hers.

- What should be Sneha's course of action?
- How would she justify what she chooses to do?
- In this case, how is medical ethics compromised with vested personal interest?

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Corporate Governance. Subsubject - Conflict of Interest

[Case Study 5] "With the summer heat being exceptionally severe this year, the district has been facing severe water shortage. The District Collector has been mobilizing his subordinate officials to conserve the remaining water reserves for preventing the district from plunging into acute drinking water crisis.

Along with an awareness campaign for conserving water, strict measures have been taken for stopping the over-exploitation of ground-water. Vigilance teams have been deployed to tour the villages and find the farmers who are drawing water from deep borewells or from the river reservoir for irrigation. The farmers are agitated by such action. A delegation of farmers meets the District Collector with their issues and complains that while they are not being allowed to irrigate their crops, big industries located near the river are drawing huge amounts of water through deep borewells for their industrial processes. The farmers allege that their administration is anti-farmer and corrupt, being bribed by the industry. The district needs to placate the farmers as they are threatening to go on a prolonged protest. At the same time, the District Collector has to deal with the water crisis. The industry cannot be closed as this would result in a large number of workers being unemployed.

- Discuss all options available to the District Collector as a District Magistrate.
- What suitable actions can be taken in view of mutually compatible interests of the stakeholders?
- What are the potential administrative and ethical dilemmas for the District Collector?

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Public Service Values. Subsubject - Resource management

[Case Study 6] "Dr. Srinivasan is a senior scientist working for a reputed biotechnology company known for its cutting-edge research in pharmaceuticals. Dr. Srinivasan is heading a research team, working on a new drug aimed at treating a rapidly spreading variant of a new viral infectious disease. The disease has been rapidly spreading across the world and the cases reported in the country are increasing. There is huge pressure on Dr. Srinivasan's team to expedite the trials for the drug as there is significant market for it, and the company wants to get the first-mover advantage in the market. During a team meeting, some senior team members suggest some shortcut for expediting the clinical trials for the drug and for getting the requisite approvals. These include manipulating data to exclude some negative outcomes and selectively reporting positive results, foregoing the process of informed consent and using compounds already patented by a rival company, rather than developing one's own component. Dr. Srinivasan is not comfortable taking such shortcuts, at the same time he realises meeting the targets is impossible without using these means.

- What would you do in such a situation?
- Examine your options and consequences in the light of the ethical questions involved.
- How can data ethics and drug ethics save humanity at large in such a scenario?

[UPSC 2024, 20 Marks] Syllabus - Ethics and Human Interface (Bioethics)



UPSC MAINS 2023

[Case Study 1] “At 9 pm on Saturday evening, Rashika, a Joint Secretary, was still engrossed in her work in her office. Her husband, Vikram, is an executive in an MNC and frequently out of town in connection with his work. Their two children aged 5 and 3 are looked after by their domestic helper. At 9:30 pm her superior, Mr. Suresh calls her and asks her to prepare a detailed note on an important matter to be discussed in a meeting in the Ministry. She realises, that she will have to work on Sunday to finish the additional task given by her superior.

She reflects on how she had looked forward to this posting and had worked long hours for months to achieve it. She had kept the welfare of people uppermost in discharging her duties. She feels that she has not done enough justice to her family and she has not fulfilled her duties in discharging essential social obligations. Even as recently as last month she had to leave her sick child in the nanny's care as she had to work in the office. Now, she feels that she must draw a line, beyond which her personal life should take precedence over her professional responsibilities. She thinks that there should be reasonable limits to the work ethics such as punctuality, hard work, dedication to duty and selfless service.

- (a) Discuss the ethical issues involved in this case.
- (b) Briefly describe at least four laws that have been enacted by the Government with respect to providing a healthy, safe and equitable working environment for women.
- (c) Imagine you are in a similar situation. What suggestions would you make to mitigate such working conditions?”

[UPSC 2023, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface
| Theme: profession vs personal duty

[Case Study 2] “You have just been appointed as Additional Director General of Central Public Works Department. The Chief Architect of your division, who is to retire in six months, is passionately working on a very important project, the successful completion of which would earn him a lasting reputation for the rest of his life.

A new lady architect. Seema, trained at Manchester School of Architecture, UK joined as Senior Architect in your division. During the briefing about the project, Seema made some suggestions which would not only add value to the project, but would also reduce completion time. This has made the Chief Architect insecure and he is constantly worried that all the credit will go to her. Subsequently, he adopted a passive and aggressive behaviour towards her and has become disrespectful to her. Seema felt it embarrassing as the Chief Architect left no chance of humiliating her. He would very often correct her in front of other colleagues and raise his voice while speaking to her. This continuous harassment has resulted in her losing confidence and self-esteem. She felt perpetually tensed, anxious and stressed. She appeared to be in awe of him since he has had a long tenure in the office and has vast experience in the area of her work.

You are aware of her outstanding academic credentials and career record in her previous organisations. However, you fear that this harassment may result in compromising her much

needed contribution in this important project and may adversely impact her emotional well-being. You have also come to know from her peers that she is contemplating tendering her resignation.

- (a) What are the ethical issues involved in the above case?
- (b) What are the options available to you in order to complete the project as well as to retain Seema in the organization?
- (c) What would be your response to Seema's predicament? What measures would you institute to prevent such occurrences from happening in your organization ?”

[UPSC 2023, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values
Theme: Gender equality based

[Case Study 3] “You hold a responsible position in a ministry in the government. One day in the morning you received a call from the school of your 11-year-old son that you are required to come and meet the Principal. You proceed to the school and find your son in the Principal's office. The Principal informs you that your son had been found wandering aimlessly in the grounds during the time classes were in progress. The class teacher further informs you that your son has lately become a loner and did not respond to questions in the class, he had also been unable to perform well in the football trials held recently. You bring your son back from the school and in the evening, you along with your wife try to find out the reasons for your son's changed behaviour. After repeated cajoling, your son shares that some children had been making fun of him in the class as well as in the WhatsApp group of the students by calling him stunted, duh and a frog. He tells you the names of a few children who are the main culprits but pleads with you to let the matter rest.

After a few days, during a sporting event, where you and your wife have gone to watch your son play, one of your colleague's son shows you a video in which students have caricatured your son. Further, he also points out to the perpetrators who were sitting in the stands. You purposefully walk past them with your son and go home. Next day, you find on social media, a video denigrating you, your son and even your wife, stating that you engaged in physical bullying of children on the sports field. The video became viral on social media. Your friends and colleagues began calling you to find out the details. One of your juniors advised you to make a counter video giving the background and explaining that nothing had happened on the field. You, in turn posted a video which you have captured during the sporting event, identifying the likely perpetrators who were responsible for your son's predicament. You have also narrated what has actually happened in the field and made attempts to bring out the adverse effects of the misuse of social media.

- (a) Based on the above case study, discuss the ethical issues involved in the use of social media.
- (b) Discuss the pros and cons of using social media by you to put across the facts to counter the fake propaganda against your family.”

[UPSC 2023, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values
Theme: Social media



[Case Study 4] “A landslide occurred in the middle of the night on 20th July, 2023 in a remote mountain hamlet, approximately 60kilometers from Uttarkashi. The landslide was caused by torrential rains and has resulted in large-scale destruction of property and life. You, as district magistrate of the area, have rushed to the spot with a team of doctors, NGOs, media and police along with numerous support staff to oversee the rescue operations.

A man came running to you with a request for urgent medical help for his pregnant wife who is in labor and is losing blood. You directed your medical team to examine his wife. They return and convey to you that this woman needs blood transfusion immediately. Upon enquiry, you come know that a few blood collection bags and blood group test kits are available in the ambulance accompanying your team. Few people of your team have already volunteered to donate blood.

Being a physician who has graduated from AIIMS, you know that blood for transfusion needs to be procured only through a recognized blood bank.

Your team members are divided on this issue; some favor transfusion while some others oppose it. The doctors in the team are ready to facilitate the delivery provided they are not penalized for transfusion. Now you are in a dilemma. Your professional training emphasizes on prioritizing service to humanity and saving lives of individuals.

(a) What are the ethical issues involved in this case?

(b) Evaluate the options available to you, being District Magistrate of the area.”

[UPSC 2023,20 Marks] Syllabus: 5. Emotional Intelligence | Theme: Compassion vs Duty

[Case Study 5] “You are working as an executive in a nationalized bank for several years. One day one of your close colleagues tells you that her father is suffering from heart disease and needs surgery immediately to survive. She also tells you that she has no insurance and the operation will cost about Rs. 10 lakh. You are also aware of the fact that her husband is no more and that she is from a lower middle class family. You are empathetic about her situation. However, apart from expressing your sympathy, you do not have the resources to fund her.

A few weeks later, you ask her about the well-being of her father and she informs you about his successful surgery and that he is recovering. She then confides in you that the bank manager was kind enough to facilitate the release of Rs. 10 lakh from a dormant account of someone to pay for the operation with a promise that it should be confidential and be repaid at

the earliest. She has already started paying it back and will continue to do so until it is all returned.

(a) What are the ethical issues involved ?

(b) Evaluate the behavior of the bank manager from an ethical point of view.

(c) How would you react to the situation ?”

[UPSC 2023,20 Marks] Syllabus: 8. Probity in Governance | Theme: Misuse of position of power

[Case Study 6] “Vinod is an honest and sincere IAS officer. Recently, he has taken over as Managing Director of the State Road Transport Corporation, his sixth transfer in the past three years. His peers acknowledge his vast knowledge, affability and uprightness.

The Chairman of the State Road Transport Corporation is a powerful politician and is very close to the Chief Minister. Vinod comes to know about many alleged irregularities of the Corporation and the high-handedness of the Chairman in financial matters.

A Board Member of the Corporation belonging to the Opposition Party meets Vinod and hands over a few documents along with a video recording in which the Chairman appears to be demanding bribe for placing a huge order for the supply of QMR tyres. Vinod recollects the Chairman expediting clearing of pending bills of QMR tyres.

Vinod confronts the Board Member as to why he is shying away from exposing the Chairman with the so-called solid proof he has with him. The member informs him that the Chairman refuses to yield to his threats. He adds that Vinod may earn recognition and public support if he himself exposes the Chairman. Further, he tells Vinod that once his party comes to power, Vinod's professional growth would be assured.

Vinod is aware that he may be penalized if he exposes the Chairman and may further be transferred to a distant place. He knows that the Opposition Party stands a better chance of coming to power in the forthcoming elections. However, he also realizes that the Board Member is trying to use him for his own political gains.

(a) As a conscientious civil servant, evaluate the options available to Vinod.

(b) In the light of the above case, comment upon the ethical issues that may arise due to the politicization of bureaucracy.”

[UPSC 2023,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption



UPSC MAINS 2022

[Case Study 1] “Prabhat was working as Vice President (Marketing) at Sterling Electric Ltd., a reputed multinational company. But presently the company was passing through the difficult times as the sales were continuously showing downward trend in the last two quarters. His division, which hitherto had been a major revenue contributor to the company’s financial health, was now desperately trying to procure some big government order for them. But their best efforts did not yield any positive success or breakthrough.

His was a professional company and his local bosses were under pressure from their London-based HO to show some positive results. In the last performance review meeting taken by the Executive Director (India Head), he was reprimanded for his poor performance. He assured them that his division is working on a special contract from the Ministry of Defence for a secret installation near Gwalior and tender is being submitted shortly.

He was under extreme pressure and he was deeply perturbed. What aggravated the situation further was a warning from the top that if the deal is not clinched in favour of the company, his division might have to be closed and he may have to quit his lucrative job.

There was another dimension which was causing him deep mental torture and agony. This pertained to his personal precarious financial health. He was a single earner in the family with two school-college going children and his old ailing mother. The heavy expenditure on education and medical was causing a big strain to his monthly pay packet. Regular EMI for housing loan taken from bank unavoidable and any default would render him liable for severe legal action.

In the above backdrop, he was hoping for some miracle to happen. There was sudden turn of events. His Secretary informed that a gentleman Subhas Verma wanted to see him as he was interested in the position of Manager which was to be filled by him in the company. He further brought to his notice that his CV has been received through the office of the Minister of Defence.

During interview of the candidate-Subhash Verma, he found him technically sound, resourceful and experienced marketer. He seemed to be well-versed with tendering procedures and having knack of follow-up and liaising in this regard Prabhat felt that he was better choice than the rest of the candidates who were recently interviewed by him in the last few days.

Subhash Verma also indicated that he was in possession of the copies of the bid documents that the Unique Electronics Ltd. would be submitting the next day to the Defence Ministry for their tender. He offered to hand over those documents subject to his employment in the company on suitable terms and conditions. He made it clear that in the process, the Sterling Electric Ltd. could outbid their rival company and get the bid and hefty Defence Ministry order. He indicated that it will be win-win situation for both-him and the company.

Prabhat was absolutely stunned. It was a mixed feeling of shock and thrill. He was uncomfortable and perspiring. If accepted, all his problems would vanish instantly and he may be rewarded for securing the much awaited tender and thereby boosting company’s sales and financial health. He was in a fix as to the future course of action. He was wonder-struck at the

guts of Subhash Verma in having surreptitiously removing his own company papers and offering to the rival company for a job. Being an experienced person, he was examining the pros and cons of the proposal/situation and he asked him to come the next day.

(a) Discuss the ethical issues involved in the case.

(b) Critically examine the options available to Prabhat in the above situation.

(c) Which of the above would be the most appropriate for Prabhat and why?

[UPSC 2022, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Misuse of position of power

[Case Study 2] “You are appointed as an officer heading the section in Environment Pollution Control Board to ensure compliance and its follow-up. In that region, there were large number of small and medium industries which had been granted clearance. You learnt that these industries provide employment to many migrant worker. Most of the industrial units have got environmental clearance certificate in their possession. The environmental clearance seeks to curb industries and projects that supposedly hamper environment and living species in the region, But in practice, most of these units remain to be polluting units in several ways like air, water and soil pollution. As such, local people encountered persistent health problems.

It was confirmed that majority of the industries were violating environmental compliance. You issued notice to all the industrial units to apply for fresh environmental clearance certificate from the competent authority. However, your action met with hostile response from a section of the industrial units, other vested interest persons and a section of the local politicians. The workers also became hostile to you as they felt that your action would lead to the closure of these industrial units, and the resultant unemployment will lead to insecurity uncertainty in their livelihood. Many owners of the industries approached you with the plea that you should not initiate harsh action as it would compel them their units, and cause huge financial loss, shortage of their products in the market. These would obviously add to the sufferings of the labourers and the consumers alike. The labour union also sent you representation requesting against the closure of the units. You simultaneously started receiving threats from unknown corners. You however received supports from some of your colleagues, who advised you to act freely to ensure environmental compliance. Local NGOs also came to your support and they demanded the closure of the polluting units immediately.

(a) What are the options available to you under the given situation?

(b) Critically examine the options listed by you.

(c) What type of mechanism would you suggest to ensure environmental compliance?

(d) What are the ethical dilemmas you faced in exercising your option?”

[UPSC 2022, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Environmental ethics



[Case Study 3] "Rakesh was working as a Joint Commissioner in Transport department of a city. As a part of his job profile, among others, he was entrusted with the task of overseeing the control and functioning of City Transport Department. A case strike by drivers' union of City Transport Department over the issue of compensation to a driver who died on duty while driving the bus came up before him for decision in the matter.

He gathered that the driver (deceased) was plying Bus No. 528 which passed through busy and congested roads of the city. It so happened that near an intersection on the way, there was an accident involving the a middle-aged man. It was found that there was altercation between the driver and the car driver. Heated arguments between them led to fight and the driver gave him a a blow. Lot of passerbys had gathered and tried to intervene but without success. Eventually, both of them were badly injured and profusely bleeding and were taken to the nearby hospital. The driver succumbed to the injuries and could not be saved. The middle-aged driver's condition was also critical but after a day, he recovered and was discharged. Police had immediately come to the spot and FIR was registered. Police investigation revealed that the quarrel in was started by the bus driver and he had resorted to physical violence. There exchange of blows between them.

The City Transport Department management is considering of not giving any extra compensation to the driver's (deceased) family. The family is very aggrieved. depressed and agitated against the discriminatory and non-sympathetic approach of the City Transport Department management. The bus driver (deceased) was 52 years of age, was survived by his wife and two school-college going daughters. He was the sole earner of the family. The City Transport Department workers' union took up this case and when found no favourable response from the management, decided to go on strike. The union's demand was two fold. First was full extra compensation as given to other drivers who died on duty and secondly employment to one family member. The strike has continued for 10 days and the deadlock remains.

- What are the options available to Rakesh to meet the above situation?
- Critically examine each of the options identified by Rakesh
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by Rakesh?
- What course of action would Rakesh adopt to diffuse the above situation?"

[UPSC 2022, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Compassion vs duty

[Case Study 4] "Ramesh is State Civil Services Officer who got the opportunity of getting posted to the capital of a border State after rendering 20 years of service. Ramesh's mother has recently been detected cancer and has been admitted in the leading cancer hospital of the city. His two adolescent children have also got admission in one of the best public schools of the town. After settling down in his appointment as Director in the Home Department of the State, Ramesh got confidential report through intelligence sources that illegal migrants are infiltrating in the State from the neighbouring country. He decided to personally carry out surprise check of the border posts along with his Home Department team. To his surprise, he caught

red-handed two families of 12 members infiltrated with the connivance of the security personnel at the border posts. On further inquiry and investigation, it was found that after the migrants from neighbouring country infiltrate, their documentation like Aadhaar Card, Ration Card and Voter Card are also forged and they are made to settle down in a particular area of the State. Ramesh prepared the detailed and comprehensive report and submitted to the Additional Secretary of the State. However, he has summoned by the Additional Home Secretary after a week and was instructed to withdraw the report. The Additional Home Secretary informed Ramesh that the report submitted by him has not been appreciated by the higher authorities. He further cautioned him that if he fails to withdraw the confidential ort, he will not only be posted out from the prestigious appointment from the State capital but his further promotion which is due in near future will also get in jeopardy.

- What are the options available to Ramesh as the Director of the Home Department of the bordering State?
- What option should Ramesh adopt and why?
- Critically evaluate each of the options.
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by Ramesh?
- What policy measures would you suggest to combat the menace of infiltration of illegal migrants from the neighbouring country?"

[UPSC 2022, 20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: National security issue

[Case Study 5] "The Supreme Court has banned mining in the Aravalli Hills to stop degradation the forest cover and to maintain ecological balance. However, the stone mining to still prevalent in the border district of the affected State with connivance of certain corrupt forest officials and politicians. Young and dynamic SP who was recently posted in the affected district promised to himself to stop this menace. In one of his surprise checks with his team, he found loaded truck with stone trying to escape the mining area. He tried to stop the truck but the truck driver overrun the police officer, killing him on the spot and thereafter managed to flee. Police filed FIR but no breakthrough was achieved in the case for almost three months. Ashok who was the Investigative Journalist working with leading TV channel, suo moto started investigating the case. Within one month, Ashok got breakthrough by interacting with local people, stone mining masia and government officials. He prepared his investigative story and presented to the CMD of the TV channel. He exposed in his investigative report the complete nexus of stone mafia working with blessing of corrupt police and civil officials and politicians. The politician who was involved in the mafia was no one else but local MLA who was considered to be very close to the Chief Minister. After going through the investigative report, the CMD advised Ashok to drop the idea of making the story public through electronic media. He informed that the local MLA was not only the relative of the owner of the TV channel but also had unofficially 20 percent share in the channel. The CMD further informed Ashok that his further promotion and hike in pay will be taken care of in addition the soft loan of 10 lakhs which he has taken from the TV channel for his son's chronic disease will be suitably adjusted if he hands over the



investigative report to him.

- What are the options available with Ashok to cope up with the situation?
- Critically evaluate/examine each of the options identified by Ashok.
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by Ashok?
- Which of the options, do you think, would be the most appropriate for Ashok to adopt and why?
- In the above scenario, what type of training would you suggest for police officers posted to such districts where stone mining illegal activities are rampant?"

[UPSC 2022,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: Investigative journalism

[Case Study 6] "You have done MBA from a reputed institution three years back but could not get campus placement due to COVID-19 generated recession. However, after a lot of persuasion and series of competitive tests including written and interview, you managed to get a job in a leading shoe company. You have ageing parents who are dependent and staying with you. You also recently got married after getting this decent job. You were allotted the Inspection Section which is responsible for clearing the final product. In first one year, you learnt your job well and was appreciated for your performance by the management. The company is doing good business for last five years in domestic market and this year it is decided even to export to Europe and Gulf countries. However, one large consignment

to Europe was rejected by their Inspecting Team due to certain poor quality and was sent back. The top management ordered that the consignment to be cleared for the domestic market. As a part of Inspecting Team, you observed the glaring poor quality and brought to the knowledge of the Team Commander. However, the top management advised all the members of the team to overlook these defects as the management cannot bear such a huge loss. Rest of the team members except you promptly signed and cleared the consignment for domestic market, overlooking glaring defects. You again brought to the knowledge of the Team Commander that such consignment, if cleared even for domestic market, will tarnish the image and reputation of the company and will be counter-productive in the long run. However, you were further advised by the top management that if you do not clear the consignment, the company will not hesitate to terminate your services citing certain innocuous reasons.

- Under the given conditions, what are the options available to you as a member of the Inspecting Team?
- Critically evaluate each of the options listed by you.
- What option would you adopt and why?
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by you?
- What can be the consequences of overlooking the observations raised by the Inspecting Team?"

[UPSC 2022,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption

UPSC MAINS 2021

[Case Study 1] Pawan is working as an officer in the State Government for the last ten years. As a part of the routine transfer, he was posted to another department. He joined a new office along with five other colleagues. The head of the office was a senior officer conversant with the functioning of the office. As a part of general inquiry, Pawan gathered that his senior officer carries the reputation of being a difficult and insensitive person having his own disturbed family life. Initially, all seem to go well. However, after some time Pawan felt that the senior officer was belittling him and at times unreasonable. Whatever suggestions given or views expressed by Pawan in the meetings were summarily rejected and the senior officer would express displeasure in the presence of others. It became a pattern of the boss's style of functioning to show him in bad light highlighting his shortcomings and humiliating him publicly. It became apparent that though there are no serious work-related problems/shortcomings, the senior officer was always on one pretext or the other and would scold and shout at him. The continuous harassment and public criticism of Pawan resulted in the loss of confidence, self-esteem and equanimity. Pawan realized that his relations with his senior officer are becoming more toxic and due to this, he perpetually tensed, anxious and stressed. His mind was occupied with negativity and caused him

mental torture, anguish and agony. Eventually, it badly affected his personal and family life. He was no longer joyous, happy and contented even at home. Rather without any reason, he would lose his temper with his wife and other family members. The family environment was no longer pleasant and congenial. His wife who was always supportive of him also became a victim of his negativity and hostile behaviour. Due to harassment and humiliation suffering by him in the office, comfort and happiness virtually vanished from his life. Thus, it damaged his physical and mental health.

- What are the options available with Pawan to cope up with the situation?
- What approach Pawan should adopt for bringing peace, tranquillity and a congenial environment in the office and home?
- As an outsider, what are your suggestions for both boss and subordinate to overcome this situation and for improving the work performance, mental and emotional hygiene?
- In the above scenario, what type of training would you suggest for officers at various levels in the government offices?"

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Toxic Boss



[Case Study 2] You are Vice Principal of a degree college in one of the middle-class towns. The principal has recently retired and management is looking for his replacement. There are also feelers that the management may promote you as Principal. In the meantime, during the annual examination, the flying squad which came from the university caught two students red-handed involving in unfair means. A senior lecturer of the college was personally helping these students in this act. This senior lecturer also happens to be close to the management. One of the students was the son of a local politician who was responsible for getting college affiliated to the present reputed university. The second student was the son of a local businessman who has donated maximum funds for running the college. You immediately informed the management regarding this unfortunate incident. The management told you to resolve the issue with the flying squad at any cost. They further said that such an incident will not only tarnish the image of the college but also the politician and the businessman are very important personalities for the functioning of the college. You were also given hint that your further promotion to Principal depends on your capability in resolving this issue with the flying squad. In the meantime, you were intimidated by your administrative officer that certain members of the student union are protesting outside the college gate against the senior lecturer and the students involved in this incident are demanding strict action against defaulters.

- Discuss the ethical issue involved in the case.
- Critically examine the options available with you as Vice Principal. What option will you adopt and why?"

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 5. Emotional Intelligence | Theme: Vice Principal vs College exam cheaters

[Case Study 3] The coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic has quickly spread to various countries. As of May 8th, 2020, in India 56342 positive cases of corona had been reported. India with a population of more than 1.35 billion had difficulty in controlling the transmission of coronavirus among its population. Multiple strategies became necessary to handle this outbreak. The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare of India raised awareness about this outbreak and to take all necessary actions to control the spread of COVID -19. Indian Government implemented a 55-day lockdown throughout the country to reduce the transmission of the virus. Schools and colleges had shifted to alternative modes of teaching-learning-evaluation and certification. Online mode became popular during these days.

India was not prepared for a sudden onslaught of such a crisis due to limited infrastructure in terms of human resources, money and other facilities needed for taking care of this situation. This disease did not spare anybody irrespective of caste, creed, religion on one hand and 'have and have not' on the other. Deficiencies in hospital beds, oxygen cylinders, ambulances, hospital staff and crematorium were the most crucial aspects.

You are a hospital administrator in a public hospital at the time when coronavirus had attacked a large number of people and patients were pouring into the hospital day in and day out.

- What are your criteria and justification for putting your clinical and non-clinical staff to attend to the patients knowing fully well that it is a highly infectious disease and resources and infrastructure are limited?

- If yours is a private hospital, whether your jurisdiction and decision would remain the same as that of a public hospital?"

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 5. Emotional Intelligence | Theme: Disaster management

[Case Study 4] An elevated corridor is being constructed to reduce traffic congestion in the capital of a particular state. You have been selected as project manager of this prestigious project on your professional competence and experience. The deadline is to complete the project in the next two years by 30 June 2021, since the project is to be inaugurated by the Chief Minister before the elections are announced in the second week of July 2021. While carrying out the surprise inspection by the inspecting team, a minor crack was noticed in one of the piers of the elevated corridor possibly due to poor material used. You immediately informed the chief engineer and stopped further work. It was assessed by you that a minimum of three piers of the elevated corridor have to be demolished and reconstructed. But this process will delay the project minimum by four to six months. But the chief engineer overruled the observation of the inspecting team on the ground that it was a minor crack that will not in any way impact the strength and durability of the bridge. He ordered you to overlook the observation of the inspecting team and continue working with the same speed and tempo. He informed you that the minister does not want any delay as he wants the Chief Minister to inaugurate the elevated corridor before the elections are declared. Also informed you that the contractor is a far relative of the minister and he wants him to finish the project. He also gave you a hint that your further promotion as an additional chief engineer is under consideration by the ministry. However, you strongly felt that the minor crack in the pier in the elevated corridor will adversely affect the health and life of the bridge and therefore it will be very dangerous not to repair the elevated corridor.

- Under the given conditions, what are the options available to you as a project manager?
- What are the ethical dilemmas being faced by the project manager and his response to overcome such challenges?
- What are the professional challenges likely to be faced by the project manager and his response to overcome such challenges?
- What can be the consequences of overlooking the observation raised by the inspecting team?"

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Engineer vs Poor quality Bridge completion before election

[Case Study 5] Sunil is a young civil servant and has a reputation for his competence, integrity, dedication and relentlessness in pursuit of difficult and onerous jobs. Considering his profile, he was picked up by his bosses to handle a very challenging and sensitive assignment. He was posted in a tribal-dominated district notorious for illegal sand mining. Excavating sand from river belts and transporting it through trucks and selling them in the black market was rampant. This illegal sand mining mafia was operating with the support of local functionaries and tribal musclemen who in turn were bribing selected poor tribals and



had kept the tribals under fear and intimidation.

Sunil being a sharp and energetic officer immediately grasped the ground realities and the modus operandi followed by the mafia through their devious and dubious mechanism. On making inquiries, he gathered that some of their own office employees are in hand and glove with them and have developed close unholy nexus. Sunil initiated stringent action against them and started conducting raids on their illegal operations of the movement of trucks filled with sand. The mafia got rattled as not many officers in the past had taken such strong steps against the mafia. Some of the office employees who were allegedly close to the mafia informed them that the officer is determined to clean up the mafia's illegal sand mining operations in that district and may cause them irreparable damage.

The mafia turned hostile and launched a counter-offensive. The tribal musclemen and mafia started threatening him with dire consequences. His family (wife and old mother) were stalked and were under virtual surveillance and thus causing mental torture, agony and stress to all of them. The matter assumed serious proportions when a musclemen came to his office and threatened him to stop raids etc., otherwise, his fate will not be different than some of his predecessors (ten years back one officer was killed by the mafia)

- Identify the different options available to Sunil in attending this situation
- Critically evaluate each of the options listed by you.
- Which of the above, do you think, would be most appropriate for Sunil to adopt and why?"

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: Corruption : IAS vs Mining Mafia

[Case Study 6] A reputed food product company based in India developed a food product for the international market and started exporting the same after getting necessary approvals. The company announced this achievement and also indicated that soon the product will be made available for domestic consumers with almost the same quality and health benefits.

Accordingly, the company got its product approved by the domestic competent authority and launched the product in the Indian market. The company could increase its market share over a period of time and earned substantial profit both domestically and internationally. However, the random sample test conducted by the inspecting team found the product being sold domestically in variance with the approval obtained from the competent authority.

On further investigation, it was also discovered that the food company was not only selling products that were not meeting the health standard of the country but also selling the rejected export products in the domestic market. This episode adversely affected the reputation and profitability of the food company.

- What action do you visualize should be taken by the competent authority against the food company for violating the laid down domestic food standard and selling rejected export products in the domestic market?
- What course of action is available with the food company to resolve the crisis and bring back its lost reputation?
- Examine the ethical dilemma involved in the case."

[UPSC 2021,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: Lack of compliance

UPSC MAINS 2020

[Case Study 1] Rampura, a remote district inhabited by a tribal population, is marked by extreme backwardness and abject poverty. Agriculture is the mainstay of the local population, though it is subsistence due to the very small landholdings. There is insignificant industrial or mining activity. Even the targeted welfare programs have inadequately benefited the tribal population. In this restrictive scenario, the youth has begun to migrate to other states to supplement the family income. Plight of minor girls is that their parents are persuaded by labour contractors to send them to work in the Bt Cotton farms of a nearby state. The soft fingers of the minor girls are well suited for plucking the cotton. The inadequate living and working conditions in these farms have caused serious health issues for the minor girls. NGOs in the districts of domicile and the cotton farms appear to be compromised and have not effectively espoused the twin issues of child labour and development of the area.

You are appointed as the District Collector of Rampura. Identify the ethical issues involved. Which specific steps will you initiate to ameliorate the conditions of minor girls of your district and to improve the overall economic scenario in the district?"

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values | Theme: child labour

[Case Study 2] Migrant workers have always remained at the socio-economic margins of our society, silently serving as the instrumental labour force of urban economics. The pandemic has brought them into national focus.

On announcement of a countrywide lockdown, a very large number of migrant workers decided to move back from their places of employment to their native villages. The non-availability of transport created its own problems. Added to this was the fear of starvation and inconvenience to their families. This caused, the migrant workers to demand wages and transport facilities for returning to their villages. Their mental agony was accentuated by multiple factors such as a sudden loss of livelihood, possibility of lack of food and inability to assist in harvesting their rabi crop due to not being able to reach home in time. Reports of inadequate response of some districts in providing the essential boarding and lodging arrangements along the way multiplied their fears.

You have learnt many lessons from this situation when you were tasked to oversee the functioning of the District Disaster Relief Force in your district. In your opinion what ethical issues arose in the current migrant crisis? What do you understand by an ethical care giving state? What assistance can the civil



society render to mitigate the sufferings of migrants in similar situations?

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 5. Emotional Intelligence | Theme: Compassion in disaster

[Case Study 3] Parmal is a small but underdeveloped district. It has a rocky terrain that is not suitable for agriculture, though some subsistence agriculture is being done on small plots of land. The area receives adequate rainfall and has an irrigation canal flowing through it. Amaria, its administrative centre, is a medium-sized town. It houses a large district hospital, an Industrial Training Institute and some privately owned skill training centres. It has all the facilities of a district headquarters. A trunk railway line passes approximately 50 kilometers from Amaria. Its poor connectivity is a major reason for the absence of any major industry therein. The state government offers a 10 year tax holiday as an incentive to new industry.

In 2010 Anil, an industrialist decided to take benefits to set up Amaria Plastic Works (APW) in Noora village, about 20km from Amaria. While the factory was being built, Anil hired the required key labour and got them trained at the skill training centres at Amria. This act of his made the key personnel very loyal to APW.

APW started production in 2011 with the labour drawn fully from Noora village. The villagers were very happy to get employment near their homes and were motivated by the key personnel to meet the production targets with high quality. APW started making large profits, a sizeable portion of which was used to improve the quality of life in Noora. By 2016, Noora could boast of a greener village and a renovated village temple. Anil liaised with the local MLA to increase the frequency of the bus services to Amria. The government also opened a primary health care centre and primary school at Noora in buildings constructed by APW. APW used its CSR funds to set up women's self-help groups, subsidize primary education to the village children and procure an ambulance for use by its employed and the needy.

In 2019, there was a minor fire in APW. It was quickly extinguished as fire safety protocols were in place in the factory. Investigations revealed that the factory had been using electricity in excess of its authorized capacity. This was soon rectified. The next year, due to nationwide lockdown, the requirement of production fell for four months. Anil decided that all employees would be paid regularly. He employed them to plant trees and improve the village habitat.

APW had developed a reputation of high-quality production and a motivated workforce.

Critically analyse the story of APW and state the ethical issues involved. Do you consider APW as a role model for the development of backward areas? Give reasons.

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: corporate governance: CSR Funding

[Case Study 4] The Chairman of Bharat Missiles Ltd (BML) was watching a program on TV wherein the Prime Minister was addressing the nation on the necessity of developing a self-reli-

ant India. He subconsciously nodded in agreement and smiled to himself as he mentally reviewed BML's journey in the past two decades. BML had admirably progressed from producing first-generation anti-tank guided missiles (ATGMs) to designing and producing state of the art ATGM weapon systems that would be the envy of any army. He sighed in reconciliation with his assumptions that the government would probably not alter the status quo of a ban on the export of military weaponry.

To his surprise, the very next day he got a telephone call from the Director-General, Ministry of Defence, asking him to discuss the modalities of increasing BML production of ATGMs as there is a probability of exporting the same to a friendly country. The Director-General wanted the Chairman to discuss the details with his staff in Delhi next week.

Two days later, at a press conference, the Defence Minister stated that he aims to double the current weapons export levels within five years. This would give an impetus to financing the development and manufacturing of indigenous weapons in the country. He also stated that all indigenous arms manufacturing nations have a very good record of the international arms trade. As the Chairman of BML, what are your views on the following points?

1. As an arms exporter of a responsible nation like India, what are the ethical issues involved in arms trade?
2. List five ethical factors that would influence the decision to sell arms to foreign governments.

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: International relations

[Case Study 5] Rajesh Kumar is a senior public servant, with a reputation of honesty and forthrightness, currently posted in the Finance Ministry as the Head of the Budget Division. His department is presently busy in organizing the budgetary support to the states, four of which are due to the polls within the financial year.

This year's annual budget had allotted Rs 8300 crores for the National Housing Scheme (NHS), a centrally sponsored social housing scheme for the weaker sections of society. Rs 775 crores have been drawn for NHS till June.

The Ministry of Commerce had long been pursuing a case for setting up a Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in a southern state to boost exports. After two years of detailed discussion between the center and state, the Union Cabinet approved the project in August. The process was initiated to acquire the necessary land. Eighteen months ago a leading Public Sector Unit (PSU) had projected the need for setting up a large natural gas processing plant in a northern state for the regional gas grid. The land is already in possession of the PSU. The gas grid is an essential component of the national energy security strategy. After three rounds of global bidding, the project was allotted to an MNC, M/s XYZ Hydrocarbons. The first tranche of payment to the MNC is scheduled to be made in December.

Finance Ministry was asked for a timely allocation of an additional Rs 6000 crores for these two developmental projects. It was decided to recommend re-appropriation of this entire amount from NHS allocation. The file was forwarded to the Budget Department for their comments and further processing.



On studying the case file, Rajesh Kumar realized that this re-appropriation may cause an inordinate delay in the execution of NHS, a project much publicized in the rallies of senior politicians. Correspondingly, the non-availability of finances would cause a financial loss in the SEZ and national embarrassment due to delayed payment in the international project.

Rajesh Kumar discussed the matter with seniors. He was conveyed that this politically sensitive situation needs to be processed immediately. Rajesh Kumar realized that diversion of funds from the NHS could raise difficult questions for the government in the Parliament.

Discuss the following with reference to this case:

1. Ethical issues involved in re-appropriation of funds from a welfare project to the development projects.
2. Given the need for proper utilization of public funds, discuss the options available to Rajesh Kumar. Is resigning a worthy option?

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: fund allocation

[Case Study 6] You are a municipal commissioner of a large city, having the reputation of a very honest and upright officer. A huge multipurpose mall is under construction in your city in which a large number of daily wage earners are employed. One night, during monsoons, a big chunk of the roof collapsed causing instant death of four labourers including two minors. Many more were seriously injured requiring immediate medical

attention. The mishap resulted in a big hue and cry, forcing the government to institute an enquiry.

Your preliminary enquiry has revealed a series of anomalies. The material used for the construction was of poor quality. Despite the approved building plans permitting only one basement, an additional basement has been constructed. This was overlooked during the periodic inspections by the building inspector of the municipal corporation. In your enquiry, you noticed that the construction of the mall was given the green signal despite encroaching on areas earmarked for a green belt and a slip road in the Zonal Master Plan of the city. The permission to construct the mall was accorded by the previous Municipal Commissioner who is not only your senior and well known to you professionally, but also a good friend.

Prima facie, the case appears to be of a widespread nexus between officials of the Municipal Corporation and the builders. Your colleagues are putting pressure on you to go slow in the enquiry. The builder, who is rich and influential, happens to be a close relative of a powerful minister in the state cabinet. The builder is persuading you to hush up the matter, promising you a fortune to do so. He also hinted that if this matter is not resolved at the earliest in his favour there is somebody in his office who is waiting to file a case against you under the POSH act.

Discuss the ethical issues involved in the case. What are the options available to you in this situation? Explain your selected course of action.

[UPSC 2020,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: Corruption

UPSC MAINS 2019

[Case Study 1] In recent times, there has been an increasing concern in India to develop effective civil service ethics, code of conduct, transparency measures, ethics and integrity systems and anti-corruption agencies. In view of this, there is a need being felt to focus on three specific areas, which are directly relevant to the problems of internalizing integrity and ethics in the civil services. These are as follows:

1. Anticipating specific threats to ethical standards and integrity in the civil services,
 2. Strengthening the ethical competence of civil servant and
 3. Developing administrative processes and practices which promote ethical values and integrity in civil services.
- Suggest institutional measures to address the above three issues.

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Ethics in Civil Services

[Case Study 2] An apparel manufacturing company having a large number of women employees was losing sales due to various factors. The company hired a reputed marketing executive, who increased the volume of sales within a short span of time. However, some unconfirmed reports came up regarding his indulgence in sexual harassment at the workplace.

After sometime a women employee launched a formal complaint to the management against the marketing executive about sexually harassing her. Faced with the companies' indifference, in not taking cognizance of her grievances, she lodged an FIR with the police.

Realizing the sensitivity and gravity of the situation, the company called the women employee to negotiate. In that she was offered a hefty sum of money to withdraw the complaint and the FIR and also give in writing that the marketing executive is not involved in the case.

Identify the ethical issues involved in this case. What options are available to the women employee?

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: gender equality based

[Case Study 3] In one of the districts of a frontier state, narcotics menace has been rampant. This has resulted in money laundering, mushrooming of poppy farming, arms smuggling and near stalling of education. The system is on the verge of collapse. The situation has been further worsened by unconfirmed reports that local politicians, as well as some senior police officers, are providing surreptitious patronage to the drug mafia. At that point of time a woman police officer, known for her skills



in handling such situations is appointed as superintendent of police to bring the situation to normalcy.

If you are the same police officer, identify the various dimensions of the crisis. Based on your understanding, suggest measures to deal with the crisis.

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: IPS Officer vs Drug Mafia

[Case Study 4] Honesty and uprightness are the hallmarks of a civil servant. Civil servants possessing these qualities are considered as the backbone of any strong organisation. In line of duty, they take various decisions, at times some become bonafide mistakes. As long as such decisions are not taken intentionally and do not benefit personally, the officer cannot be said to be guilty. Though such decisions may, at times, lead to unforeseen adverse consequences in the long-term.

In the recent past, a few instances have surfaced wherein civil servants have been implicated for bonafide mistakes. They have often been prosecuted and even imprisoned. These instances have greatly rattled the moral fibre of the civil servants.

How does this trend affect the functioning of the civil services? What measures can be taken to ensure that honest civil servants are not implicated for bonafide mistakes on their part? Justify your answer.

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Civil Servants implicated for Bonafide Mistakes

[Case Study 5] You are the heading the rescue operations in an area affected by severe natural calamity, thousands of people are rendered homeless and deprived of food, drinking water and other basic amenities. Rescue work has been disrupted by heavy rainfall and damaged to supply routes. The local people are seeding with anger against the delayed limited rescue operations.

When your team reaches the affected area, the people there heckle and even assault some of the team members. One of your team members is even severely injured. Faced with this crisis some team member pleads with you to call off the operations freeing threats to their life.

In such trying circumstances, what will be your response? Examine the qualities of a public servant which will be required to manage the situations.

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 5. Emotional Intelligence | Theme: Disaster relief

[Case Study 6] In a modern democratic polity, there is a concept of the political executive and permanent executive elected people's representatives forms the political executive and bureaucracy form the permanent executive. Ministers frame policy decisions and bureaucrats execute these. In the initial decades after independence, the relationship between the permanent executives and the political executives were characterized by mutual understanding, respect, and cooperation, without encroaching upon each other's domain.

However, in subsequent decades, the situation has changed. There are instances of the political executive insisting upon the permanent executives to follow its agenda. Respect for an appreciation of upright bureaucrats has declined. There is an increasing tendency among the political executive to get involved in routine administrative matters such as transfers, posting etc. Under this scenario, there is a definitive trend towards 'politicization of bureaucracy'. The rising materialism and acquisitiveness in social life has also adversely impacted upon the ethical values of both the permanent executive and the political executive.

What are the consequences of this 'politicization of bureaucracy'? Discuss.

[UPSC 2019,20 Marks] Syllabus: 8. Probity in Governance | Theme: politicization of bureaucracy

UPSC MAINS 2018

[Case Study 1] A big corporate house is engaged in manufacturing industrial chemicals on a large scale. It proposes to set upon the additional unit. Many states rejected its proposal due to the detrimental effect on the environment. But one state government acceded to the request and permitted the unit close to a city, brushing aside all opposition. The unit was set up 10 years ago and was in full swing till recently. The pollution caused by the industrial effluents was affecting the land, water and crops in the area. It was also causing serious health problems to human beings and animals. This gave rise to a series of agitation thousands of people took part, creating a law and order problem necessitating stern police action. Following the public outcry, the State government ordered the closure of the factory. The closure of the factory resulted in the unemployment of not only those workers who were engaged in the factory but also those who were working in the ancillary units. It also very badly

affected those industry which depended on the chemicals manufactured by it. As a senior officer entrusted with the responsibility of handling this issues, how are you going to address it?

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Environmental ethics

[Case Study 2] It is a State where prohibition is in force. You are recently appointed as the Superintendent of Police of a district notorious for illicit distillation of liquor. The illicit liquor leads to many death, reported and unreported, and causes a major problem for the district authorities. The approach till now had been to view it as a law and order problem and tackle it accordingly. Raids, arrest, police cases, and criminal trials – all these had only limited impact. The problem remains as serious as ever. Your inspections show that the parts of the district where



the distillation flourishes are economically, industrially and educationally backward. Agriculture is badly affected by poor irrigation facilities. Frequent clashes among communities gave boost to illicit distillation. No major initiatives had taken place in the past either from the government's side or from social organizations to improve the lot of the people. Which new approach will you adopt to bring the problem under control?"

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 3. Attitude | Theme: Enforcing liquor prohibition in backward area

[Case Study 3] Dr X is a leading medical practitioner in a city. He has set up a charitable trust through which he plans to establish a super-speciality hospital in the city to cater to the medical needs of all sections of the society. Incidentally, that part of the State had been neglected over the years. The proposed hospital would be a boon for the region. You are heading the tax investigation agency of that region. During an inspection of the doctor's clinic, your officers have found out some major irregularities. A few of them are substantial which had resulted in considerable withholding of tax that should be paid by him now. The doctor is cooperative. He undertakes to pay the tax immediately. However, there are certain other deficiencies in his tax compliance which are purely technical in nature. If these technical defaults are pursued by the agency, considerable time and energy of the doctor will be diverted to issues which are not so serious, urgent or even helpful to the tax collection process. Further, in all probability, it will hamper the prospects of the hospital coming up. There are two options before you:

1. Taking a broader view, ensure substantial tax compliance and ignore defaults that are merely technical in nature.
2. Pursue the matter strictly and proceed on all fronts, whether substantial or merely technical.

As the head of the tax agency, which course of action will you opt and why?

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: officer's compassion

[Case Study 4] Rakesh is a responsible district level officer, who enjoys the trust of his higher officials. Knowing his honesty, the government entrusted him with the responsibility of identifying the beneficiaries under a health care scheme meant for senior citizens. The criteria to be a beneficiary are the following:

1. 60 years of age or above.
2. Belonging to a reserved community.
3. Family income of less than 1 Lakh rupees per annum.
4. Post-treatment prognosis is likely to be high to make a positive difference to the quality of life of the beneficiary.

One day, an old couple visited Rakesh's office with their application. They have been the residents of a village in his district since their birth. The old man is diagnosed with a rare condition that causes obstruction in the large intestine. As a consequence, he has severe abdominal pain frequently that prevents him from doing any physical labour. The couple has no children to support them. The expert surgeon whom they contacted is willing to do the surgery without charging any fee. However, the couple will have to bear the cost of incidental charges, such as medicines, hospitalization, etc., to the tune of rupees one lakh. The couple

fulfils all the criteria except criterion 'b'. However, any financial aid would certainly make a significant difference in their quality of life. How should Rakesh respond to the situation?

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: services delivery

[Case Study 5] As a senior officer in the Ministry, you have access to important policy decisions and upcoming big announcements such as road constructions projects before they are notified in the public domain. The Ministry is about to announce a mega road project for which the drawings are already in place. Sufficient care was taken by the planners to make use of the government land with the minimum land acquisition from private parties. Compensation rate for private parties was also finalized as per government rules. Care was also taken to minimize deforestation. Once the project is announced, it is expected that there will be a huge spurt in real estate prices in and around that area. Meanwhile, the Minister concerned insists that you realign the road in such a way that it comes closer to his 20 acres farmhouse. He also suggests that he would facilitate the purchase of a big plot of land in your wife name at the prevailing rate which is very nominal, in and around the proposed mega road project. He also tries to convince you by saying that there is no harm in it as he is buying the land legally. He even promises to supplement your savings in case you do not have sufficient funds to buy the land. However, by the act of realignment, a lot of agricultural lands has to be acquired, thereby causing a considerable financial burden on the government, and also the displacement of the farmers. As if this is not enough, it will involve cutting down of a large number of trees denuding the area of its green cover. Faced with this situation, what will you do? Critically examine various conflicts of interest and explain what your responsibilities are as a public servant."

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Political pressure

[Case Study 6] Edward Snowden, a computer expert and former CIA administrator, released confidential Government documents to the press about the existence of Government surveillance programmes. According to many legal experts and the US Government, his action violated the Espionage act of 1971, which identified the leak of State secret as an act of treason. Yet, despite the fact that he broke the law, Snowden argued that he had a moral obligation to act. He gave a justification for his "whistle blowing" by stating that he had a duty "to inform the public as to that which is done in their name and that which is done against them." According to Snowden, the Government's violation of privacy had to be exposed regardless of legality since more substantive issues of social action and public morality were involved here. Many agreed with Snowden. Few argued that he broke the law and compromised national security, for which he should be held accountable.

Do you agree that Snowden's actions were ethically justified even if legally prohibited? Why or why not? Make an argument by weighing the competing values in this case.

[UPSC 2018,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: whistleblowing



UPSC MAINS 2017

[Case Study 1] You are aspiring to become an IAS officer and you have cleared various stages and now you have been selected for the personal interview. On the day of the interview, on the way to the venue you saw an accident where a mother and child who happen to be your relatives were badly injured. They needed immediate help. What would you have done in such a situation? Justify your action.

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Self interest vs right to life

[Case Study 2] You are the manager of a spare parts company A and you have to negotiate a deal with the manager of a large manufacturing company B. The deal is highly competitive and sealing the deal is critical for your company. The deal is being worked out over a dinner. After dinner the manager of manufacturing company B offered to drop you to the hotel in his car. On the way to hotel he happens to hit motorcycle injuring the motorcyclist badly. You know the manager was driving fast and thus lost control. The law enforcement officer comes to investigate the issue and you are the sole eyewitness to it. Knowing the strict laws pertaining to road accidents you are aware that your honest account of the incident would lead to the prosecution of the manager and as a consequence the deal is likely to be jeopardised, which is of immense importance to your company. What are the dilemmas you face? What will be your response to the situation?

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Integrity

[Case Study 3] You are the head of the Human Resources department of an organisation. One day one of the workers died on duty. His family was demanding compensation. However, the company denied compensation because it was revealed in investigation that he was drunk at the time of the accident. The workers of the company went to strike demanding compensation for the family of the deceased. The Chairman of the management board has asked for your recommendation. What recommendation would you provide the management? Discuss the merits and demerits of each of the recommendations.

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Compassion vs duty

[Case Study 4] A building permitted for three floors, while being extended illegally to 6 floors by a builder, collapses. As a consequence, a number of innocent labourers including women and

children died. These labourers are migrants of different places. The government immediately announced cash relief to the aggrieved families and arrested the builder. Give reasons for such incidents taking place across the country. Suggest measures to prevent their occurrence.

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Duty vs illegal building (compassion)

[Case Study 5] You are an honest and responsible civil servant. You often observe the following:

1. There is a general perception that adhering to ethical conduct one may face difficulties to oneself and cause problems for the family, whereas unfair practices may help to reach the career goals.
2. When the number of people adopting unfair means is large, a small minority having a penchant towards ethical means makes no difference.
3. Sticking to ethical means is detrimental to the larger developmental goals
4. While one may not involve oneself in large unethical practices, but giving and accepting small gifts makes the system more efficient.

Examine the above statements with their merits and demerits.

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: Integrity: Opinion as honest officer

[Case Study 6] You are a Public Information Officer (PIO) in a government department. You are aware that the RTI Act 2005 envisages transparency and accountability in administration. The act has functioned as a check on the supposedly arbitrarily administrative behaviour and actions. However, as a PIO you have observed that there are citizens who filed RTI applications not for themselves but on behalf of such stakeholders who purportedly want to have access to information to further their own interests. At the same time there are these RTI activists who routinely file RTI applications and attempt to extort money from the decision makers. This type of RTI activism has affected the functioning of the administration adversely and also possibly jeopardises the genuineness of the applications which are essentially aimed at getting justice. What measures would you suggest to separate genuine and non-genuine applications? Give merits and demerits of your suggestions.

[UPSC 2017,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: RTI



UPSC MAINS 2016

[Case Study 1] You are a young, aspiring and sincere employee in a Government office working as an assistant, to the director of your department. Since you've joined recently, you need to learn and progress. Luckily your superior is very kind and ready to train you for your job. He is a very intelligent and well-informed person having knowledge of various departments. In short, you respect your book and are looking forward to learn a lot from him.

Since you've good tuning with the boss, he started depending on you. One day due to ill health he invited you at his place for finishing some urgent work. You reached his house and you heard shouting noises before you could ring the bell. You waited for a while. After entering, boss greeted you and explained the work. But you were constantly disturbed by the crying of a woman. At last, you inquired with the boss but his answer did not satisfy you. Next day, you were compelled to inquire further in the office and found out that his behavior is very bad at home with his wife. He also beat up his wife.

His wife is not well educated and is a simple woman in comparison to her husband. You see that though your boss is a nice person in the office, he is engaged in domestic violence at home. In such a situation, you are left with the following options. Analyse each option with its consequences.

1. Just ignore thinking about it because it is their personal matter.
2. Report the case to the appropriate authority.
3. Your own innovative approach towards the situation."

[UPSC 2016,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Gender equality

[Case Study 2] Land needed for mining, dams and other large-scale projects is acquired mostly from Adivasis, hill dwellers and rural communities. The displaced persons are paid monetary compensation as per the legal provisions. However, the payment is often tardy. In any case, it cannot sustain the displaced families for long. These people do not possess marketable skills to engage in some other occupation. They end up as low paid migrant labourers. Moreover, their living is destroyed. Thus, the benefits of traditional ways of community development go to industries, industrialists and urban communities whereas the costs are passed on to these poor helpless people. This unjust distribution of costs and benefits is unethical. Suppose you have been entrusted with the task of drafting a better compensation-cum-rehabilitation policy for such displaced persons, how would you approach the problem and what would be the main elements of your suggested policy?

[UPSC 2016,20 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values | Theme: Vulnerable sections

[Case Study 3] ABC Ltd. is a large transnational company having diversified business activities with a huge shareholder base. The company is continuously expanding and generating employment. The company, in its expansion and diversification programme, decides to establish a new plant at Vikaspuri, an area which is underdeveloped. The new plant is designed to use

energy efficient technology that will help the company to save production cost by 20%. The company's decision goes well with the Government policy of attracting investment to develop such underdeveloped regions. The Government has also announced tax holiday for five years for the companies that invest in underdeveloped areas. However, the new plant may bring chaos for the inhabitants of Vikaspuri region which is otherwise tranquil. The new plant may result in increased cost of living, aliens migrating to the region, disturbing the social and economic order. The company sensing the possible protest tried to educate the people of Vikaspuri region and public in general that how its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) policy would help overcome the likely difficulties of the residents of Vikaspuri region. In spite of this the protests begin and some of the residents decided to approach the judiciary as their plea before the Government did not yield any result.

- (a) Identify the issues involved in the case.
- (b) What can be suggested to satisfy Company's goal and to address the resident's concern.

[UPSC 2016,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Corporate governance

[Case Study 4] Suppose you are an officer in-charge of implementing a social service scheme to provide support to old and destitute women. An old and illiterate woman comes to you to avail the benefits of the scheme. However, she has no documents to show that she fulfils the eligibility criteria. But after meeting her and listening to her you feel that she certainly needs support. Your enquiries also show that she is really destitute and living in a pitiable condition. You are in a dilemma as to what to do. Putting her under the scheme without documents would clearly be violation of rules. But denying her the support would be cruel and inhuman.

1. Can you think of a rational way to resolve this dilemma?
2. Give your reasons for it.

[UPSC 2016,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Service delivery

[Case Study 5] Saraswati was a successful IT professional in USA. Moved by the patriotic sense of doing something for the country she returned to India. Together with some other like-minded friends, she formed an NGO to build a school for a poor rural community.

The objective of the school was to provide the best quality modern education at a nominal cost. She soon discovered that she has to seek permission from a number of Governments agencies. The rules and procedures were quite confusing and cumbersome. What frustrated her most was the delays, callous attitude of officials and constant demand of bribes. Her experience and the experience of many others like her has deterred people from taking up social service projects.

A measure of Government control over voluntary social work is necessary. But it should not be exercised in a coercive or



corrupt manner. What measures can you suggest to ensure that due control is exercised but well meaning, honest NGO efforts are not thwarted?

[UPSC 2016,25 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption

[Case Study 6] A fresh engineering graduate gets a job in a prestigious chemical industry. She likes the work. The salary is also good. However, after a few months accidentally discovers that a highly toxic waste is being secretly discharged into a river nearby. This is causing health problems to the villagers downstream who depend on the river for their water needs. She is perturbed and mentions her concern to her colleagues who have been with the company for longer periods. They advise

her to keep quite as anyone who mentions the topic is summarily dismissed. She cannot risk losing her job as she is the sole bread-winner for her family and has to support her ailing parents and siblings.

At first, she thinks that if her seniors are keeping quiet, why should she stick out her neck. But her conscience pricks her to do something to save the river and the people who depend upon it. At heart she feels that the advice of silence given by her friends is not correct though she cannot give reasons for it. She thinks you are a wise person and seeks your advice.

1. What arguments can you advance to show her that keeping quiet is not morally right?
2. What course of action would you advise her to adopt and why?"

[UPSC 2016,25 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: Whistle-blow

UPSC MAINS 2015

[Case Study 1] "Case-Study: To do Drug Research on non-profitable disease or not?"

One of the scientists working in the R & D laboratory of a major pharmaceutical company discovers that one of the company's best selling veterinary drugs, B has the potential to cure a currently incurable liver disease that is prevalent in tribal areas. However, developing a variant of the drug suitable for human beings entailed a lot of research and development having a huge expenditure to the extent of 50 crores rupees. It was unlikely that the company would recover the costs as the disease was rampant only in poverty-stricken area having very little market otherwise. If you were the CEO, then—

- (a) Identify the various actions that you could take;
- (b) Evaluate the pros and cons of each of your actions."

[UPSC 2015,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: professional ethics

[Case Study 2] A private company is known for its efficiency, transparency and employee welfare. The company though owned by a private individual has a cooperative character where employees feel a sense of ownership. The company employs nearly 700 personnel and they have voluntarily decided not to form a union.

One day suddenly in the morning, about 40 men belonging to a political party gatecrashed into the factory demanding jobs in the factory. They threatened the management and employees, and also used foul language. The employees feel demoralized. It was clear that those people who gate-crashed wanted to be on the payroll of the company as well as continue as the volunteers/members of the party. The company maintains high standards in integrity and does not extend favours to civil administration that also includes law enforcement agency. Such incidents occur in public sector also.

1. Assume you are the CEO of the company. What would you do to diffuse the volatile situation on the date of gate-crashing with the violent mob sitting inside the company premises?

2. What could be the long-term solution to the issue discussed in the case?

3. Every solution/action that you suggest will have a positive and a negative impact on you (as CEO), the employees and the performance of the employees. Analyze the consequences of each of your suggested actions."

[UPSC 2015,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Trade union issue

[Case Study 3] You are recently posted as district development officer of a district. Shortly thereafter you found that there is considerable tension in the rural areas of your district on the issue of sending girls to schools.

The elders of the village feel that many problems have come up because girls are being educated and they are stepping out of the safe environment of the household. They are of the view that the girls should be quickly married off with minimum education. The girls are also competing for jobs after education, which have traditionally remained in boys' exclusive domain, adding to unemployment amongst male population.

The younger generation feels that in the present era, girls should have equal opportunities for education and employment, and other means of livelihood. The entire locality is divided between the elders and the younger lot and further sub-divided between sexes in both generations. You come to know that in Panchayat or in other local bodies or even in busy cross-roads, the issue is being acrimoniously debated.

One day you are informed that an unpleasant incident has taken place. Some girls were molested, when they were en route to schools. The incident led to clashes between several groups and a law and order problem has arisen. The elders after heated discussion have taken a joint decision not to allow girls to go to school and to socially boycott all such families, which do not follow their dictate.

1. What steps would you take to ensure girls' safety without disrupting their education?



2. How would you manage and mould matriarchic attitude of the village elders to ensure harmony in the inter-generational relations?

[UPSC 2015,25 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values | Theme: gender equality

[Case Study 4] You are the Sarpanch of a Panchayat. There is a primary school run by the government in your area. Midday meals are provided to the children attending the school. The Headmaster has now appointed a new cook in the school to prepare the meals. However, when it is found that the cook is from Dalit community, almost half of the children belonging to higher castes are not allowed to take meals by their parents. Consequently the attendance in the school falls sharply. This could result in the possibility of discontinuation of midday meal scheme, thereafter of teaching staff and subsequent closing down the school.

1. Discuss some feasible strategies to overcome the conflict and to create right ambience.

2. What should be the responsibilities of different social segments and agencies to create positive social ambience for accepting such changes?"

[UPSC 2015,20 Marks] Syllabus: 6. Contributions of Moral Thinkers | Theme: Caste system

[Case Study 5] There is a disaster-prone State having frequent landslides, forest fires, cloudbursts, flash floods and earthquakes, etc. Some of these are seasonal and often unpredictable. The magnitude of the disaster is always unanticipated. During one of the seasons, a cloudburst caused devastating floods and landslides leading to high casualties.

There was major damage to infrastructure like roads, bridges and power generating units. This led to more than 100000 pilgrims, tourists and other locals trapped across different routes and locations. The people trapped in your area of responsibility included senior citizens, patients in hospitals, women and children, hikers, tourists, ruling party's regional president along with his family, additional jail. As secretary State and prisoners in jail. As a civil services officer of the State, what would be the order in which you would rescue these people and why? Give

justifications."

[UPSC 2015,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Disaster management

[Case Study 6] You are heading a district administration in a particular department. Your senior officer calls you from the State Headquarters and tells you that a plot in Rampur village is to have a building constructed on it for a school. A visit is scheduled during which he will visit the site along with the chief engineer and the senior architect. He wants you to check out all the papers relating to it and to ensure that the visit is properly arranged.

You examine the file which relates to the period before you joined the department. The land was acquired from the local Panchayat at a nominal cost and the papers show that clearance certificates are available from the two of the three authorities who have to certify the site's suitability. There is no certification by the architect available on file. You decide to visit Rampur to ensure that all is in order as stated on file. When you visit Rampur, you find that the plot under reference is part of Thakurgarh Fort and that the walls, ramparts, etc., are running across it. The fort is well away from the main village, therefore a school here will be a serious inconvenience for the children. However, the area near the village has potential to expand into a larger residential area.

The development charges on the existing plot, at the fort, will be very high and the question of heritage site has not been addressed. Moreover, the Sarpanch, at the time of acquisition of the land, was a relative of your predecessor. The whole transaction appears to have been done with some vested interest.

1. List the likely vested interests of the concerned parties.
2. Some of the options for action available to you are listed below. Discuss the merits and demerits of each of the options :

1. You can await the visit of the superior officer and let him take a decision.

2. You can seek his advice in writing or on phone.

3. You can consult your predecessor/colleagues, etc., and then decide what to do.

4. You can find out if any alternate plot can be got in exchange and then send a comprehensive written report.

Can you suggest any other option with proper justification?

[UPSC 2015,25 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption

UPSC MAINS 2014

[Case Study 1] Now-a-days, there is an increasing thrust on economic development all around the globe. At the same time, there is also an increasing concern about environmental degradation caused by development. Many a time, we face a direct conflict between developmental activity and environmental quality. It is neither feasible to stop or curtail the development process, nor it is advisable to keep degrading the environment,

as it threatens our very survival.

Discuss some feasible strategies which could be adopted to eliminate this conflict and which could lead to sustainable development.

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Environment degradation



[Case Study 2] Suppose one of your close friends, who is also aspiring for civil services, comes to you for discussing some of the issues related to ethical conduct in public service. He raises the following points :

1. In the present times, when unethical environment is quite prevalent, individual attempts to stick to ethical principles may cause a lot of problems in one's career. It may also cause hardship to the family members as well as risk to one's life. Why should we not be pragmatic and follow the path of least resistance, and be happy with doing whatever good we can?
2. When so many people are adopting wrong means and are grossly harming the system, what difference would it make if only a small minority tries to be ethical? They are going to be rather ineffective and are bound to get frustrated.
3. If we become fussy about ethical considerations, will it not hamper the economic progress of our country? After all, in the present age of high competition, we cannot afford to be left behind in the race of development.
4. It is understandable that we should not get involved in grossly unethical practices, but giving and accepting small gratifications and doing small favours increases everybody's motivation. It also makes the system more efficient. What is wrong in adopting such practices?

Critically analyze the above viewpoints. On the basis of this analysis, what will be your advice to your friend?

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: need of ethics

[Case Study 3] In our country, the migration of rural people to towns and cities is increasing drastically. This is causing serious problems both in the rural as well as in the urban areas. In fact, things are becoming really unmanageable. Can you analyze this problem in detail and indicate not only the socio-economic but also the emotional and attitudinal factors responsible for this problem? Also, distinctly bring out why—

1. Educated rural youth are trying to shift to urban areas;
2. Landless poor people are migrating to urban slums;
3. Even some farmers are selling off their land and trying to settle in urban areas taking up petty jobs.

What feasible steps can you suggest which will be effective in controlling this serious problem of our country?"

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 3. Attitude | Theme: attitude

[Case Study 4] Rameshwar successfully cleared the prestigious civil services examination and was excited about the opportunity that he would get through the civil services to serve the country. However, soon after joining the services, he realized that things are not as rosy as he had imagined.

He found a number of malpractices prevailing in the department assigned to him. For example, funds under various schemes and grants were being misappropriated. The official facilities were frequently being used for personal needs by the officers and staff. After some time, he noticed that the process of recruiting the staff was also not up to the mark. Prospective candidates were required to write an examination in which a lot of cheating was going on. Some candidates were provided external help in the examination. Rameshwar brought these incidents to the

notice of his seniors. However, he was advised to keep his eyes, ears and mouth shut and ignore all these things which were taking place with the connivance of the higher-ups. Rameshwar felt highly disillusioned and uncomfortable. He comes to you seeking your advice.

Indicate various options that you think are available in this situation. How would you help him to evaluate these options and choose the most appropriate path to be adopted?

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 4. Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Service | Theme: demotivation in civil services

[Case Study 5] You are a no-nonsense, honest officer. You have been transferred to a remote district to head a department that is notorious for its inefficiency and callousness. You find that the main cause of the poor state of affairs is the indiscipline of a section of employees. They do not work themselves and also disrupt the working of others. You first warned the troublemakers to mend their ways or else face disciplinary action. When the warning had little effect, you issued a show cause notice to the ringleaders. As a retaliatory measure, these troublemakers instigated a woman employee amongst them to file a complaint of sexual harassment against you with the Women's Commission. The Commission promptly seeks your explanation. The matter is also publicized in the media to embarrass you further. Some of the options to handle this situation could be as follows :

1. Give your explanation to the Commission and go soft on the disciplinary action.
2. Ignore the Commission and proceed firmly with the disciplinary action.
3. Brief your higher-ups, seek directions from them and act accordingly.

Suggest any other possible option(s). Evaluate all of them and suggest the best course of action, giving your reasons for it."

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Bogus rape complaint

[Case Study 6] Suppose you are the CEO of a company that manufactures specialized electronic equipment used by a government department. You have submitted your bid for the supply of this equipment to the department. Both the quality and cost of your offer are better than those of the competitors. Yet the concerned officer is demanding a hefty bribe for approving the tender. Getting the order is important both for you and for your company. Not getting the order would mean closing a production line. It may also affect your own career. However, as a value-conscious person, you do not want to give bribe.

Valid arguments can be advanced both for giving the bribe and getting the order, and for refusing to pay the bribe and risking the loss of the order. What those arguments could be? Could there be any better way to get out of this dilemma? If so outline the main elements of this third way, pointing out its merits.

[UPSC 2014,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: corruption



UPSC MAINS 2013

[Case Study 1] Sivakasi in Tamil Nadu is known for its manufacturing clusters on firecrackers and matches. The local economy of the area is largely dependent on firecrackers industry. It has led to tangible economic development and improved standard of living in the area.

So far as child labour norms for hazardous industries like firecrackers industry are concerned, International Labour Organization (ILO) has set the minimum age as 18 years. In India, however, this age is 14 years.

The units in industrial clusters of firecrackers can be classified into registered and non-registered entities. One typical unit is household-based work. Though the law is clear on the use of child labour employment norms in registered/non-registered units, it does not include household-based works. Household-based work means children working under the supervision of their parents/relatives. To evade child labour norms, several units project themselves as household-based works but employ children from outside. Needless to say that employing children saves the costs for these units leading to higher profits to the owners.

On your visit to one of the units at Sivakasi, the owner takes you around the unit which has about 10-15 children below 14 years of age. The owner tells you that in his household-based unit, the children are all his relatives. You notice that several children smirk, when the owner tells you this. On deeper enquiry, you figure out that neither the owner nor the children are able to satisfactorily establish their relationship with each other.

1. Bring out and discuss the ethical issues involved in the above case.
2. What would be your reaction after your above visit?"

[UPSC 2013,25 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Child Labourers

[Case Study 2] You are the Executive Director of an upcoming InfoTech Company which is making a name for itself in the market. Mr. A, who is a star performer, is heading the marketing team. In a short period of one year, he has helped in doubling the revenues as well as creating a high brand equity for the Company so much so that you are thinking of promoting him. However, you have been receiving information from many corners about his attitude towards the female colleagues; particularly his habit of making loose comments on women. In addition, he regularly sends indecent SMS's to all the team members including his female colleagues.

One day, late in the evening, Mrs. X, who is one of Mr. A's team members, comes to you visibly disturbed. She complains against the continued misconduct of Mr. A, who has been making undesirable advances towards her and has even tried to touch her inappropriately in his cabin. She tenders her resignation and leaves your office.

1. What are the options available to you?
2. Evaluate each of these options and choose the option you would adopt, giving reasons."

[UPSC 2013,20 Marks] Syllabus: 1. Ethics and Human Interface | Theme: Sexual Harassment

[Case Study 3] You are heading a leading technical institute of the country. The institute is planning to convene an interview panel shortly under your chairmanship for selection of the post of professors. A few days before the interview, you get a call from the Personal Secretary (PS) of a senior government functionary seeking your intervention in favour of the selection of a close relative of the functionary for this post. The PS also informs you that he is aware of the long pending and urgent proposals of your institute for grant of funds for modernization, which are awaiting the functionary's approval. He assures you that he would get these proposals cleared.

1. What are the options available to you?
2. Evaluate each of these options and choose the option which you would adopt, giving reasons."

[UPSC 2013,20 Marks] Syllabus: 2. Human Values | Theme: Favoritism

[Case Study 4] As a senior officer in the Finance Ministry, you have access to some confidential and crucial information about policy decisions that the Government is about to announce. These decisions are likely to have far-reaching impact on the housing and construction industry. If the builders have access to this information beforehand, they can make huge profits. One of the builders has done a lot of quality work for the Government and is known to be close to your immediate superior, who asks you to disclose this information to the said builder.

1. What are the options available to you?
2. Evaluate each of these options and choose the option which you would adopt, giving reasons."

[UPSC 2013,20 Marks] Syllabus: 7. Public/Civil Service Values and Ethics in Public Administration | Theme: Leaking information

[Case Study 5] You are working as an Executive Engineer in the construction cell of a Municipal Corporation and are presently in-charge of the construction of a flyover. There are two Junior Engineers under you who have the responsibility of day-to-day inspection of the site and are reporting to you, while you are finally reporting to the Chief Engineer who heads the cell. While the construction is heading towards completion, the Junior Engineers have been regularly reporting that all construction is taking place as per design specifications. However, in one of your surprise inspections, you have noticed some serious deviations and lacunae which, in your opinion, are likely to affect the safety of the flyover. Rectification of these lacunae at this stage would require a substantial amount of demolition and rework which will cause a tangible loss to the contractor and will also delay completion. There is a lot of public pressure on the Corporation to get this construction completed because of heavy traffic congestion in the area. When you brought this matter to the notice of the Chief Engineer, he advised you that in his opinion it is not a very serious lapse and may be ignored. He advised for further expediting the project for completion in time. However, you are convinced that this was a serious matter which might



affect public safety and should not be left unaddressed.

What will you do in such a situation? Some of the options are given below. Evaluate the merits and demerits of each of these options and finally suggest what course of action you would like to take, giving reasons.

1. Follow the advice of the Chief Engineer and go ahead.
2. Make an exhaustive report of the situation bringing out all facts and analysis along with your own viewpoints stated clearly and seek for written orders from the chief Engineer.
3. Call for explanation from the Junior Engineers and issue orders to the contractor for necessary correction within targeted time.
4. Highlight the issue so that it reaches superiors above the Chief Engineer.
5. Considering the rigid attitude of the Chief Engineer, seek transfer from the project or report sick."

[UPSC 2013,20 Marks] Syllabus: 8. Probity in Governance | Theme: project mismanagement

[Case Study 6] In the following questions, carefully study the cases presented and then answer the questions that follow:

A Public Information Officer has received an application under RTI Act. Having gathered the information, the PIO discovers that the information pertains to some of the decisions taken by him, which were found to be not altogether right. There were other employees also who party to these decisions were. Disclosure of the information is likely to lead to disciplinary action with

possibility of punishment against him as well as some of his colleagues. Non-disclosure or part disclosure or camouflaged disclosure of information will result into lesser punishment or no punishment.

The PIO is otherwise an honest and conscientious person but this particular decision, on which the RTI application has been filed, turned out to be wrong. He comes to you for advice.

The following are some suggested options. Please evaluate the merits and demerits of each of the options:

1. The PIO could refer the matter to his superior officer and seek his advice and act strictly in accordance with the advice, even though he is not completely in agreement with the advice of the superior.
2. The PIO could proceed on leave and leave the matter to be dealt by his successor in office or request for transfer of the application to another PIO.
3. The PIO could weigh the consequences of disclosing the information truthfully, including the effect on his career, and reply in a manner that would not place him or his career in jeopardy, but at the same time a little compromise can be made on the contents of the information.
4. The PIO could consult his other colleagues who are party to the decision and take action as per their advice.

Also please indicate (without necessarily restricting to the above options) what you would like to advise, giving proper reasons. "

[UPSC 2013,20 Marks] Syllabus: 9. Information Sharing and Transparency in Government | Theme: RTI: To hide or not to hide.



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